

J&K Police allege attack by Army inside station

MOHIT KANDHARI

Jammu

A Commanding Officer of the Rashtriya Rifles (RR) Unit stationed in the Kishtwar district of the Jammu division has been booked by the Jammu and Kashmir Police, along with over three dozen army personnel, for allegedly trespassing into the premises of Police Station Atholi and attacking policemen.

The attack allegedly took place shortly after a police party intercepted and seized a private vehicle owned by an Army official for traffic violations. According to the FIR, filed by the Station House Officer, Inspector Amrit Kotach, he received a call informing him about the assault within the premises of the police station under the direct instructions of Commanding Officer N Arun Gandhi of 17 RR, when he was away attending a meeting with the deputy commissioner.

The FIR names Colonel Gandhi, Major Sharma, Naib Subedar Gurkhe, Sepoys Raj Kumar, Rahul Kumar, Anoop Singh and Omkar Ingale, and unidentified Army personnel of the 17 RR camp as accused. It claims, around 30 to 40 personnel from 17 RR, Camp Kijayee, led by Major Vikash Sharma and Naib Subedar Shankar Gurkhe, launched an attack after scaling the main gate and boundary wall of the police station. They were armed with lathis, iron rods and other weapons, he added. "Their common intention was to cause fatal injuries and kill the police personnel on duty," he said, adding that he rushed back to the station and was allegedly physically assaulted by Major Sharma.

A Jammu-based Army PRO, Lt Col Suneel Barthwal, told *The Pioneer* that the matter is being probed.

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A J&K policeman stand guard next to an Army personnel during a Muharram procession in Srinagar

PTI

What makes an Indian citizen? Ministry of External Affairs draws a legal distinction

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

New Delhi

On Wednesday, an MEA official explained that the Indian passport is a "travel document," not a "citizenship document." While only Indian citizens can obtain a passport after verification, simply having one does not, on its own, prove citizenship.

This statement was made during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of voter rolls in several states, in which some people attempted to use passports to contest their exclusion from the rolls. This distinction is important because the Supreme Court has also said that Aadhaar is just an identity document, not proof of citizenship.

This difference is based on the law. The Passports Act, 1967, states that a passport's primary purpose is to facilitate international travel. It identifies the holder and asks foreign governments to allow safe passage. Section 6 generally bars non-citizens from obtaining a passport. Still, Section 20 permits the Central Government to issue a passport or travel document to a non-citizen if it serves the public interest.

A passport is not final proof of citizenship. It shows nationality for travel, but Indian citizenship is a separate legal status under the Citizenship Act, 1955 (as amended). Courts have said that no single document, including a passport, is enough by itself. In 2013, the Bombay High Court ruled that a passport, even with a birth certificate or Aadhaar, was not enough to prove citizenship for people born after July 1, 1987. They also need to show that at least one parent was an Indian citizen at the time of their birth.

Some key questions are: how carefully citizenship is checked before a passport is issued; whether the passport booklet is your property; when and why you must return it; what counts as proof of citizenship; and why this clarification is important now. Passport authorities review Aadhaar, PAN, birth records, school certificates, and they also carry out police verification with other government agencies.

However, this process only decides if you qualify for a travel document, not your citizenship. Past errors show why this is important. The passport says it is the "property of the Government of India." You can use and keep it, but the government owns and controls it. This is normal in most countries and shows that a passport is an official document, not your personal property.

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Representative image

ISTOCK

LG directs DDA to initiate revival of Sanjay Lake

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Thursday directed the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) to initiate a phased revival plan for Sanjay Lake in east Delhi. The lake, spread over 52 acres and surrounded by a 165-acre protected forest area, recently came under focus after hundreds of fish died due to disruption in the water supply.

“Visited Sanjay Lake in East Delhi to review the ongoing restoration and rejuvenation works. During the on-site inspection, officials from DDA briefed me on the phased action plan to revive this vital 52-acre waterbody and its surrounding 165-acre protected forest,” Sandhu said in a post on X. He added that

planting 5,000 native trees will enrich ecological biodiversity. “The upcoming phases will focus on channelising stagnant water, installing bioswales to improve groundwater recharge, undertaking bio-remediation measures and setting up aerators and fountains to improve dissolved oxygen levels,” the LG added.

During the on-site inspection, DDA officials led by its vice chairman briefed the LG on the phased action plan designed to revive this vital 52-acre manmade water body and its surrounding 165-acre protected forest.

The LG had earlier taken serious note of reports that brought out the lake’s pathetic condition due to the drying up of the water supply and accumulation of silt/garbage and sewage and directed the



DDA to undertake its rejuvenation in mission mode. The lake and adjoining park area are bounded by residential colonies of Kalyanpuri and Trilokpuri on the eastern side and Mayur Vihar, Phase II, on the western side. Strategically located along National Highway-24, it is a large, recognisable green lung in East Delhi.

Sandhu also said that several key initiatives are being undertaken to “transform this important blue-green asset into a resilient, all-weather, and pristine recreational space”. To further boost the environmental vitality of the area, the LG directed that the ecological biodiversity of the precinct be heavily enriched

through the strategic plantation of 5,000 native trees.

Initially planted with Eucalyptus in 1977-78 to improve poor soil conditions, the area now has better soil health. Eucalyptus, Neem, Arjun, Papri, Ashoka, Marorfali, Pilkhan, Chandni, Hibiscus, Hamelia, Kaner, Tecoma are the major plant species that exist at Sanjay Lake. He emphasised that these collective efforts will ensure the lake serves as a clean, vibrant, and ecologically rich public space, strengthening the capital’s environmental sustainability and resilience for generations to come. Taking note of the disrupted water supply to the lake, the LG directed the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) to expeditiously repair the pipeline operated by it. He emphasised that a steady supply of

treated water from the Dallupura Sewage Treatment Plant (STP) must be restored at the earliest to maintain the lake’s optimal water levels and ensure its survival as a resilient, all-weather blue-green asset.

“I directed the expedited repair of the pipeline operated by the Delhi Jal Board to ensure a steady supply of treated water from the Dallupura Sewage Treatment Plant.” In May, hundreds of fish were found dead in the lake after it dried up due to issues related to water supply from the Delhi Jal Board.

“Continuous de-weeding, algae removal, and the strengthening of embankment slopes using geo-textile technology are already underway to protect and rejuvenate the waterbody,” Sandhu added.

Govt to upgrade infra of 75 CM Shri schools



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi government’s Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC) will spend ₹265 crore to upgrade infrastructure at 75 CM Shri schools, including sports facilities, auditoriums and CCTV surveillance systems.

A proposal to this effect has been approved in the recent EFC meeting chaired by the chief minister Rekha Gupta. The meeting was attended by PWD Minister Parvash Sahib Singh, Education Minister Ashish Sood and senior officials of the concerned departments. The chief minister said that under the project, school entrance gates will be redesigned, upgraded and beautified in a modern style. They will display the new CM SHRI logo along with the name of the school.

According to the chief minister, the government’s objective is not merely to repair school buildings, but to create a learning environment where students have access to safe, clean, modern and inspiring campuses.

“The project will also address seepage and dampness in school buildings through waterproofing, carry out interior and exterior painting, repair plaster, construct or repair boundary

walls and fencing, upgrade toilets and drinking water facilities, improve sewerage and drainage systems, develop sports facilities wherever required, repair rain-water harvesting systems, renovate multipurpose halls, and undertake other repair works as needed,” she said.

The chief minister said that the electrical works will include fire safety measures. Defective LED lights, ceiling fans, exhaust fans and the PA (Public Address) system will be replaced to ensure effective dissemination of announcements and emergency information across the campus.

High-mast lighting will be installed in school premises. Multipurpose halls and computer laboratories will be equipped with air conditioning and stage lighting. LED signage and LED boards bearing the CM SHRI logo, in-built RO water coolers, upgraded main electrical panels, new wiring, rewiring, power points and LAN points will also be provided.

As part of priority works, child-friendly accessibility features for children with special needs, including ramps, tactile paths and handrails, will be developed. CCTV systems, compound lighting and sports grounds will also be upgraded.

Sirsa directs district magistrates to identify pollution hotspots

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Stepping up efforts to tackle pollution in the national Capital, Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa on Thursday directed the district magistrates to identify hotspots and submit periodic progress reports. He also ordered them to attend review meetings to monitor the implementation of action points and ensure time-bound outcomes.

These were some of the main takeaways from his comprehensive review meeting with all the district magistrates to formulate a coordinated district-level strategy for mitigating pollution and strengthening environmental governance across the Capital.

Addressing the officers, Sirsa said “Dust pollution remains one of the most significant contributors to Delhi’s deteriorating air quality. Every district magistrate must proactively identify sources of dust generation and work with all concerned departments to implement effective mitigation measures. Whether it is damaged roads, construction activity or poor maintenance, every source of dust must be



addressed through coordinated and result-oriented action.”

The meeting focused on identifying pollution hotspots, improving traffic management to reduce congestion, strengthening dust mitigation measures, removing encroachments, improving maintenance of public parks, monitoring polluting industries, and ensuring seamless coordination among all concerned departments.

NDMC confers Anupam Colony certification on Golf Links

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Thursday conferred the prestigious “Anupam Colony” certification on Golf Links, recognising the upscale residential neighbourhood for its exemplary waste management and sustainability practices.

NDMC Chairperson Keshav Chandra unveiled the certification plaque at Golf Links Colony, making it the ninth residential area to receive the distinction under the civic body’s Waste Management and Sustainability Initiative.

Addressing residents and officials at the event, Chandra said the recognition reflected the colony’s collective commitment to environmental responsibility and sustainable living. “Golf Links has set a remarkable



example of community-led waste management that can inspire other neighbourhoods across the city,” Chandra said, adding that such initiatives contribute to cleaner surroundings and help build environmentally conscious and self-sustaining communities.

He also acknowledged the role of voluntary organisations, NGOs and community groups that partnered with residents in achieving the milestone. Golf Links

Association president Ajay Mathur welcomed the certification, describing it as recognition of the residents’ efforts to transform the vision of a zero-waste colony into reality.

Highlighting the colony’s environmental initiatives, Golf Links Association Joint Secretary Namrata Khanna said residents had been actively promoting the principles of reduce, reuse and recycle through community-driven programmes.



यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण
प्रथम तल, कॉमर्शियल कॉम्प्लेक्स, ओमेगा-1, (पी-2), ग्रेटर नोएडा
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सार्वजनिक सूचना

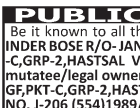
यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा ग्राम उटरावली सैक्टर 13, 15सी (45 मी० रोड) व ग्राम मुन्नागा सैक्टर-34 व ग्राम आकलपुर सैक्टर-09 व 10 के अन्तर्गत आने वाली भूमि का सुनियोजित विकास हेतु सम्बंधित कृकों द्वारा दी गयी सहमति की दर रु० 3808/- प्रतिवर्गमीटर से यमुना विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा शासनादेश संख्या 314/77-3-163एम, दिनांक 23.02.2016 में तय प्रक्रियानुसार निम्नानुसार क्रय किया जाना प्रस्तावित है:-

क्र० सं०	काश्तकार का नाम	खाता संख्या	खसरा संख्या	खसरे का क्षेत्रफल (हे० मे)	काश्तकार का माग	क्षेत्रफल (हे० मे)	हिस्सानुसार क्षेत्रफल (हे० मे)	अन्य विवरण
ग्राम उटरावली सैक्टर-13 व 15सी (45 मी० रोड)								
1.	सुरेश चन्द्र त्यागी पुत्र जगजीत उर्फ जगदीश नि० ग्राम	533	675	3.7490	मे से	0.7436	0.0210	0.7646
2.	ओमवती देवी पत्नी ओमप्रकाश सिंह व रोबिन सिंह, सुधीर, सुभाष पुनराग ओमप्रकाश सिंह निवासी आच्छेपुर।	43	151	0.2790	सम्पूर्ण मे से	0.2790	0.0032	0.2822
3.	धर्मपाल सिंह पुत्र मेवाराम निवासी चौकी झाझर तहसील बुलन्दशहर।	80	65	0.6960	मे से	0.0870	0.0438	0.1342
		422	82	0.5370		0.2650		
4.	कुसुमपाल सिंह पुत्र मेवाराम निवासी नियर मदरडेरी सैक्टर 46 नोएडा।	80	65	0.6960	मे से	0.0870	0.0437	0.1343
		79	81	0.1750		0.2650		
		422	82	0.5370		0.1342		0.2649
5.	रेशमपाल सिंह पुत्र मेवाराम निवासी चौकी झाझर तहसील बुलन्दशहर 203203।	80	65	0.6960	मे से	0.0870	0.0437	0.1342
		79	81	0.1750		0.0437		
		422	82	0.5370		0.1342		0.2649
6.	महेश पाल सिंह, बृजेशपाल सिंह व दिनेश कुमार सिंह पुत्र सुरेन्द्र सिंह निवासी 89/26, अन्धा एक्लेव, पन्नीनगर, बुलन्दशहर उ० प्र० 203001	265	904	0.1410	सम्पूर्ण	0.1410		
7.	यशपाल सिंह पुत्र रामचन्द्र सिंह नि० चौकी, झाझर, ककोड़, बुलन्दशहर उ० प्र० 203203।	80	65	0.6960	मे से	0.0870		
ग्राम मुन्नातागा सैक्टर-34								
8.	शीला देवी पत्नी गुलाब सिंह उर्फ शीला पत्नी गुलाग निवासी मोहल्ला मेना ठाकुरान कस्बा रबपुरा।	245	377	1.9120	1/9	0.2125		
9.	भगवत सिंह मीना पुत्र गुलाब सिंह मीना निवासी मोहल्ला मेना ठाकुरान कस्बा रबपुरा।	245	377	1.9120	1/9	0.2124		
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ग्राम आकलपुर सैक्टर-09 व 10								
11.	गंगा उर्फ राधेश्याम शर्मा पूर्व परसादी लाल निवासी गढ़ी मेड़ु उत्तर पूर्वी दिल्ली 110053	37	276	0.3540	मे से	0.0590	0.0612	0.0549
			246	0.3670		0.0526		0.1202
			245	0.3290		0.3750		0.7600
			273	0.3160		1.4829		0.1265
			274	0.7210	सम्पूर्ण			
			163	0.3750	सम्पूर्ण			
			270	0.7600				
12.	कुसुम पत्नी मेहन्द्र निवासी ग्राम म्याना	152	293	4.2360	मे से			

अतः उपरोक्त भूमि क्रय किये जाने में यदि किसी व्यक्ति को कोई आपत्ति है, तो वह लिखित रूप में 15 दिवस के अंदर यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण कार्यालय/सीओआर/सेल में अपनी आपत्ति प्रस्तुत कर सकता है।

विशेष कार्यधिकारी/उप जिलाधिकारी यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औ० विकास प्राधिकरण

महत्वपूर्ण सूचना: यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के अधिसूचित क्षेत्र में प्राधिकरण द्वारा स्वीकृत मास्टर प्लान के अतिरिक्त प्लॉटिंग/झाउसिंग/कॉलोनी या किसी भी प्रकार का अन्य निर्माण पूरी तरह से अवैध है। सामान्यज इस प्रकार की खरीदफरोख्त से पूर्णतः सचेत रहे तथा कॉलोनाइज़र के नामक विज्ञापनों से बचे। अधिक जानकारी के लिए प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com देखें।



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			270	0.7600				
12.	कुसुम पत्नी मेहन्द्र निवासी ग्राम म्याना	152	293	4.2360	मे से			

अतः उपरोक्त भूमि क्रय किये जाने में यदि किसी व्यक्ति को कोई आपत्ति है, तो वह लिखित रूप में 15 दिवस के अंदर यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण कार्यालय/सीओआर/सेल में अपनी आपत्ति प्रस्तुत कर सकता है।

विशेष कार्यधिकारी/उप जिलाधिकारी यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औ० विकास प्राधिकरण

महत्वपूर्ण सूचना: यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के अधिसूचित क्षेत्र में प्राधिकरण द्वारा स्वीकृत मास्टर प्लान के अतिरिक्त प्लॉटिंग/झाउसिंग/कॉलोनी या किसी भी प्रकार का अन्य निर्माण पूरी तरह से अवैध है। सामान्यज इस प्रकार की खरीदफरोख्त से पूर्णतः सचेत रहे तथा कॉलोनाइज़र के नामक विज्ञापनों से बचे। अधिक जानकारी के लिए प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com देखें।



यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण
प्रथम तल, कॉमर्शियल कॉम्प्लेक्स, ओमेगा-1, (पी-2), ग्रेटर नोएडा
Toll Free No. 18001808296 वेबसाइट: www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com

पत्रांक: वाई.ई.ए./मूलेख/517/2026

दिनांक: 19.06.2026

सार्वजनिक सूचना

यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा ग्राम उटरावली सैक्टर 13, 15सी (45 मी० रोड) व ग्राम मुन्नागा सैक्टर-34 व ग्राम आकलपुर सैक्टर-09 व 10 के अन्तर्गत आने वाली भूमि का सुनियोजित विकास हेतु सम्बंधित कृकों द्वारा दी गयी सहमति की दर रु० 3808/- प्रतिवर्गमीटर से यमुना विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा शासनादेश संख्या 314/77-3-163एम, दिनांक 23.02.2016 में तय प्रक्रियानुसार निम्नानुसार क्रय किया जाना प्रस्तावित है:-

क्र० सं०	काश्तकार का नाम	खाता संख्या	खसरा संख्या	खसरे का क्षेत्रफल (हे० मे)	काश्तकार का माग	क्षेत्रफल (हे० मे)	हिस्सानुसार क्षेत्रफल (हे० मे)	अन्य विवरण
ग्राम उटरावली सैक्टर-13 व 15सी (45 मी० रोड)								
1.	सुरेश चन्द्र त्यागी पुत्र जगजीत उर्फ जगदीश नि० ग्राम	533	675	3.7490	मे से	0.7436	0.0210	0.7646
2.	ओमवती देवी पत्नी ओमप्रकाश सिंह व रोबिन सिंह, सुधीर, सुभाष पुनराग ओमप्रकाश सिंह निवासी आच्छेपुर।	43	151	0.2790	सम्पूर्ण मे से	0.2790	0.0032	0.2822
3.	धर्मपाल सिंह पुत्र मेवाराम निवासी चौकी झाझर तहसील बुलन्दशहर।	80	65	0.6960	मे से	0.0870	0.0438	0.1342
		422	82	0.5370		0.2650		
4.	कुसुमपाल सिंह पुत्र मेवाराम निवासी नियर मदरडेरी सैक्टर 46 नोएडा।	80	65	0.6960	मे से	0.0870	0.0437	0.1343
		79	81	0.1750		0.2650		
		422	82	0.5370		0.1342		0.2649
5.	रेशमपाल सिंह पुत्र मेवाराम निवासी चौकी झाझर तहसील बुलन्दशहर 203203।	80	65	0.6960	मे से	0.0870	0.0437	0.1342
		79	81	0.1750		0.0437		
		422	82	0.5370		0.1342		0.2649
6.	महेश पाल सिंह, बृजेशपाल सिंह व दिनेश कुमार सिंह पुत्र सुरेन्द्र सिंह निवासी 89/26, अन्धा एक्लेव, पन्नीनगर, बुलन्दशहर उ० प्र० 203001	265	904	0.1410	सम्पूर्ण	0.1410		
7.	यशपाल सिंह पुत्र रामचन्द्र सिंह नि० चौकी, झाझर, ककोड़, बुलन्दशहर उ० प्र० 203203।	80	65	0.6960	मे से	0.0870		
ग्राम मुन्नातागा सैक्टर-34								
8.	शीला देवी पत्नी गुलाब सिंह उर्फ शीला पत्नी गुलाग निवासी मोहल्ला मेना ठाकुरान कस्बा रबपुरा।	245	377	1.9120	1/9	0.2125		
9.	भगवत सिंह मीना पुत्र गुलाब सिंह मीना निवासी मोहल्ला मेना ठाकुरान कस्बा रबपुरा।	245	377	1.9120	1/9	0.2124		
10.	महेश सिंह मीना पुत्र गुलाब निवासी मोहल्ला मेना ठाकुरान कस्बा रबपुरा।	245	377	1.9120	1/9	0.2124		
ग्राम आकलपुर सैक्टर-09 व 10								
11.	गंगा उर्फ राधेश्याम शर्मा पूर्व परसादी लाल निवासी गढ़ी मेड़ु उत्तर पूर्वी दिल्ली 110053	37	276	0.3540	मे से	0.0590	0.0612	0.0549
			246	0.3670		0.0526		0.1202
			245	0.3290		0.3750		0.7600
			273	0.3160		1.4829		0.1265
			274	0.7210	सम्पूर्ण			
			163	0.3750	सम्पूर्ण			
			270	0.7600				
12.	कुसुम पत्नी मेहन्द्र निवासी ग्राम म्याना	152	293	4.2360	मे से			

अतः उपरोक्त भूमि क्रय किये जाने में यदि किसी व्यक्ति को कोई आपत्ति है, तो वह लिखित रूप में 15 दिवस के अंदर यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण कार्यालय/सीओआर/सेल में अपनी आपत्ति प्रस्तुत कर सकता है।

विशेष कार्यधिकारी/उप जिलाधिकारी यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औ० विकास प्राधिकरण

महत्वपूर्ण सूचना: यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के अधिसूचित क्षेत्र में प्राधिकरण द्वारा स्वीकृत मास्टर प्लान के अतिरिक्त प्लॉटिंग/झाउसिंग/कॉलोनी या किसी भी प्रकार का अन्य निर्माण पूरी तरह से अवैध है। सामान्यज इस प्रकार की खरीदफरोख्त से पूर्णतः सचेत रहे तथा कॉलोनाइज़र के नामक विज्ञापनों से बचे। अधिक जानकारी के लिए प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com देखें।



यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण
प्र

Yamuna Bazar residents face uncertain future after demolition

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Scenes of despair, anxiety and uncertainty unfolded along the Yamuna Bazar stretch on Thursday morning as bulldozers rolled into the settlement and razed hundreds of homes, leaving families scrambling to salvage their belongings and confront an uncertain future.

Earlier in the day, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) demolished several houses it found illegal in the Yamuna Bazar area near Kashmere Gate. The authority said it had issued notices asking residents living in settlements between Ghat Nos 2 and 32 to vacate the protected Yamuna floodplain.

As the DDA carried out a demolition drive to clear

alleged encroachments from the Yamuna floodplain, residents stood amid mounds of debris, clutching bags and household items that they could save. Some looked on silently, while others broke down as decades-old homes disappeared before their eyes.

Carrying their few possessions on their backs, many displaced residents began making their way toward nearby shelter homes, unsure of where they would eventually settle. The noise of the demolition machinery drowned out repeated pleas from locals who claimed authorities had not heard their concerns. "The court has asked the authorities to listen to us, but they are not listening," several residents said.

The operation began



around 6 am following a fresh notice issued by the DDA on June 23 directing occupants of the Yamuna Bazar ghats to vacate the area. Heavy police deployment was made to maintain law and order during the exercise.

According to residents, at least 310 houses were demolished, affecting more than 1,100 people. News reports

noted that many residents, who had lived in the area for 20 to 30 years, questioned why they were now being described as illegal occupants after decades of residence.

The DDA has maintained that the action was undertaken in compliance with National Green Tribunal (NGT) directions to remove encroachments from the



Yamuna floodplain, a protected O-Zone where construction is prohibited. Residents had also received eviction notices from the DDA and the Delhi Disaster Management Authority in recent months.

Among those affected was Muskan, a third-year BA student raised by her maternal uncle and aunt since losing her mother and being abandoned

by her father. Standing amid the rubble, she worried that the demolition could force her to give up her education and enter the workforce prematurely.

Muskan, who is currently interning at a chartered accountant firm in East Delhi, said that paying rent would place an additional financial burden on her family. "Now I

will start looking for a job since I can't be a burden on them, and the rent will affect us all," Muskan said.

For many families, the demolition was not merely the loss of a home but the loss of a livelihood. Nagendra Mishra, a light technician who works near Kashmere Gate and has lived in the area for nearly two decades, said his family was unwilling to move into shelter homes suggested by authorities.

"I have a family of eight. They have asked us to shift to different night shelters. Those facilities are not safe for us. My daughters don't feel safe there," he said.

The drive also dealt a severe blow to those whose livelihoods are tied to the Yamuna. Sudhakar Kumar Nishadraj, who ferries pil-

grims and visitors across the river and assists families performing last rites, said around 100 families dependent on river-based occupations have been affected.

"I have been sitting here since six in the morning, just watching," Nishadraj said. "Officials came two days ago and told us everything had to be removed by June 25. We had seen it coming. But where do we go now?" He said several affected families have depended on the river for generations, earning their living through ferry services and religious activities along the ghats.

As evening approached, the settlement was largely reduced to rubble. Displaced residents weighed their next move amid concerns over rehabilitation, safety and survival.

CM Rekha orders probe into Fortis Hospital over negligence in treatment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Following complaints of irregularities and serious negligence in the treatment of patients at Fortis Hospital in Shalimar Bagh, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta had ordered an inquiry into the hospital. On Thursday, a team comprising officials from various departments inspected the hospital and found several irregularities. The Government has decided to initiate action against Fortis Hospital. A detailed inquiry report is being prepared.

The inquiry was ordered after a family lodged a complaint with the Chief Minister during a public hearing at the Chief Minister's Jan Seva Sadan. The family alleged that their son, who had been stabbed in the Shalimar Bagh area, was taken to Fortis Hospital.

According to the family, the hospital demanded money before beginning his treatment. They further alleged that the delay in providing timely and appropriate treatment led to their



son's death. Disturbed by the incident and the alleged irregularities and serious negligence in patient care, the Chief Minister ordered an inquiry into the matter.

On Thursday, a team led by SS Parihar, District Magistrate of the Central-North District, along with officials from the health department, the municipal corporation, the fire department and other departments, inspected the hospital.

During the inspection, the team found several irregularities, including misuse of building by-laws, illegal construction, deficiencies in the fire safety system, misuse of the basement, and serious lapses in adherence to the

Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) governing medical protocols.

The team also examined CCTV footage and found that the youth who later died after suffering the stab injury had walked into the emergency department on his own. This suggests that had he received timely treatment, his life could have been saved.

The team also examined records maintained by the emergency department. According to the District Magistrate, in view of these irregularities and the negligence in patient care, it has been decided to initiate action against the hospital. A detailed inquiry report is being prepared.

Pollution levels at some points along Yamuna dipped in May: DPCC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Pollution Control Committee's (DPCC) data on Yamuna water quality for May shows a decrease in faecal coliform levels at several points along the river, even as marked deterioration was observed at some points, indicating that significant amounts of untreated sewage were still entering the river.

The report also shows high levels of Biological Oxygen Demand (BOD), a measure of the amount of dissolved oxygen required by microorganisms to break down organic matter in water. A higher BOD value indicates higher levels of pollution, often leading to oxygen depletion and harm to aquatic life.

The water quality testing by the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) involves collecting water samples from eight locations along the course of the Yamuna in the capital and gauging several parameters, such as BOD, dissolved oxygen, chemical oxygen demand, pH and faecal coliform content, to determine pollution level.



These locations are Palla, Wazirabad, ISBT Bridge, ITO Bridge, Nizamuddin Bridge, Hindon Cut, Okhla Barrage and Asgarpur in Kidwali, Haryana. While five of the points showed slight improvement in faecal coliform levels since April, the figures remained above the permissible limit of 2,500 and the desirable level of 500.

The May report showed slight improvement at ISBT Bridge, but levels of faecal coliform remained as high as 130,000 Most Probable Number per 100 millilitres (MPN/100 ml), as compared to 170,000 MPN/100 ml in April.

The four other locations which showed improvement were Palla, where faecal coliform levels improved from 2,800 MPN/100 ml in April to 2,200 MPN/100 ml in May;

Wazirabad, where the level improved from 9,200 MPN/100 ml to 3,500 MPN/100 ml; ITO Bridge, where the level went from 150,000 MPN/100 ml in April to 120,000 MPN/100 ml in May; and Nizamuddin Bridge, where the level improved from 140,000 MPN/100 ml to 110,000 MPN/100 ml.

The river showed further deterioration at Asgarpur, where levels of faecal coliform remained as high as 330,000 (MPN/100 ml) in May, as compared to 310,000 in April.

The pollution level has also deteriorated at the Okhla barrage, where the faecal coliform level touched 140,000 MPN/100 ml in May, as compared to 120,000 MPN/100 ml in April; and Hindon Cut where the level remained around 92,000 MPN/100 ml as compared to 54,000 MPN/100 ml in April.

BOD levels for May also showed alarming readings, ranging from 2-60 milligrams per litre (mg/l), while the water quality criteria stipulated a maximum of 3 mg/l, with the highest BOD recorded at Asgarpur at 60 mg/l. BOD at Asgarpur last month was 58 mg/l.

Two held for stabbing after dispute at Shahbad Daulatpur Bar



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

What began as a late-night argument over a song request at a bar in Delhi's Shahbad Daulatpur allegedly spiralled into a deadly revenge attack. Two teenagers returned armed with knives hours after a brawl and stabbed two people, one of whom later died from his injuries. The Delhi Police Crime Branch has now arrested the two accused and claimed to have cracked what was initially a blind murder case.

The Crime Branch's Western Range-I unit apprehended the accused, Abhishek, 18, and Ashwin, 18, both residents of Mangolpuri, on June 24 after a sustained investigation involving technical surveillance and human intelligence.

The case pertains to a violent incident that took place during the intervening night of June 17 and 18 at OH Village Lodge and Bar in Shahbad Daulatpur. According to police, two young men were stabbed multiple times after a dispute broke out inside the establishment. Both victims were admitted to the hospital with serious injuries. One of them succumbed to his injuries on June 23, prompting investigators to add the charge of murder under Section 103(1) of the BNS to the case.

Initially, investigators had few leads, making it a blind murder case. Crime Branch officers said extensive technical analysis and intelligence gathering helped identify the suspects and track their movements. Acting on specific information, a special team laid a

AN ARGUMENT REPORTEDLY BROKE OUT WITH THE DJ OPERATOR AFTER HE REFUSED TO CHANGE A SONG

trap near Mahavir Hospital in Pitampura on June 24. The two suspects were intercepted and apprehended after a brief chase.

During interrogation, the accused allegedly confessed to their involvement in the crime. Police said the pair had visited the lodge and bar with friends to smoke hookah on the night of the incident. An argument reportedly broke out with the DJ operator after he refused to change a song. The dispute escalated into a physical fight in which the accused claimed they were assaulted by several people present there.

Investigators said the duo subsequently returned to Mangolpuri, gathered associates, armed themselves with knives and went back to the venue seeking revenge. They allegedly attacked two men whom they believed had assaulted them earlier, inflicting multiple stab wounds before fleeing.

The accused had been absconding since the incident. DCP (Crime Branch) Harsh Indora said the arrests demonstrate the Crime Branch's commitment to tackling serious violent crime and ensuring offenders are brought to justice. Further investigation is underway to establish the complete sequence of events and determine the involvement of other suspects.

Govt transfers 60 IAS, DANICS officers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a major administrative reshuffle, the Delhi Government has transferred 60 IAS and DANICS cadre officers, involving secretaries of four ministers, with immediate effect.

According to the Services department orders issued on Wednesday, the additional chief secretary (ACS) of the Social Welfare Department will also handle the additional charge of the Women and Child Development department.

Navin Chaudhary IAS (AGMUT 1994), ACS Irrigation Department, will take additional charge of the general administration department (GAD) after the relieving of Pandurang Pole (AGMUT 1994).

Pole will now be Secretary (Land and Building) with additional charge of Secretary, Labour and Cooperation.

Sandeep Kumar Singh (AGMUT 2011), who is Special Secretary at the Chief



Minister's Office (CMO), will also handle the charge of managing director of S h a h b a d Redevelopment Corporation.

Sachin Rana (AGMUT 2014), holding the post of special secretary (Home), will hold additional charges of Special Secretary of Urban Development, and principal director of Delhi Fire Services.

Santosh Kumar Rai will be the special CEO of Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) with additional charge of Special Secretary (Home).

Ankur Mehra (DANICS 2014), serving as ADM (Outer North), will now be the secretary to Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Singh

Indraj.

Vinay Kumar Jindal (DANICS 2014), who served as secretary to Law Minister Kapil Mishra, will now be Delhi Jal Board (DJB) director. Ranjeet Kumar Singh (DANICS 2014), joint director (education), will replace him as the new secretary to Mishra.

Health Minister Pankaj Singh's secretary, Vaibhav Rikhari (DANICS 2013), was also transferred as director of DJB. Mukesh Rajora (DANICS 2013) ADM (HQ) will be the new secretary of Singh, who also holds the Transport and IT department charge.

Rajesh Chaudhary (DANICS 2013), serving as joint secretary (urban development), will be secretary to Industries

and Environment minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa, according to the orders.

Several district magistrates and sub-divisional magistrates were also reshuffled in the administrative shake-up.

South West district magistrate Mekala Chaitanya Prasad (AGMUT 2015) will be Special Secretary (Health), while KK Lakshman (AGMUT 2017) has been shifted from Old Delhi district magistrate to the same post in South West Delhi.

The Public Works Department (PWD) approved the project in December last year, along with the Modi Mill flyover's integration with the Kalkaji Temple road.

"After administrative approval, the work was awarded; however, due to constraints of space in the area, we have requested the DDA for around two acres so that construction can be carried out without too much hindrance to traffic movement," an official said.

According to the plan, the second flyover at Savitri Cinema will be constructed parallel to the existing structure for ₹58 crore. This construction will provide hassle-

Govt seeks DDA land for Savitri Cinema flyover

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has requested land from the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) to begin construction of the Savitri Cinema half-flyover in South Delhi.

The Public Works Department (PWD) approved the project in December last year, along with the Modi Mill flyover's integration with the Kalkaji Temple road.

"After administrative approval, the work was awarded; however, due to constraints of space in the area, we have requested the DDA for around two acres so that construction can be carried out without too much hindrance to traffic movement," an official said.

According to the plan, the second flyover at Savitri Cinema will be constructed parallel to the existing structure for ₹58 crore. This construction will provide hassle-

free movement between Greater Kailash and Nehru Place, Chittranjan Park and the Chirag Delhi area.

The official said the authorities identified the need for a second flyover in 2016, and a basic plan was also prepared and approved by the Unified Traffic and Transportation Infrastructure (Planning & Engineering) Centre (UTTIPEC).

"Once operational, the flyovers will provide signal-free movement, improve traffic speeds, and eliminate congestion at key junctions, particularly at Captain Gaur Marg-Outer Ring Road and Outer Ring Road-GK-II Road and nearby areas," PWD Minister Parvash Sahib Singh said.

The official said to integrate Kalkaji Mandir with the Modi Mill flyover, a new three-lane carriageway will be constructed. He said a three-lane carriageway will be constructed from Modi Mill to Kalkaji Temple at the cost of ₹312.94 crore.

Delhi's historic Safdarjung Tomb set for major restoration under ₹5 crore conservation project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 270 years after the mausoleum was built for the eponymous Nawab of Awadh and minister in the Mughal court, the grand Safdarjung Tomb — one of Delhi's best-known late-Mughal monuments — is set for a fresh lease of life.

The imposing sandstone-and-marble mausoleum is getting a revamp, with the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) and the World Monuments Fund (WMF) undertaking restoration and conservation works estimated to cost ₹5 crore, an official said.

The project, which includes structural repairs, restoration of damaged architec-

tural elements, landscaping works and revival of the monument's ancient water system, is targeted for completion by July 30 and is among the most extensive conservation efforts undertaken at the site in recent decades, he said.

ASI Superintending Archaeologist RK Patel said the WMF has taken up restoration of the monument's outer boundary walls, underpinning works, repairs of pathways, rejuvenation of Charbagh-style gardens and installation of a rainwater harvesting system across the complex.

He said the rainwater harvesting infrastructure would help revive the ancient fountains and water channels surrounding the tomb, many

of which have remained non-functional for years, restoring a key feature of the monument's original design.

Additionally, the ASI has undertaken conservation and repair works within the main mausoleum, including restoration of the ground floor, roof and several structurally vulnerable sections of the building, Patel said.

According to the official, damaged supports from the plinth level up to the first floor are being replaced, while collapsed masonry, plaster-work and flooring are being restored using traditional materials and techniques consistent with the monument's original design.

Patel said 'lakhauri' bricks -- flat, thin, red burnt-clay blocks, often referred to as



'Badshahi' bricks for their extensive use in Mughal architecture — are being used in repairs, while underpinning and strengthening are being carried out to stabilise ageing portions of the structure that have deteriorated over time.

The conservation effort comes amid growing con-

cerns over the monument's condition. Several sections of the upper-level red sandstone parapet have either weakened or disappeared over the years, posing a risk for visitors.

A young woman was injured a few months ago after falling from the first floor when a damaged

boundary section gave way. She remained hospitalised for two days following the incident, highlighting concerns over visitor safety within the protected monument.

Built in 1754, the mausoleum houses the remains of Mirza Muqim Abul Mansur Khan, popularly known as Safdarjung, the Nawab of Awadh who served as prime minister of the Mughal Empire under Emperor Ahmad Shah Bahadur.

Historians regard Safdarjung Tomb as one of the last major monuments of the Mughal era and a symbol of the empire's waning political authority.

Unlike earlier grand Mughal mausoleums commissioned by emperors and

members of the imperial family, the tomb was built by Safdarjung's son, Nawab Shuja-ud-Daula, reflecting the shifting balance of power within the empire during the mid-18th century.

Patel said the monument represents a shift from the architecture of earlier Mughal imperial tombs, while retaining certain key elements such as the Mughal garden and funerary design.

Set amid a sprawling Charbagh garden — four gardens traditionally separated by waterways, quintessential to Mughal mausoleums — the tomb follows the 'hasht bihisht' or 'eight paradises' layout, featuring a central domed burial chamber surrounded by eight interconnected rooms.

The monument stands on an elevated platform measuring about 18.29 metres by 18.29 metres and is built primarily of red and buff sandstone, with marble detailing giving it a distinctive appearance.

Patel said signs of deterioration became increasingly visible after the pandemic period, with stone sections of boundary walls developing cracks, plaster peeling from surfaces and decorative colours fading across large parts of the structure.

The restoration would help safeguard one of Delhi's most iconic heritage landmarks and improve the overall visitor experience without compromising the monument's historic character, the officer added.

Row over NCERT move on Emergency

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A war of words broke out between the BJP and Congress on Wednesday after the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) included a section on Emergency in its class 9 social science textbook. Earlier, the topic was part of class 12 school curriculum. The textbook refers to the period as “one of the major challenges to democracy in India.”

“One of the major challenges to democracy in India was recorded when an Emergency was imposed in 1975-77. In the early 1970s, public dissatisfaction with the government led by Indira Gandhi was growing. Rising unemployment, inflation, and allegations of mis-governance led to widespread protests,” said the



WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

paragraph in the newly developed Social Science textbook “Understanding Society: India and Beyond”.

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan hailed the move saying future generations should know about the “dark deeds” of the

Congress with the latter accusing the NCERT of engaging in “divisive politics” and undermining Constitutional values.

Former law minister and BJP leader Ravi Shankar Prasad alleged that the Congress is afraid of the

truth because any discussion on the Emergency will raise uncomfortable questions about the arrest of Jayaprakash Narayan, the forced sterilisation campaign and other actions taken during the period. “Young people will ask

why Jayaprakash Narayan was arrested. Why was forced sterilisation carried out? The Congress does not have any reply,” Prasad told reporters during a Press conference at the BJP head-quarters.

Congress MP KC Venugopal criticised the NCERT for including a section on the Emergency in the Class IX textbook. “They (BJP) are interested only in this type of divisive politics. They are trying to divert the history of India and are trying to change the curriculum... This is not at all acceptable. This is an attack on constitutional values, and we are fighting against that,” Venugopal said.

The Emergency was imposed 51 years ago on June 25, 1975, following a period of political unrest and a court verdict that declared Gandhi’s election

UP opposition slams BJP over Ayodhya Ram temple FIR

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow



Opposition parties in Uttar Pradesh stepped up their attack on the BJP Government on Thursday after an FIR was lodged in connection with the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, with Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav and Uttar Pradesh Congress chief Ajay Rai questioning the timing and scope of the police action.

Police in Ayodhya registered the FIR on Thursday following a complaint from a member of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, hours after the Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP) also backed demands for a criminal case in the matter. In a post on X, Yadav alleged

that the FIR was preceded by efforts to shield influential persons. “In BJP rule, this is how injustice will be displayed: the tip of the tree will be hanged while the branches will be forgiven,” he said.

“The public is saying that first, under the pretext of the SIT, all evidence would have been cleaned up and it would have been decided which big fish had to be saved and who had to be trapped. Only after that has the FIR been registered,” he added. “It appears the SIT

report was prepared in advance and the investigation was conducted accordingly, meaning the conclusion had already been reached beforehand,” the former Uttar Pradesh chief minister added.

Speaking to PTI Videos in Varanasi, Rai said the Congress had raised the issue across Uttar Pradesh and demanded the registration of an FIR in connection with the alleged donation embezzlement.

“Our party raised its voice in every district of the state over the theft and embezzlement of offerings at the Ayodhya Ram temple and demanded that an FIR be registered. We had also submitted copies of a memorandum addressed to the president to officials in every district,” he said.

Two women die by suicide in Delhi; husbands booked

KHUSHI MEHROTRA ■ New Delhi

Two women in their 20s allegedly died by suicide in separate incidents in Delhi, with police registering cases against their husbands after family members accused them of harassment and cruelty.

In the first case, a 24-year-old woman was found dead inside her rented room in Khyala on June 24 after police received a PCR call regarding her death. Investigators who reached the spot found the woman hanging and seized a chunni allegedly used as the ligature material, along with other exhibits from the scene.

Police said the crime team and forensic experts inspected the room and preserved evidence. As the woman had been married for around three years, the matter was reported to the Sub-Divisional Magistrate (SDM), Rajouri Garden, for inquest proceedings.

During the inquiry, statements recorded from the deceased’s family members before the SDM allegedly pointed to cruelty and harassment by her in-laws. No suicide note was recovered. A ligature mark was found on her neck, and the body was shifted to the mortuary at Deen Dayal



Upadhyay Hospital after medico-legal formalities. Based on the allegations, police registered an FIR under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and began further investigation.

In a separate incident, a 26-year-old woman from Nangloi Extension was declared dead at Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital on June 23. Police said preliminary inquiry revealed she died by suicidal hanging within seven years of marriage, necessitating an inquest by the concerned SDM.

The deceased’s mother told authorities that her daughter had allegedly been subjected to physical abuse by her husband, who frequently assaulted her while under the influence of alcohol.

Investigators also learned that the husband is currently undergoing treatment for a severe head injury suffered in an accident a few months ago.

During the investigation, the woman’s family handed over two videos purportedly recorded by her shortly before her death. Police said the videos appeared to show her in severe psychological distress and expressing fears for her safety due to alleged continuous harassment by her husband.

A post-mortem examination was conducted on June 24, and police subsequently registered a case against the husband based on the allegations and evidence collected so far. Further investigation is underway in both cases.

Kolkata warehouse collapse toll rises to 11

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

The toll in the Taratala warehouse collapse in south Kolkata rose to 11 on Thursday as rescue teams, aided by the Army’s advanced ground-penetrating radar (GPR) system, continued intensive search operations through the rubble for over 24 hours after the incident, officials said.

Five more people were rescued from the debris in the morning, taking the total number of victims pulled out from under the rubble to 30, according to sources involved in the operation.

According to official sources, 10 people died either at the site of the incident or shortly thereafter, while another injured person succumbed to injuries during treatment on Thursday, taking the toll to 11. The deceased, have been identified as Krishna Chowdhury (30) of North 24 Parganas, Rohit Choudhary (40) of Nadia, Rahul Choudhury (17) of Purba Bardhaman, Chandrama Choudhury (60) of Krishnanagar, Pappu Rajak (40) of Shyamnagar, Azgar Hossain (55) of Khidirpur in Kolkata, Sahil Sardar (17) of Basanti, Ghi Kumar (17) of Munger



Owner of the under-construction warehouse being produced at a court in Kolkata PTI

in Bihar, Hasan Imam (44) of Metiabruz, Nabin Singh of Asansol and Ganesh Kalindi (45), who died while undergoing treatment at SSKM Hospital. Nineteen injured are currently undergoing treatment in the state-run hospital, officials said.

Meanwhile, heavy rain stalled the rescue operations for nearly an hour, even as personnel from police, fire services, NDRF and the Army remained deployed at the

site. The warehouse was being built on a leasehold plot owned by the Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port in the city. Rescue efforts continued through the night under the supervision of senior state Government and civic officials, including Health Secretary Narayan Swarup Nigam, Kolkata Police Commissioner Ajay Nanda and Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC) Commissioner Smita Pandey.

Canada names Khalistanis for...

Surveillance did not work well, intelligence was not shared or acted on properly, and chances to stop the plot were missed.

For many years, Indian authorities said the bombing was carried out by Khalistani terrorists based in Canada. Canadian governments and memorials usually referred to them as “Sikh extremists” or simply described the event as a terrorist attack, without mentioning the Khalistan movement in official statements.

The report also says that violent extremist activities by CBKs continue to threaten Canada’s national security and Canadian interests abroad. It clearly separates peaceful advocacy for Khalistan, which is not considered extremism, from the actions of “a small group of individuals who use Canada as a base to promote, fundraise, or plan violence primarily in India.”

FIR filed in Ram Mandir fund embezzlement case

In its preliminary report to Additional Chief Secretary (Home) Sanjay Prasad, the SIT found serious problems with how cash was handled, how employees were hired and checked, how CCTV was used, and how offerings were tracked from the temple donation boxes to the Trust office and banks.

The report said that a private agency hired by SBI to count money used workers recommended by Trust associates, but there were insufficient checks on who entered or left the work areas. It also found problems in how gold, silver, and other valuables from devotees were recorded and tracked. The report noted that some sevadars and employees saw their assets grow quickly after the temple’s consecration in January 2024.

It is alleged that embezzlement went on for years, with staff staying quiet because influential people were involved. The SIT named 17 people as accused, including some senior Trust officials. It recommended filing FIRs, reorganising the Trust, and appointing a senior administrator. The investigation now also covers land deals and the purchase of construction materials. The Trust’s decision to file the FIR follows the SIT’s findings.

Sources say the complaint was based on the preliminary report and internal findings. The SIT has reportedly instructed key Trust functionaries not to leave the city. The Trust had initially maintained that internal audits were underway and sought the independent SIT probe to establish facts and counter what it described as attempts to tarnish the temple’s image. The development has intensified political debate.

The Trust and the UP government have said that the investigation began internally to ensure accountability. However, opposition parties want the full SIT report, all financial records, CCTV footage, and bank statements to be made

public. Some are asking for a CBI or court-monitored investigation. The SIT report and the FIR highlight ongoing concerns about how major religious institutions manage large public donations. Since the preliminary findings show both systemic problems and individual responsibility, more action is expected in the coming weeks, including possible arrests and a detailed final report. The Ram Mandir, consecrated in January 2024, attracts millions of devotees.

The Trust says it is committed to transparency and to protecting offerings made in faith.

Commercial LPG curbs lifted

To safeguard household consumption, the Government initially halted supplies of commercial LPG to hotels, restaurants and industrial users, diverting available volumes to domestic consumers.

Supplies were subsequently restored in phases to about 70 per cent of normal levels, although several sectors continued to face curbs of up to 50 per cent of their usual allocations as authorities sought to conserve fuel stocks amid concerns over import availability. Refineries were ordered to produce more LPG by diverting streams they would otherwise use for petrochemical production.

Crude oil prices have fallen back to pre-war levels, government crisis briefings have been suspended, and fuel supply concerns have receded as shipping and energy flows normalise. The rollback of emergency restrictions underscores New Delhi’s confidence that domestic production and imports are sufficient to meet demand, reducing the need for crisis-era rationing measures that had affected industrial and commercial fuel users.

The ministry has also directed Oil Marketing Companies to continue maintaining comprehensive data on commercial and industrial LPG consumers to facilitate efficient planning and supply management.

The government has directed Oil Marketing Companies to continue maintaining comprehensive data on commercial and industrial LPG consumers to facilitate efficient planning and supply management. A unified sectoral database will also be maintained across the OMCs to strengthen monitoring and operational coordination.

At the same time, the Government remains committed to expanding PNG connectivity. Commercial and bulk consumers who have already shifted to Piped Natural Gas (PNG) will continue to remain on PNG. Other eligible LPG consumers having access to the PNG network, or those in the process of shifting to PNG, will be progressively transitioned to PNG in coordination with City Gas Distribution (CGD) entities.

In this regard, the Secretary, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, has written to the Chief Secretaries of all States and Union Territories for ensuring smooth implementation of the revised supply arrangements.

FROM PAGE - 1 Earthquake hits Venezuela hard

Acting President Delcy Rodríguez, who gave the latest death toll early Thursday, said authorities were shifting rescue teams from other parts of the country to La Guaira, which sits north of Caracas on the coast. Officials were trying to make the most of the daylight hours to speed up efforts to rescue people believed to remain trapped under the rubble, she said.

Footage on state TV showed three children, covered in dust but alive, pulled from the rubble in La Guaira state, which Rodríguez described as a “disaster zone” and one of the areas hardest hit by the quakes because of the large number of collapsed buildings.

“Dozens of buildings have collapsed there ... and we are currently carrying out intensive rescue operations to save lives,” Rodríguez said. Video shared online appeared to show dozens of people, some lying on the ground and others on hospital beds, being treated outside a hospital in La Guaira.

While Venezuela sits near multiple fault lines, its position straddling the South American and Caribbean plates makes strong earthquakes much less common than in other parts of Latin America. Rodríguez appealed to businesses to make heavy construction equipment available for rescue operations, adding that search and rescue teams certified by the United Nations were on their way to Venezuela.

During the quakes, people ran from swaying buildings in Caracas, many visibly shocked when they turned back to see destroyed walls that left furniture visible from the street. Columns of dust rose in two typically busy neighborhoods in the capital.

“It started off gently and then gradually grew, and in the end, we all had to leave our houses, go outside and gather together,” Caracas resident Hector Ricci said.

The U.S. Geological Survey said the first earthquake, with a magnitude of 7.2, hit west of Moron on the Caribbean coast, about 170 kilometers (105 miles) west of Caracas. It had a depth of 22 kilometers (about 14 miles). Just a minute later, USGS reported a second 7.5 magnitude earthquake, with a depth of 10 kilometers (about 6 miles) and an epicenter 16 kilometers (10 miles) southwest of Moron. Interior Minister Diosdado Cabello urged people to remain outside as aftershocks could further damage structures, and many people stayed on the streets for hours, some sitting on the ground hugging pets as dust gathered around them. In downtown Caracas, hundreds of people spent the night huddled around parks, parking lots and other open spaces. Authorities warned against returning to homes with structural damage.

“We were afraid the buildings would collapse on us,” said Maria Cristina Diaz, a 41-year-old janitor. “My mother, my daughter and I were cold. We didn’t sleep a wink; but I didn’t want to spend the night alone at home after that ter-

rible earthquake.” “It was awful. We cried, we screamed. Thankfully, we’re alive,” she added.

Diaz and her family rushed to Plaza Candelaria in downtown Caracas because it’s one of the few open areas near her home. Parts of the capital lost power and cellphone coverage, and the earthquakes damaged and closed Simon Bolivar International Airport, the country’s main airport, Rodríguez said. In Caracas, subway services were suspended and natural gas shut off, she said. Classes will also be cancelled for several days, and the Ministry of Education said some school buildings would be used as shelters and donation centers.

On Thursday morning, scores of people in Venezuela and abroad struggled to contact family members. Families began posting missing-person fliers with photos of loved ones, while others shared handwritten lists of names as they searched for those still unaccounted for.

Also on Thursday, the UN human rights mission in Venezuela called on the government to lift local restrictions on social media.

“In the coming hours and days, timely access to reliable information and communication channels will be essential for the protection of the lives, safety, and well-being of the population,” the mission said in a statement.

In August 2024, then President Nicolas Maduro ordered X blocked in an attempt to suppress the exchange of information among those who rejected his claim of victory in the July presidential elections. (AP)

Dinesh Trivedi gets Cabinet rank tag

The travel visas were halted nearly two years ago amid an escalated security situation and strained ties with New Delhi during the Muhammad Yunus-led interim regime. “I am very happy to be able to announce the launch of general travel visas again. Visa applications can be submitted starting June 28,” Trivedi said.

New Delhi’s decision to send a veteran politician to Dhaka came at a time when both sides are looking at repairing the bilateral ties that came under severe strain during the tenure of Bangladesh’s interim government headed by Yunus. The relations between the two neighbours witnessed a major downturn after the Yunus-led interim government came to power in Dhaka following the collapse of the Sheikh Hasina government in August 2024. Trivedi succeeded Pranay Kumar Verma, a 1994-batch officer of the Indian Foreign Service (IFS).

J&K Police allege attack by Army inside station

“The matter pertains to an FIR registered by the local police in Atholi, Kishtwar. The matter is under examination through the appropriate institutional mechanisms. The Indian Army will extend full cooperation in the legal process.

Appropriate actions will be taken based on the outcome of the joint investigation. At this stage, it would be premature to comment further while the investigations are in progress,” he said.

According to the FIR, the Army personnel allegedly tore Kotach’s uniform and also assaulted Sub-Divisional Police Officer (SDPO) Vijay Kumar Bhagat, who had also reached the spot. Katoch further alleges Special Police Officer Suresh Kumar was struck on the neck with the butt of a service rifle, resulting in serious injuries to him. He claimed several other police personnel on duty also sustained injuries during the unprovoked assault.

The FIR also alleges that the Army personnel assaulted the assistant regional transport officer (ARTO) of Kishtwar and his personal security officers inside the police station. The attackers also caused extensive damage to government and public property, vandalising the official vehicle of the ARTO, vehicles of the SDPO and the SHO, and breaking down the main gate of the police station, the FIR said.

What makes an Indian citizen? Ministry of...

Section 10 of the Passports Act allows authorities to revoke or cancel a passport for reasons such as wrongful possession, concealment of important information, security issues, ongoing criminal cases, or violations of rules. If your passport is cancelled, you must return it right away. Section 12 also requires you to return your passport if you become a citizen of another country, as India does not allow dual citizenship for ordinary citizens. If you do not follow these rules, you can be penalised. The government can ask for your passport at any time, so you do not have an absolute right to keep it.

No single document can fully prove citizenship. Indian citizenship is a legal status you get by birth, descent, registration, or naturalisation under the Citizenship Act. For people born after 1987, it is often necessary to show that a parent was an Indian citizen at the time of birth.

In cases such as voter list exclusions, deportations, or rights claims, officials and courts review all the evidence in accordance with the law. Aadhaar, Voter ID, PAN, or a passport can help prove identity or residency, but none is sufficient on its own. The state or courts make the final decision. Once is part of how things work in India. As digital checks become more common with Aadhaar links, voter roll updates, and biometric e-passports, the government is making it clear what each document is meant for.

A passport lets you travel and get visa-free or e-visa entry in many countries, but it does not determine citizenship in India. The key takeaway is simple: the law keeps citizenship separate from any single document. The MEA’s statement is legally sound and useful because it clarifies that citizenship is determined by law, not by holding a passport.

Amazon commits fresh \$13 billion to India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Global giant Amazon will invest an additional \$13 billion in India, taking its planned capital commitment in the country to \$48 billion between 2026 and 2030, Chief Executive Officer Andy Jassy said on Thursday after meeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

"A great meeting with Andy Jassy. I welcome Amazon's record \$48 billion investment in India. This will create new opportunities for our youth," Prime Minister Modi said in a social media post. This also reflects the growing interest across the world to invest in India, he said.

Announcing investment plans, Jassy also said the fresh investment underscores Amazon's long-term commitment to India, which Jassy described as one of the company's most important growth markets globally. He said Amazon's India business is seeing strong momentum, driven by robust customer demand across e-commerce and Amazon Web Services (AWS), its cloud-computing division.

The announcement comes as global technology firms step up investments in India, attracted by the country's expanding digital economy, growing consumer base and rising demand for cloud and AI services. Amazon has invested heavily in India over the past decade, building out logistics networks, technology infrastructure and digital services as it seeks to deepen its presence in one of the world's fastest-growing major economies.

Jassy affirmed Amazon's long-term commitment to the country, and said the company's India business is on a strong growth trajectory with robust customer demand, especially in e-commerce and Amazon Web Services, its cloud computing

unit. He also highlighted the growing importance of India, a market where Amazon operates several businesses, including e-commerce, AI, cloud, and entertainment.

Sharing a photo from his meeting with the Prime Minister, Jassy, in a post on social media, said he really enjoyed the discussion about what's ahead for Amazon in India. "We've been serving customers, sellers, developers, startups, and enterprises in India for more than a decade and just getting started... Excited about what's ahead. Still early days for what we can build," Jassy said.

The Amazon top boss discussed the company's plans to invest \$48 billion over the coming five years, including more than \$21 billion in AI and cloud infrastructure.

By 2030, Amazon plans to support 3.8 million jobs, enable \$80 billion in e-commerce exports, and bring the benefits of AI to 15 million small businesses and four million Government school students, Amazon's top executive said. The company, in a statement, said that during his meeting with the PM, Jassy reiterated Amazon's long-term commitment to India and announced plans to invest an additional \$13 billion to expand AI and cloud infrastructure in the country by 2030.

The latest investment pledge positions Amazon as one of the largest global AI and cloud infrastructure investors in India, the US-headquartered e-commerce giant added. "The investment will expand AWS data centre capacity in Mumbai and Hyderabad, giving startups, enterprises and government organisations access to custom AI chips, managed AI services, secure and reliable cloud technologies and developer tools to innovate faster, scale rapidly, and serve customers globally," according to Amazon. With



PM Narendra Modi during a meeting with Amazon CEO Andy Jassy PTI

this, Amazon's cumulative investments in India exceed \$88 billion between 2010 and 2030. Just six months back, Amazon had announced \$35 billion in new India investments.

"The latest investment makes Amazon one of the largest global AI and cloud infrastructure investors in India, in addition to being the largest foreign investor in India, the largest enabler of e-commerce exports and one of the biggest job creators in the country," Amazon said.

The company plans to launch more than 20 new fulfilment centres and over 100 new last-mile delivery stations this year, bringing faster and reliable deliveries to customers nationwide, especially in tier 3 and 4 cities, the statement said. Amazon has also announced 'Sammaan', a programme focused on the welfare of tens of thousands of delivery associates powering its e-commerce and quick commerce network.

Since its launch in India, Amazon has digitised 12 million small businesses, enabled over \$20 billion in cumulative e-commerce exports, and supported 2.8 million jobs. Amazon has also trained over 10 million Indians on cloud skills.

"Through 2030, the company plans to invest a total of \$48 billion to expand and support its businesses in

India. In line with the government priorities, Amazon will continue its strong focus on AI-led digitisation, export growth, and job creation," according to the statement.

The Amazon top honcho said the company has seen strong growth in India, especially across e-commerce, AI, and cloud businesses.

"As we grow Amazon in India, our business priorities continue to align with India's priorities of democratising access to AI, digitising small businesses, creating jobs, and enabling exports. We are investing over \$48 billion in the coming five years to meet the strong demand across our business in India and to help the country achieve these priorities," Jassy said.

"We are inspired by Prime Minister Modi's vision of a Viksit and Atmanirbhar Bharat, and we are committed to being a long-term partner in India's growth story."

On the expanded investment pool, the company said the fresh investment commitment will help expand and support AI and cloud infrastructure across the two regions in Mumbai and Hyderabad. "Both AWS regions enable customers to securely store their data within India and give them access to the world's most advanced AI and cloud technology, including high-perfor-

COMMITMENTS ANNOUNCED BY GLOBAL CEOS, COMPANIES

Feb 18, 2026 — Google: \$15 billion

Google announced a five-year \$15 billion AI infrastructure plan, including subsea connectivity, data centres, cloud capacity and AI skilling in India

Mar 9, 2026 — ABB: \$75 million

ABB announced a \$75 million investment in India to expand manufacturing and R&D capabilities across critical industrial segments

Jun 5, 2026 — AirTrunk: \$30 billion

Australia's AirTrunk announced plans to invest \$30 billion in India to build 5 GW of data centre capacity by 2030

Jun 17, 2026 — CPP Investments: ₹7,000 cr

Canada Pension Plan Investment Board committed up to ₹7,000 crore with CtrIS Datacenters to expand India's digital infrastructure and hyperscale data centre capacity

Jun 18, 2026 — Saint-Gobain: ₹1 billion

Saint-Gobain announced another ₹1 billion investment in India over the next five years, calling India one of its fastest-growing markets

Jun 25, 2026 — Amazon: \$48 billion

Amazon CEO Andy Jassy met PM Narendra Modi and announced plans to take Amazon's India investment commitment to \$48 billion by 2030, including fresh AI and cloud infrastructure expansion

mance Trainium chips and AWS's leading inference engine Amazon Bedrock," Amazon said. The e-commerce giant underlined that hundreds of thousands of Indian enterprises, startups, and government agencies are already using AWS to build, train, and deploy AI workloads at production scale, including National Health Authority, Government e-Marketplace, Apollo Tyres, Delhivery, Physics Wallah, Axis Bank, and HDFC Bank.

"From day one, AWS has built its infrastructure so customers have full control over where their data resides, who can access it, and how it's secured," the company pointed out.

Amazon.in has over 100 million customers and more

than 1.7 million sellers, it said, adding that the company is seeing 85 per cent of new customers and over 65 per cent of orders from tier 2 and 3 cities.

In Bengaluru on Wednesday, Jassy had announced the company's plans to expand its ultra-fast delivery service, Amazon Now, to more than 300 Indian cities and to build what Amazon describes as the country's largest "delivery in minutes" network.

Amazon Now's aggressive expansion comes at a time when India's quick commerce market has emerged as one of the fastest-growing segments of the country's digital economy, driven by rising demand for ultra-fast deliveries and changing consumer preferences.

Nation Focus



GEHLOT CRITICISES BJP OVER CORRUPTION, LAW AND ORDER

Alleging that Rajasthan was witnessing deteriorating governance, rising corruption and a decline in law and order, former chief minister Ashok Gehlot on Thursday said the Congress is prepared to extend moral support to the BJP Government if it seeks the Opposition's cooperation to improve the situation. Interacting with journalists here after concluding his 3-day visit to his hometown, Gehlot claimed that corruption has spread from villages to Jaipur city, and alleged that the spurt in the incidents of murder, rape and dacoity reflects the State's deteriorating administrative condition. (PTI)



CONSTRUCTION BEGINS ON 4TH OF 6 NEXT-GEN PATROL VESSELS

Work has begun on the construction of the fourth of the six next-generation offshore patrol vessels (OPVs) for the Indian Coast Guard, with a keel-laying ceremony held in Mumbai on Thursday, officials said. This ship, with modern machinery and state-of-the-art systems, is being indigenously designed, developed and constructed by Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Ltd (MDL), in line with the Government's vision of Aatmanirbhar Bharat. "This initiative marks a key milestone in ICG's ongoing efforts to enhance its operational capabilities and bolster coastal security, thereby strengthening the nation's strategic autonomy," the defence ministry said. The keel-laying ceremony of the fourth of the six next-generation OPVs, being built by MDL for the Coast Guard, took place in Mumbai on June 25, it said in a statement. The ceremony was attended by senior officials of the ICG and MDL. (PTI)

AI operates first flight from Varanasi under hub and spoke model



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Varanasi

Air India on Thursday operated the first flight from Varanasi under the Hub and Spoke model, which seeks to provide seamless connectivity between smaller cities and overseas destinations, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi saying the initiative will bring India's regions closer to global opportunities.

After inaugurating the first flight, Civil Aviation Minister K Rammoan Naidu said such services will commence from six more cities in six weeks.

The model that seeks to make India a global aviation hub will enable seamless connectivity between Tier-II and Tier-III airports with international destinations.

Passengers arriving from smaller cities will be routed through major hub airports such as Delhi for onward international connections.

The inaugural 'Easy Connect' flight AI1111 departed from Varanasi at 9.30 am and landed at Delhi at around 10.50 am, and further passengers would be connected to nine international destinations, including Dubai, Colombo, Jeddah and Phuket.

In a message on Thursday, Modi said the Hub and Spoke international flights model would reduce travel time for passengers, as well as bring regions of India closer to global opportunities.

Modi said better international connectivity creates new opportunities for trade, tourism, investment, education and business.

During Emergency, Congress strangled democracy to save power, says Pradhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Thursday said that June 25, 1975, was the 'darkest day' in the history of Indian democracy when the then Congress Government attacked the very spirit of the Constitution, democratic institutions, and civil liberties to retain power.

Pradhan was addressing a gathering at an event to mark the 51st anniversary of the Emergency.

He emphasised that India is not just a geographical entity but a civilisation with thousands of years of cultural heritage and democratic traditions. He noted that India's democratic ethos is deeply rooted in its civilisational values, which is why it is often referred to as the "Mother of Democracy."

According to Pradhan, the framers of the Constitution, following India's Independence, envisioned a nation where the people would hold the supreme power, and governance would operate within the framework of the Constitution.

However, by declaring the Emergency on June 25, 1975, the then Congress



Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, during the Samvidhan Hatya Diwas, marking the 51st anniversary of the Emergency's imposition in Chandigarh PTI

government sought to suppress these democratic ideals, he said. Pradhan said that during the Emergency, freedom of expression was restricted, the press faced censorship, opposition leaders were imprisoned, and countless activists endured severe hardship and persecution.

Highlighting that the fundamental rights of citizens were suspended, and an atmosphere of fear was created throughout the country, Pradhan accused the then Congress Government of misusing the State machinery to stifle political Opposition.

He stressed that democracy is not just about holding elections; it involves protecting individual liberty, freedom of

thought, and upholding constitutional values.

As the world looks toward India with hope and confidence, Pradhan emphasised the importance of ensuring that the younger generation understands this dark chapter in the nation's history.

Senior BJP leader and former MP Satya Pal Jain shared his personal experiences from the Emergency period, accusing the then Congress Government of misusing the entire administrative apparatus to quell political dissent.

He added that the suffering of those imprisoned extended beyond themselves, significantly impacting their families, who faced severe economic and social struggles.

Railway allows javelins, bulky equipment except pole-vaults

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Sportspersons will now be allowed to carry javelins and bulky sports equipment on trains even if these items exceed the prescribed dimensions. However, pole-vault poles have been excluded from the relaxation.

In a recently issued circular, the railway ministry made provisions for the carriage of oversized and fragile sports equipment of non-standard dimensions in trains.

The relaxation followed reports highlighting the difficulties faced by sportspersons in carrying equipment



of non-standard dimensions while travelling by train.

The circular states that javelins and other bulky sports equipment may be booked and carried in the available luggage space of

trains on a priority basis, subject to payment of the applicable freight charges.

"It shall also be ensured that the above sports equipment shall be transported in the available luggage space of

Operation Sindoor showcased indigenous defence strength, says President Murmu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Asserting that a self-reliant country is better equipped to maintain its economic stability, President Droupadi Murmu on Thursday said that Operation Sindoor highlighted how indigenous defence capabilities are integral to enhancing operational readiness and strategic effectiveness of a nation.

Addressing a group of officer trainees of Military Engineer Services (MES), who had called on the president at the Rashtrapati Bhavan here, she said in today's world, marked by conflicts and geopolitical tensions, self-reliance has become a strategic necessity for nations. A self-reliant country is better equipped to maintain its economic stability and undertake developmental priorities during times of crisis, Murmu said.

"This was evident during Operation Sindoor, which highlighted how indigenous defence capabilities, advanced technology, and a robust domestic industrial base are integral to enhancing operational readiness and strategic effectiveness of a nation," the president said, addressing the officer trainees of 2023 and 2024 batches. Operation Sindoor



President Droupadi Murmu greets the officer trainees of Military Engineer Services during a meeting at Rashtrapati Bhavan in New Delhi on Thursday PTI

was carried out by the country's defence forces, targeting terrorist and military facilities in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir from May 7-10, 2025.

This operation was carried out in retaliation for the April 22, 2025, terror attack in Jammu and Kashmir's Pahalgam in which 26 people, mostly tourists, were killed in cold blood by three Pakistani terrorists.

Murmu said that the world today is facing climate change and various environmental challenges. "In this scenario, sustainable development is no longer an option, but a necessity," she said.

The president asked them to adopt green technologies, conserve energy and water, increase green cover, minimise waste, and inte-

grate sustainability into every aspect of their work.

"Infrastructure that is resilient, efficient, and environmentally responsible will not only serve the needs of today but also safeguard the interests of future generations," Murmu said.

She said that the MES forms the backbone of defence infrastructure in our country and by developing and maintaining strategic installations, it plays a vital role in strengthening the operational capabilities of our armed forces.

Murmu said that in recent years, the country has seen the increasing participation of women in every field, including in the armed forces and defence establishments.

"Across the Army, Navy, Air Force, and supporting

organisations, women are breaking barriers and excelling in roles that were once considered beyond their reach. Their professionalism, leadership, courage, and commitment have enriched our institutions and strengthened our national defence," the president said, and hoped to "see women officers of MES in the upcoming batches". A diverse and inclusive workforce not only reflects the values of our Constitution but also enhances organisational effectiveness and innovation, she said.

Addressing the officers, Murmu said their efforts should contribute not only to a strong and secure India but also to a clean, green, and sustainable India.

कार्यालय कृषि उपज मंडी समिति नीमच, जिला-नीमच (म.प्र.)

क्रमांक/ मंडी/नि./26-27/240 नीमच, दिनांक 25.06.2026

-//निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना -//

प्रमुख अभियंता म.प्र. लोक निर्माण विभाग में उपयुक्त (एकीकृत पंजीयन प्रणाली) पंजीकृत निविदाकारों से प्रतिशत दर आधार पर सिस्टम निविदाएँ क्रमांक 2026_MPSAM_517485_1, के अंतर्गत ऑनलाईन निविदाएँ दिनांक 29.06.2026 समय 10.30 से दिनांक 20.07.2026 को साय 5:30 बजे तक आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा प्रपत्र एवं अन्य जानकारी निविदाकारों को म.प्र. शासन के ई-निविदा के पोर्टल <http://www.mptenders.gov.in/nicgep/app> पर प्राप्त होगी, एवं उक्त निविदा से संबंधित समस्त जानकारी मंडी बोर्ड के पोर्टल <http://www.mpmmandiboard.gov.in> पर भी अवलोकनीय होगी।

नोट: आवश्यक होने पर उपरोक्त निविदा सूचना से संबंधित किसी भी प्रकार के संशोधन सूचना अथवा अन्य जानकारी केवल उपरोक्तानुसार पोर्टल पर ही प्रदर्शित किया जावेगा।

सचिव
कृषि उपज मण्डी समिति, नीमच
जिला-नीमच (म.प्र.)

भारसाधक अधिकारी
कृषि उपज मण्डी समिति, नीमच
जिला-नीमच (म.प्र.)

States Focus



INDIA OFFERS ASSISTANCE TO EARTHQUAKE-HIT VENEZUELA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday expressed sadness over the devastation caused by the earthquakes in Venezuela, and said India stands ready to extend all possible assistance to the Latin American country. Powerful earthquakes struck off the coast of Venezuela on Wednesday evening, leaving at least 32 people dead and 700 injured. "Deeply saddened by the devastation caused by the severe earthquakes in Venezuela. On behalf of the people of India, I extend our heartfelt condolences to the Government and people of Venezuela, especially to the families who have lost their loved ones," Modi said in a post on social media. The PM said India prays for the speedy recovery of those injured and stand in solidarity with all those affected during this difficult time. "India stands ready to extend all possible assistance," he added.



VP ADMINISTERS OATH TO 10 NEWLY ELECTED RS MEMBERS

Rajya Sabha Chairman CP Radhakrishnan on Thursday administered oath of office to ten newly elected members of the Upper House. The lawmakers took the oath in the main chamber of the Rajya Sabha. Among the new members sworn in were four members from Andhra Pradesh, two from Jharkhand, one each from Arunachal Pradesh, Gujarat, Odisha, and Tamil Nadu. Five newly-elected members took the oath in Hindi, one in English, one in Tamil, and three in Telugu. The newly inducted members were Sana Sathish Babu (TDP), Vijay Chintakayala (TDP), Bhashyam Rama Krishna (TDP) and Lingamaneni Ramesh (JSP) (all from Andhra Pradesh), Tai Tagak (BJP) from Arunachal Pradesh, Rajesh Parmanad Shukla (BJP) from Gujarat, Parimal Nathwani (IND) and Baidyanath Ram (JMM), both from Jharkhand, Debashish Samantaray (BJP) from Odisha and Praveen Chakravarty (INC) from Tamil Nadu.

West Bengal Govt to unveil new policies before Durga Puja, says Finance Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The West Bengal Government will unveil a series of policies, including an investment promotion framework, before Durga Puja festivities, as part of efforts to accelerate economic growth, Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta said on Thursday.

Dasgupta made the remarks while replying to the discussion on the state Budget in the Assembly. "In the next three months, before Durga Puja, we will present an investment promotion framework, an incentive policy and a startup policy," he said.



Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta

The minister said dedicated policy for women entrepreneurs would also be introduced to encourage greater participation in business and enterprise.

A cloud kitchen policy will be introduced, too, to encourage the women entrepreneurs, Dasgupta said.

The other policies will be on a global capability centre (GCC), an AI mission, and in addition, the Government plans to formulate a policy for sportspersons, he said.

Dasgupta said the absence of some of these policy frameworks had affected the state's ability to attract investments, including in the information technology sector.

The minister said the budget should be viewed as a roadmap signalling the direction in which the Government intends to take the state economy.

BJP seeks Congress apology on 51 years of emergency

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Thursday attacked the Congress on the 51st anniversary of the Emergency, with party president Nitin Nabin saying it was a dark chapter in the history of Indian democracy and the Congress has not yet offered an "unconditional apology" to the nation for it.

In a series of social media posts in Hindi, Nabin said the Emergency was a dark chapter in the history of Indian democracy, during which an attempt was made to "crush the soul of the Constitution".

"On June 12, 1975, the Allahabad High Court had declared the election of the then prime minister, Indira Gandhi, illegal. After this, priority was given not to national interest but to the interest of power," the BJP chief said.

"To save the chair of one person, the freedom of the entire country was held hostage, and an attempt



was made to crush the constitutional values and democratic dignity established by Baba Saheb Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar," he added. Nabin said the Congress constantly blames the Modi Government for various reasons, including its election losses.

"If Parliament doesn't function, it is the Government's fault. If Congress is defeated in elections, it is the system's fault.

"If the public doesn't support (Congress), it is the institutions' fault. The

biggest question is why the party that invokes the Constitution has not yet offered an unconditional apology to the country for the Emergency," the BJP chief said. If there truly was concern for the Constitution, the first thing would have been to seek forgiveness from the country for the crime of murdering democracy, he added.

Nabin alleged that for decades, attempts were made to erase the "dark chapter of the Emergency" from the nation's collec-

tive memory. Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership, however, justice has been done to history with the decision to observe June 25 as 'Samvidhan Hatya Diwas', the BJP president said.

"Samvidhan Hatya Diwas not only reminds us of the past but also reinforces our resolve to remain ever-vigilant and dedicated to protecting the Constitution, democracy and civil liberties," Nabin said.

"This day reminds us of the importance of freedom and the need to safeguard democratic values. We pay tribute to all those who fought to protect democracy, even amidst trying circumstances," the BJP chief.

Addressing a press conference at the BJP headquarters, senior party leader Ravi Shankar Prasad slammed the Congress for the imposition of the Emergency during its rule and said all the excuses made by the opposition party to justify it are "absolutely baseless".

Emergency tried to crush democracy, says Himanta



TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday said the Emergency imposed in 1975 was an attempt to crush India's democratic values and civil liberties. Remembering the period, Sarma paid tribute to all the "brave warriors" who struggled to protect democracy.

"We remember that dark chapter in the history of Indian democracy, when in 1975 the Emergency was imposed in an attempt to crush the country's democratic values and civil liberties," he said in a social media post.

"Humble salutations to all the brave warriors who struggled to protect democracy," he added. In a programme organised by the BJP in the evening, Sarma honoured

"Loktantra Senanis" and said people must not let that dark chapter in the nation's history be forgotten.

"Just to cling on to power, the then Cong govt trampled upon the Constitution and converted the country into a jail," he said in another post. The Emergency was in force from June 25, 1975, to March 21, 1977, after it was proclaimed under Article 352 of the Constitution.

Since 2025, the Narendra Modi Government has observed June 25 as 'Samvidhan Hatya Diwas'.

A gazette notification issued in this regard said the Emergency was declared on June 25, 1975, and was followed by a "gross abuse of power" by the government of the day, with people subjected to excesses and atrocities.

Congress launches nationwide campaign against paper leaks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

The Congress on Thursday announced a 40-day nationwide "Chhatron Ki Gooni" campaign, to press for reforms in the examination system and highlight issues of paper leaks, examination irregularities and unemployment.

Addressing a press conference, Congress Working Committee member Rajeev Shukla, Punjab Congress president Amarinder Singh Raja Warring and Chandigarh Congress president HS Lucky said the campaign would begin on June 30 and continue till August 9.

The leaders informed that the campaign would be carried out



Congress Working Committee member Rajeev Shukla

across coaching centres, universities, hostels, libraries and other public places to engage with students and raise awareness about examination-related issues.

They alleged that repeated paper leaks and controversies surrounding competitive examinations and recruitment tests had shaken public confidence and affected millions of students and job aspirants across the country.

The Congress leaders noted that the campaign would focus on the alleged irregularities in national-level examinations, particularly the NEET-UG 2026 controversy, which they claimed exposed serious shortcomings in the examination system.

They also claimed that paper leaks had become an organised racket involving different stages of the examination process, including question paper preparation, print-

ing, transportation and examination centres. The party demanded the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan and called for an independent investigation into the alleged paper leak networks and their links with officials, contractors and other entities.

They accused the Centre of failing to prevent repeated examination scandals and said the issue affected not only students but also unemployed youth waiting for recruitment processes to be completed.

According to the Congress, grassroots activities under the campaign will include pamphlet distribution, corner meetings and direct outreach to students.

ED attaches ₹55 cr assets of Punjab minister Sanjeev Arora, linked entities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

The house-to-house enumeration exercise under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) 2026 of electoral rolls commenced across Punjab on Thursday, with 24,453 Booth Level Officers (BLOs) beginning visits to households.

The exercise, scheduled from June 25 to July 24, aims to cover more than 2.14 crore voters in Punjab, according to the Office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO).

Chief Electoral Officer Anindita Mitra filled her enumeration form on Thursday with her family members and urged citizens to cooperate with BLOs visiting their homes for the distribution and collection of forms. She noted that the first day of the exercise witnessed the successful distribution of enumeration forms across the State.

Mitra advised voters to keep a recent colour photograph ready, fill and sign the form, and hand it over to the BLO while retaining the second copy for future reference. She informed that if a house is locked, the BLO will leave the form and paste a sticker indicating the date of the next visit.

Govt considers revising AAY foodgrain entitlement to 7 kg per person

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government is considering shifting the Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY) foodgrain entitlement from a fixed 35 kg per household per month to 7 kg per person per month — capped at 35 kg — a move to address the "inequities" in food distribution among the country's poorest households and provide for more rational food grain allocation and better align entitlements with nutritional requirements.

The Department of Food and Public Distribution has proposed an amendment to the National Food Security

Act, 2013, and the Food Ministry has invited public comments on the National Food Security (Amendment) Bill, 2026, until July 13.

Under the National Food Security Act (NFSA), up to 75 per cent of the rural population and 50 per cent of the urban population — covering roughly two-thirds of India's population—are legally entitled to highly subsidised or free foodgrains.

The proposed changes seek to "remove intra-caste inequities and provide for a more equitable and rational allocation of foodgrains while aligning beneficiary entitlements more closely with household



nutritional requirements," says the draft Bill.

Under the current law, Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY) households, designated as the poorest of the poor and are legally entitled to receive 35 kg of foodgrains per family per month, the

Priority Households are entitled to 5 kg of foodgrains per person per month.

"The existing household-based entitlement under Antyodaya Anna Yojana, though intended as a protective measure for the most vulnerable families, results

in significant inequities depending upon the size of the household," the ministry said in a statement.

Under the proposed design, a two-member AAY household would receive 14 kg per month, while a family of five or more would be entitled to the existing ceiling of 35 kg.

Smaller households may see little change in absolute terms; larger ones stand to gain as allocation would scale with family size.

The Government has framed the amendment as part of its broader push to strengthen food and nutritional security through a "human life cycle approach"

— ensuring access to adequate quantities of quality food at affordable prices, in line with the objectives of the National Food Security Act, 2013. Currently, rice and wheat are distributed for free to both priority households and AAY.

In Delhi, the State Government has cancelled nearly 7.72 lakh invalid and ineligible ration cards following a recent welfare audit and verification drive. This massive clean-up exercise freed up approximately 7.72 lakh ration card slots intended for the National Food Security Act (NFSA) and other public distribution benefits.

LG chairs meeting in Pahalgam, reviews preparations for Amarnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Thursday chaired a high-level meeting in Pahalgam and reviewed preparations for the Shri Amarnath Yatra-2026, which starts on 3rd July.

The Lieutenant Governor held a comprehensive review of all key sectors, including logistics, lodging, healthcare facilities, sanitation, power and water supply, availability of civic amenities, road connectivity, RFID cards, functioning on joint control rooms, track maintenance and widening works, construction of footbridges, setting up of langars, creation of holding areas, traffic management and security arrangements.

Deputy Commissioner Anantnag briefed the meeting on the overall preparations being made for the smooth and hassle-free conduct of the annual pilgrimage.

Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP), Anantnag, delivered a detailed presentation on the multi-layered security framework and the comprehensive measures in place to ensure pilgrim safety along the entire route.

Speaking to the media persons, the Lieutenant Governor said, "The Jammu Kashmir Administration, Police,



Security Forces, Government of India, and the Shrine Board have finalised all preparations to ensure a safe and spiritually enriching experience for the devotees of Baba Amarnath. Residents and all stakeholders are eager to welcome pilgrims arriving from across the nation.

During the review meeting, LG directed the authorities to ensure safety, and weather-based evacuation protocols must be established alongside the strategic deployment of Mountain Response Teams (MRTs) at critical intervals. Furthermore, all transit tents must pass rigorous quality inspections and be equipped with functional fire extinguishers.

On the tracks, real-time crowd analysis must be utilised to identify and clear choke points, while robust

traffic management plans and designated parking zones must be enforced to prevent congestion and guarantee the uninterrupted transportation of essential supplies," the Lieutenant Governor directed the officials.

The meeting was attended by Mandeep K Bhandari, Principal Secretary to Lieutenant Governor and CEO Amarnathji Shrine Board; Shahid Iqbal Choudhary, Commissioner Secretary, Youth Services and Sports Department and Nodal Officer for Pahalgam Axis; Anshul Garg, Divisional Commissioner Kashmir; VK Birdi, IGP Kashmir; M Suleman Choudhary, IGP Traffic J&K; Bilal Mohiuddin Bhat, Deputy Commissioner, Anantnag; Amod Nagpure Ashok, SSP Anantnag and senior officers of civil administration, police and security forces.

NH-44 connectivity restored before Yatra: Gadkari

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Ahead of the beginning of the Amarnath Yatra from July 3, the Union Minister for Road Transport and Highways, Nitin Gadkari, on Thursday said the flood-damaged bridges over the Ravi River and Sehar Khad near Kalibari on the Jammu-Srinagar National Highway (NH-44) have been restored, re-establishing a vital road link between Punjab and Jammu and Kashmir.

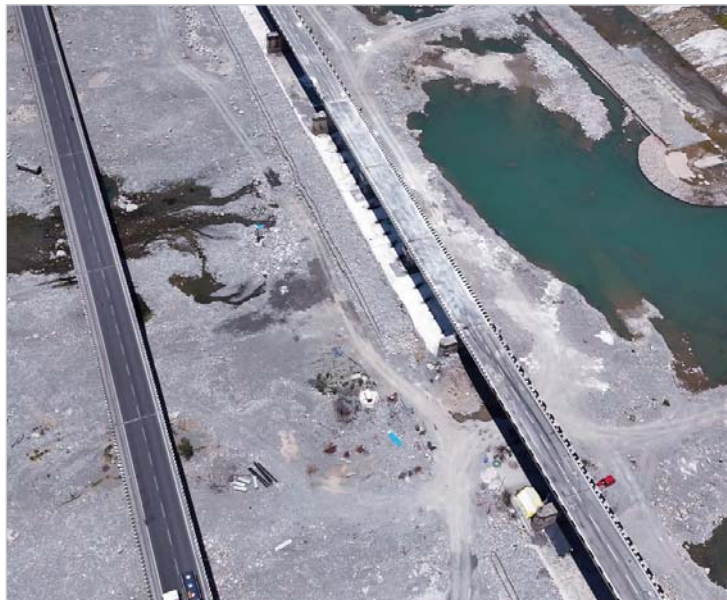
The Union Minister said the restored infrastructure would also provide a major boost to travel during the upcoming annual Amarnath Yatra by improving connectivity along the route.

In a post on X, Gadkari said the bridges had sustained extensive damage during last year's flash floods, severely disrupting traffic along the strategically important highway. He said the restoration work was taken up on priority in view of the highway's strategic and economic significance and was completed within the stipulated timeline.

"The reopening of these bridges will ensure seamless connectivity and facilitate the smooth movement of passengers and freight," the minister said.

In the Kashmir valley, the Gondola services were resumed in Gulmarg, a month after a technical snag forced the closure of the services.

On May 25, the army, police, NDRF and SDRF launched a rescue operation after the Gulmarg Cable Car services developed a techni-



cal snag, leaving more than 300 tourists and local guides stranded mid-air.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah oversaw the official resumption of the Gulmarg Gondola service, marking the full restoration of its operations. Omar said the services were restarted only after the French firm Puma certified repair work. On the other hand, the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) also restored road connectivity between Gulabgarh and Machail in Jammu and Kashmir's Kishtwar district with the operationalisation of a 140-foot Bailey bridge at cloudburst-hit Chishoti.

The bridge was virtually inaugurated by White Knight Corps

Commander Lt Gen P K Mishra on Thursday, in the presence of Jammu and Kashmir Assembly leader of opposition and Padder-Nagseni MLA Sunil Kumar Sharma, officials said.

The triple-double reinforced Bailey bridge replaces the earlier structure, which was washed away in a devastating cloudburst on August 14, 2025, severing the only road link to the remote Machail region, they said.

A cloudburst struck Chisoti village, the gateway to the Machail Mata temple in Kishtwar district, on August 14 last year, killing 65 people, mostly pilgrims, while more than 30 persons are still missing.

DRDO hands over FOC for Netra AEW&C system to Indian Air Force

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) has achieved a significant milestone with the handing over of the Final Operational Clearance (FOC) certificate of the Indigenous 'Netra' Airborne Early Warning and Control (AEW&C) system to the Indian Air Force (IAF), the defence ministry said here on Thursday.

Giving details, it said the system has been indigenously developed through close collaboration among the IAF, DRDO, and associated industries to significantly enhance airborne surveillance, situational awareness and battle management capability. It represents a landmark achievement in India's journey towards self-reliance in advanced aerospace & defence technologies. The Initial Operational Clearance (IOC) was given in 2017.

The ceremony was presided over by the Deputy Chief of the Air Staff Air Marshal Awadhesh Kumar



DRDO's indigenously developed NETRA Airborne Early Warning and Control (AEW&C) system receives its Final Operational Clearance (FOC) during a ceremony at Centre for Airborne Systems (CABS) in Bengaluru on Thursday

Bharti in Bengaluru, Karnataka on Thursday.

Former Chief of the Air Staff Air Chief Marshal RKS Bhadauria (Retd), former DRDO Chairman Dr S Christopher, serving and retired senior officers of IAF, Outstanding Scientist & Director Centre for Air Borne System (CABS)P Santhya, Outstanding Scientist and Chief Executive (Airworthiness) APVS Prasad, Scientist 'C' & Head NETRA FOC AS Kumaran, other senior

officials of DRDO, and industry partners attended the event.

In his address, the Deputy Chief of the Air Staff appreciated the FOC of indigenous Netra AEW&C. He spoke about the operational utilisation and reliability of the system during Operation Sindoor and Balakot strikes.

He reiterated the importance of indigenous technologies which offer the services the flexibility to adapt the system to the evolving

war scenario by undertaking modifications. He lauded the synergy among DRDO, IAF and the industry which has defined the success of the programme.

Distinguished Scientist and Director General of Aeronautics Cluster of DRDO Dr K Rajalakshmi Menon narrated the successful journey of NETRA. She brought out the challenges faced and the decisions taken that enabled to achieve the programme objectives and deliver the operationally capable system to IAF. She emphasised the importance of System Engineering and how it helped in the planning and execution of flight-tests.

The successful induction of the Netra AEW&C system into operational service reflects the DRDO's commitment to indigenisation, innovation, and capability enhancement of the Defence Services.

The programme stands as a shining example of synergy between operational users, scientific agencies, and defence production establishments.

Viral video row: BJP seeks Bhagwant Mann's resignation over 'mask theory' remarks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ludhiana

The Punjab unit of the BJP on Thursday demanded the resignation of Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, alleging that he had repeatedly changed his stand on a controversial video and was misleading the public.

Punjab BJP general secretary Anil Sareen said the people of the state no longer had faith in the chief minister's statements. He claimed that different explanations had been given for the video over time, including that it was AI-generated, a deep-fake and most recently linked to a "mask theory".

Mann finds himself in the midst of a raging controversy after the Akal Takht earlier this month declared him "guru dokhi" (anti-guru) and "Khalsa panth virodhi" (anti-Khalsa panth) over a video purportedly showing a man resembling him indulging in objectionable activities with pictures of Sikh gurus and slain militant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale.

Sareen questioned whether

the forensic reports cited by ministers and spokespersons of the AAP Government to term the video fake were genuine or whether the latest explanation should be accepted as the truth.

He alleged that serious questions had already been raised over the forensic reports obtained from Gurugram and claimed there were allegations that fake reports had been prepared with the involvement of Punjab Police officials.

The BJP leader also asked why the video had not been examined by an accredited independent forensic laboratory for eight months if the chief minister was certain that it was fake.

Accusing the Mann Government of misusing power and attempting to conceal the truth, Sareen said the chief minister should take moral responsibility for the controversy and resign from his post.

He alleged that the Government's changing versions had further eroded public trust and raised doubts over its credibility.



Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann addressing a press conference, in Mohali, Punjab on Thursday

Facing mounting criticism from the opposition over a controversial video, Mann on Thursday reiterated that he was not in that video and claimed that the person seen in the objectionable clip was wearing a mask resembling his face.

The matter stems from the Akal Takht summoning Mann in January this year for allegedly making comments on "Guru ki Golak" (gurdwara donation box) and indulging in "objectionable activities" with the pictures of the Sikh Gurus and slain militant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale in the purported video clip.

Addressing the media in Mohali on Thursday, Mann

showed a purported video clip to claim that the person seen in the controversial video was wearing a mask which resembles his face.

On January 15, when Mann had appeared before the Akal Takht in Amritsar, he had submitted that the video was fake or AI-generated and that the 'Singh Sahib' (Sikh Clergy) could get its forensic examination done from any lab in the country.

On June 18, the chief minister reiterated that it was not him in the objectionable video and claimed that some actor was imitating him. He cited reports of two labs showing that the man in the alleged objectionable video was someone else.

Contactless passenger health self-declaration portal launched amid Ebola outbreak

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Civil Aviation Ministry and Delhi International Airport Limited on Thursday launched an upgraded and contactless passenger health self-declaration portal to strengthen public health surveillance at points of entry in response to the Ebola disease outbreak in parts of Africa.

Developed in collaboration with the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Union health ministry, the AIR SUVIDHA 2.0 portal enables international arriving passengers to submit a mandatory online health self-declaration covering 21-day travel history, exposure history and related symptoms, if any, prior to immigration clearance.

The portal enables real-



time data sharing with the Airport Health Officer, Bureau of Immigration, IDSP and State Surveillance Officers, enables swift identification and referral of at-risk travellers while keeping the arrival experience seamless and contactless, with no physical forms to fill on landing, the Health ministry said in a statement.

The Airsuvidha Self Declaration Form (SDF) can be completed 24 hours in advance before arrival to India.

"Passengers are requested to fill the forms before boarding of the flight, during web check-in for swift clearance on arrival and only required to show the downloaded SDF at the International Travel Health Desk or Immigration counter," the statement said.

The launch of the portal follows the WHO's declaration of the Ebola/Bundibugyo Virus Disease outbreak in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Uganda as a public health emergency of international concern on May 17 under the International Health Regulations (IHR) 2005.

The current outbreak has been confirmed as Bundibugyo Virus Disease (BVD), and countries bordering Congo and Uganda, including South Sudan, have been assessed as high-risk for transmission.

Ex-bureaucrat Sujata Karthikeyan joins BJD, inducted by Patnaik

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

Former bureaucrat Sujata Rout Karthikeyan, wife of former Odisha chief minister Naveen Patnaik's close aide VK Pandian, formally joined the BJD on Thursday. Patnaik announced her induction after a meeting at Sankha Bhawan, the party headquarters here.

"I would like to welcome Sujata Rout to the BJD. She will be joining the party as a simple member. She has been an IAS officer and held several important positions, including her last assignment where she looked after many women of our state," Patnaik said. "I am sure, as time passes, she will get used to her new position. She will learn to lead people, particularly



women," he added.

Amid speculation that Sujata could eventually take over the reins of the party, Patnaik asserted that he would continue to lead the BJD in the next elections. "I would like to repeat again for the information of the media and all other people that, of course, I will lead the BJD in the next elections. I want to make it very clear," he said.

Sujata, a native of Kendrapara district, said she would work sincerely

for the people of the state. "I have availed opportunities to serve the people of Odisha for 24 years under the leadership of Naveen Patnaik. Today, I got the same opportunity again to serve the people of Odisha under his leadership," she told reporters after joining the party.

"I will work for the people of Odisha with sincerity and dedication, with the blessings of Lord Jagannath, party leaders and millions of BJD workers," she added.

An IAS officer of the 2000 batch, Sujata resigned from the civil services on March 13, 2025. She is widely credited with expanding Mission Shakti, the women's empowerment programme of the previous BJD Government.

Rahul Gandhi expresses regret in Shivraj's son defamation case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jabalpur

Congress MP Rahul Gandhi has filed an application before the Madhya Pradesh High Court expressing regret for his allegedly defamatory statement about Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan's son Kartikeya Singh.

Kartikeya Singh had filed a defamation complaint in a Bhopal court against the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha. Gandhi's application, filed by his lawyer on Wednesday, said his statement was not related to Singh.

In the defamation complaint lodged in the Bhopal court for cases against MPs-MLAs, Kartikeya Singh alleged that during an election rally in Jhabua in 2018, Gandhi mentioned his name while referring to the Panama Papers leak scandal, thus



damaging his reputation.

The court issued a summons to Gandhi for personal appearance, following which the Congress leader moved the HC seeking to quash the summons as well as the defamation case. Justice Pramod Kumar Agarwal will hear Gandhi's petition on Thursday.

The petitioner on Wednesday produced the records of the lower court, as directed by the HC. Advocate Sankalp Kochhar represented the complainant before the high court.

Nominations open for Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar 2026, July 31 deadline



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government has invited nominations for the Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Bal Puraskar 2026, a national honour for children aged 5 to 18, with July 31 set as the last date for submission.

In a statement, the Ministry of Women and Child Development said the award recognises exceptional achievements by children in bravery, social service, environment, sports, art & culture, and Science & Technology, and celebrates their "exceptional resilience, courage, creativity, and indomitable spirit". The ministry said the award will be conferred by the President at a special ceremony in New Delhi on Veer Bal Diwas on December 26.

"The award serves to encourage and inspire young talent by acknowledging their contributions at the national level and motivating others to strive for excellence," it said.

According to the statement, children nominated for the award must be Indian citizens and residents of India, between five and 18 years of age as on July 31, 2026, and should not be previous recipients of the award in any category.

The act, incident or achievement must have occurred within two years of the nomination deadline of July 31, 2026, it added.



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma chairing a budget review meeting at Lok Sewa Bhawan, Dispur evaluating proposals for 13 departments for FY 2026-27

CITU backs July 1 protest for MGNREGA restoration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre of Indian Trade Unions (CITU) extends its fullest support, solidarity and active participation to the nationwide protest actions on July 1, 2026, called by the All India Agricultural Workers Union (AIAWU) and the joint platform of Rural Workers' Organisations.

The Government's decision to replace the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) with the VB-GRAMG Scheme from July 1, 2026, is a calculated attempt to dismantle the only statutory guarantee of 100 days of wage employment available to rural households.

"For the rural working class, MGNREGA is not a welfare programme; it is a legally enforceable right to work that provides wage security, strengthens the bargaining power of labour against landlordist and capitalist exploitation, and offers protection against chronic unemployment and distress," said General Secretary Elamaram Kareem. The attack on MGNREGA is



not confined to agricultural workers alone. It is an assault on the entire rural and urban unorganised working class. The weakening of rural employment inevitably depresses rural wages, intensifies distress migration and expands the pool of cheap labour available to urban employers.

CITU demands strengthening of MGNREGA through a legally guaranteed minimum of 200 days of employment per rural household, a substantial enhancement of wages linked to inflation, and the timely payment of wages as mandated by law. CITU further demands that the employment guarantee be expanded to cover every rural household seeking work and that a similar legally

guaranteed employment programme be introduced for urban workers.

CITU calls upon all its State Committees, federations and affiliated unions at the district, block and panchayat levels to mobilise industrial workers, unorganised workers and all sections of the working class to actively participate in the 1 July nationwide protests in solidarity with rural workers.

CITU will stand shoulder-to-shoulder with AIAWU and all organisations of rural workers to strengthen this united struggle and ensure that July 1 becomes a resounding assertion of the Right to Work, the dignity of labour and the unity of India's working people.

Govt expands QR code tracking to key drug categories to curb counterfeits

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government has expanded the ambit of the QR code-based track-and-trace mechanism to cover all antimicrobials, vaccines, anti-cancer medicines, and narcotic and psychotropic drugs, a move aimed at strengthening safeguards against counterfeit and substandard medicines.

The Union Health Ministry has notified amendments to the Drugs Rules, 1945, bringing these categories of medicines under Schedule H2, which mandates the use of bar codes or Quick Response (QR) codes for product identification and verification.



Under the amended provisions, manufacturers will be required to print or affix a barcode or QR code on the primary packaging label of the drug formulation, or on the secondary packaging where space constraints exist,

tification and verification. Under the amended provisions, manufacturers will be required to print or affix a barcode or QR code on the primary packaging label of the drug formulation, or on the secondary packaging where space constraints exist,

the ministry said. The code will enable authentication and verification of medicines through software applications across the supply chain.

According to the ministry, the QR code will contain key product information such as a unique product identifica-

Clinical Establishments Act: Centre replaces criminal penalties with administrative adjudication

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Union Health Ministry has notified amendments to the Clinical Establishments (Registration and Regulation) Act, 2010, replacing criminal penalties for certain procedural violations with an administrative adjudication mechanism as part of the Jan Vishwas reforms.

The amendments, notified on June 22, operationalise provisions of the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2026, which seeks to decriminalise minor procedural non-compliances across multiple central laws and promote trust-based governance.

The Jan Vishwas law, published in April this year, and aimed at reducing compliance burden and improving ease of doing business, amends provisions across 79 Central Acts administered by 23 ministries and departments. In the health sector, 35 provisions spread across five laws under the



Ministry of Health and Family Welfare have been modified, a statement by the ministry said.

Under the amended framework, the term "fine" has been replaced with "penalty" in Sections 40, 43 and 46 of the Act, shifting the enforcement framework from criminal prosecution to administrative adjudication.

Section 44 has been amended to introduce graded and proportionate penalties for contraventions committed by companies, ensuring that enforcement action is commensurate

with the nature and severity of the violation, the statement said.

Further, the adjudicating authority mechanism under Section 41 has been strengthened and its scope expanded to cover proceedings under sections 40, 43 and 44, facilitating transparent, efficient and accountable enforcement, it stated.

The amendments also provide for a structured adjudication process, including an opportunity for a hearing before the imposition of penalties, mechanisms for recovery

of penalties, and an appeal framework for aggrieved parties. "These measures are expected to encourage voluntary compliance, reduce unnecessary litigation, and ensure proportionate action in cases of minor procedural non-compliances, while maintaining regulatory oversight over clinical establishments," the statement said.

The notification implements the recommendations of the High-Level Committee on Regulatory Reforms and underscores the Government's commitment to fostering a transparent, efficient and citizen-centric regulatory framework.

By replacing criminal penalties for procedural lapses with a fair and balanced administrative mechanism, the reforms seek to improve the ease of doing business in the healthcare sector while preserving the highest standards of patient care, safety and accountability, the ministry said.



Editor's
TAKE

Why India faces a cybercrime emergency

The SC's intervention and PM Modi's recent remarks underscore a stark reality: cybercrime has emerged as a pressing challenge of our times

For years, cybercrime in India was not taken seriously – yet another crime that could be easily dealt with. But the menace has now emerged as multi-headed hydra that has siphoned off millions of rupees and even forced individuals to lock themselves in their own homes as prisoners – digital arrest and phishing is no longer minor crimes they can wreck lives and the worst part it is very difficult to nab the culprits. But not any more, that comfortable distance has collapsed.

The Prime Minister has reviewed digital-arrest scams at a PRAGATI meeting and pushed states to operationalise the e-Zero FIR system nationwide, while the Supreme Court continues to hear a suo motu case it opened after an elderly Ambala couple was swindled of over a crore rupees by fraudsters wielding forged court orders. When the executive and the judiciary independently decide the same menace deserves their direct attention, it is no longer a law-and-order footnote. It is a governance emergency.

The numbers explain the urgency. The apex court itself has described the scale of digital fraud – running into tens of thousands of crores – in language usually reserved for organised crime, not white-collar mischief. "Digital arrest" scams, where can artists impersonate police officers, CBI or ED officials, or even judges to terrify victims into transferring their life savings, have proliferated precisely because they exploit two things India has in abundance: rising digital penetration among people who weren't raised on it, and a fragmented enforcement architecture where a fraud originating in one state, routed through a server in another, and cashed out via mule accounts in a third, falls through every jurisdictional crack. The e-Zero FIR mechanism – which converts verified financial-fraud complaints filed through the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal into instant, borderless FIRs – is sound in design but has been adopted by barely a handful of states. Universal, urgent rollout, is the need of the hour.

This must be matched by genuine coordination between police, banks, telecom operators and platforms to freeze and trace money in real time, a standard operating procedure of the kind the Supreme Court has already asked the Centre to draft, and movement on international cooperation frameworks like the UN Cybercrime Convention, since most networks behind these scams operate from beyond India's borders. But no FIR portal, however fast, repairs damage already done. The first line of defence has to be the citizen. Verifying independently, hanging up, and reporting to 1930 or cybercrime.gov.in before money moves is the only real firewall available to most people, and it costs nothing.

The PM's intervention and the Court's scrutiny together create unusual institutional momentum. Squandering it through slow state-level implementation or public complacency would be the real failure. Cybercrime will not be defeated by outrage alone – it will be defeated by boring, relentless follow-through: faster FIRs, tighter bank-telecom coordination, and citizens who simply refuse to be afraid.

The path to freedom: Towards a drug-free India

Under the leadership of Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, Nasha Mukh Bharat Abhiyan (Drug-Free India Campaign) is not merely a government programme but a mass movement aimed at empowering India's youth power, family structure and national consciousness



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VERMA

As the entire world reflects on the challenge of substance use on the occasion of World Drug Day on June 26, for India, this issue emerges not merely as a social or health-related problem, but as a grave matter linked to the nation's future. Substance abuse weakens not just an individual, but the family, society, and ultimately the collective strength of the nation. It shatters the dreams of the youth, tears families apart, and hinders the pace of development.

Today, India has the largest youth population in the world. This youth power is the greatest asset of our 'Amrit Kaal'. If this power is channelled into education, skills, innovation, and nation-building, nothing can stop India from becoming a 'Vishwa Guru' but if the youth fall into the addiction of drugs, it will be a loss not just to one generation but to the future of the nation. Therefore, the fight against drugs is the responsibility of every Indian.

Under the leadership of Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, the Central Government has not viewed the problem of drug abuse merely as a matter of law and order or health; instead, it considers it a critical issue linked to the future of India's youth and the progress of the nation. On numerous occasions, he has called upon the youth, parents, and all sections of society from public platforms to remain aware of substance abuse. From 'Mann Ki Baat' to various national programmes, he has repeatedly emphasised that drug addiction becomes a problem not of an individual but of the entire family and society.

It is indeed a result of the Prime Minister's sensitivity that the fight against drug abuse has not been limited to government action alone but has been transformed into a campaign driven by public participation. The 'Nasha Mukh Bharat Abhiyan' (Drug-Free India Campaign) was launched under his guidance, through which the message of awareness has reached crores of youth, students, and citizens.

The Prime Minister firmly believes that India's youth power is the country's biggest asset, and it is our national responsibility to safeguard it from evils like drug abuse.

Launched on August 15, 2020, the 'Nasha Mukh Bharat Abhiyan' (Drug-Free India Campaign) has today become a people's movement. This campaign is not merely a government programme, but a medium for social awakening.



Millions of youths, students, women, teachers, and voluntary organisations have actively participated in this movement. From villages to metropolises, from schools to universities, and from digital platforms to community events, a widespread public awareness against substance abuse has emerged.

The government has taken decisive steps to curb the supply of substances. The Narcotics Control Bureau and various security agencies have dismantled numerous international smuggling networks through coordinated action. Surveillance at the borders has been strengthened, and strict action has been taken against organised crime. We must understand that drug trafficking is not merely a crime; it is often linked to anti-national activities and the financing of terrorism. Therefore, this struggle against drug trafficking is also a struggle for national security.

However, the success of any law or government campaign is ensured only when society becomes its driving force. India's greatest strength is its social and cultural consciousness. Our families, our values, our community traditions, and our social solidarity are the strongest shields against substance abuse.

Family is the first and most important unit of this fight. If parents maintain open communication with their children, become their friends, and keep a watchful eye on changes in their behaviour, the problem of substance abuse can be prevented at an early stage. Schools and colleges, too, will have to play an active role in fostering self-confidence, positive thinking, and a healthy lifestyle among the youth.

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The writer is Union Minister of
State Minister of State for
Consumer Affairs, Food and
Public Distribution of India

When the distinction between performance and authenticity blurs



SANJAY
CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

A recent WhatsApp communication on our society group, a few cryptic comments on my Facebook wall, and several recent premature deaths among people in their mid-fifties have made me pause and reflect. At first glance, the incidents appear unrelated.

A camp was organised by our newly elected governing body to facilitate certain services for residents. It was a good initiative with a few inevitable hiccups. Many appreciated the effort, while some expressed disappointment. One resident urged the President of the Residents' Welfare Association to personally address such irritants in future. What caught my attention, however, was the response of another well-meaning resident who rushed to defend the President while assigning blame to the committee member who organised the event. In corporate and public

life, leadership is often defined by the willingness to absorb criticism while sharing credit. In our increasingly polarised environment, criticism and defence seem to attach themselves not to actions but to individuals.

A few days later, a neighbour chose to respond to one of my articles on social media with comments such as 'writing for publicity' and 'pathetic'. Interestingly, in face-to-face interactions, he remains polite and courteous. I also found myself reflecting on the untimely deaths of several talented individuals in their fifties. People who still had much to contribute, both professionally and personally.

I do not suggest that these losses can be explained by technology or social media. They did, however, make me reflect on the various pressures that modern life places upon us, often in ways we scarcely recognise. For much of human history, there existed a degree of separation between our public and private selves. Most people encountered a limited version of us. Public life usually required us to present our better selves. Our frustrations, contradictions, and unguarded moments remained largely within private spaces shared with those closest to us.

Digital technology has altered that arrangement fundamentally. Public life now accompanies us throughout the day. Opinions are formed instantly, reactions are displayed immediately, and disagreements are preserved indefinitely. The audience is always present. Moments of genuine solitude have become increasingly rare. The distinction between public and private life has become increasingly blurred. What earlier generations experienced in private

is now expressed, displayed, and debated in public spaces. Perhaps this is why civility appears more fragile. The pace of communication has accelerated, while reflection has not. We have acquired unprecedented tools for expression, but not necessarily the habits of restraint, patience, and perspective required to use them wisely. Technology has amplified our voices; it has not always deepened our understanding.

In such an environment, the distinction between performance and authenticity also begins to blur. The person we present to the world and the person we are in our unguarded moments are expected to coexist continuously. Social approval, criticism, validation, and comparison have become part of everyday life in ways previous generations never experienced. Perhaps this is one of the defining psychological challenges of our age. Technology has connected us more extensively than ever before, but it has also made performance a permanent condition of modern life. We are simultaneously participants, audiences, and subjects. There may be value in rediscovering something that earlier generations understood instinctively: the importance of spaces where one is not performing, responding, or being observed. Spaces where one can simply be. While technology has succeeded in bringing the world closer to us, it may also have made it harder for us to find distance from the world.

The writer is a founder of Kala - Crazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator, and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Europe's heatwave is a warning to the world

The recent "Omega Heat" episode across Europe serves as a stark reminder of the growing dangers posed by climate change. The phenomenon, caused by an Omega Block atmospheric pattern, traps hot air over a region for extended periods, resulting in persistent and often deadly heatwaves. Scientists warn that rising global temperatures are making such extreme weather events more frequent, intense and prolonged. The consequences are already visible. Heat-related illnesses, deaths and wildfires have become recurring features of European summers. The United Nations has rightly described climate change as a public health emergency, underscoring the urgency of collective action. While Europe is currently in focus, countries like India are not immune. Similar atmospheric blocking patterns can intensify heatwaves across northern and central India, affecting millions of people. Improving early warning systems and investing in climate-resilient infrastructure have become essential.

However, adaptation alone is not enough. Meaningful reductions in greenhouse-gas emissions, rapid expansion of renewable energy and large-scale afforestation remain crucial to addressing the root causes. The lesson from Europe is clear: climate change is no longer a future threat but a present reality demanding immediate action.

R.S. NARULA | PATIALA

Building resilience through fitness

Rajyogi Brahma Kumar Nikunj Ji rightly points out that addiction cannot be tackled through awareness campaigns alone. Preventing substance abuse requires providing young people with meaningful pursuits that foster discipline, achievement and self-worth.

Alongside meditation and spiritual practices, progressive calisthenics can be a powerful tool in this effort. Unlike drugs, which offer temporary gratification, calisthenics rewards persistence and gradual progress. Each new milestone, whether mastering a push-up, pull-up or advanced bodyweight skill, builds confidence and generates a healthy sense of accomplishment. This process encourages self-discipline and resilience rather than dependency. Another advantage of calisthenics is its accessibility. It requires little or no equipment. Proper nutrition, adequate sleep and regular exercise become priorities, while harmful habits such as smoking and excessive drinking increasingly appear as barriers to progress. Most importantly, physical training provides a sense of purpose and direction. Activities that cultivate these qualities can help fill the void that often leads to substance abuse. India's fight against addiction must therefore focus not only on prevention but also on promoting healthy alternatives that strengthen both mind and body.

HARSH PAWARIA | ROHTAK

TN politics beyond electoral setbacks

Recent developments in Tamil Nadu politics have generated intense debate about the future of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the evolving political landscape of the state. Electoral setbacks, alliance realignments and the emergence of new political forces have naturally prompted questions about the party's long-term prospects.

However, it would be premature to conclude that the DMK is in terminal decline. The DMK remains one of Tamil Nadu's most influential political movements, with deep organisational roots and a legacy that extends beyond electoral cycles. Growing voter expectations, anti-incumbency sentiments and the rise of alternative political platforms are reshaping the state's political dynamics.

New entrants and opposition leaders are seeking to capitalise on this changing environment by presenting themselves as credible alternatives. For any political party, setbacks can serve either as a catalyst for renewal or a sign of deeper structural weaknesses. The coming years will reveal which path the DMK follows. Tamil Nadu's political future will be determined by the choices made by both leaders and voters alike.

JAYANTHY CK | CHENNAI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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AMMONIA LEAK: WHEN PROFIT COMES BEFORE HUMAN LIVES

The tragic ammonia leak in Tamil Nadu is yet another reminder of the unacceptable safety standards that persist in many industrial workplaces across India.

The deaths of workers and the hospitalisation of dozens more cannot be dismissed as an unfortunate accident. Such incidents are often the consequence of negligence, inadequate safety protocols and weak regulatory oversight. India's economic progress cannot be measured solely by rising industrial output and investment figures.

True development requires ensuring that every worker returns home safely at the end of the day. Unfortunately, migrant labourers and contract workers frequently bear the highest risks while possessing

the least bargaining power. Safety compliance is too often treated as a bureaucratic formality rather than a moral and legal obligation. The recurring pattern of industrial disasters points to systemic failures in enforcement.

Regulatory agencies must conduct rigorous inspections, impose strict penalties for violations and hold management accountable when preventable tragedies occur. Compensation alone cannot substitute for lost lives.

A nation aspiring to become a global manufacturing hub must place worker safety at the centre of its growth strategy. Economic prosperity loses its meaning when it is built upon avoidable human suffering.

VIJAYKUMAR H K | RAICHUR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Small modular reactors: Promise, progress and risks in the global energy transition

For countries such as India, where electricity demand continues to rise, SMRs offer intriguing possibilities but also significant uncertainties. The technology's future will depend not on its theoretical promise, but on whether governments and industry can demonstrate that it can be deployed safely, affordably and at scale.



RAJIB K MISHRA

As countries pursue ambitious decarbonisation goals while seeking reliable electricity supplies, Small Modular Reactors (SMRs) have emerged as one of the most discussed technologies in the global energy landscape. Promoted as a cleaner and more flexible alternative to conventional nuclear power plants, SMRs are increasingly being viewed as a potential complement to renewable energy systems. Yet despite growing policy enthusiasm and a long list of announced projects, commercial deployment remains limited, highlighting the importance of assessing both their promise and their risks.

SMRs are generally defined as nuclear reactors with a capacity of up to 300 MW per unit. Unlike conventional nuclear plants, which are typically built as large, site-specific projects, SMRs are designed for factory-based manufacturing and modular deployment. Their smaller size allows capacity to be added incrementally, reducing upfront capital requirements and potentially shortening construction timelines. Advocates argue that this approach could make nuclear energy more accessible and financially manageable, particularly for countries with moderate demand growth or constrained fiscal resources.

The growing interest in SMRs is closely linked to the changing structure of electricity systems. Rapid expansion of solar power has created a familiar challenge in many countries: abundant electricity during daylight hours but shortages during evening peak demand. Wind power, while valuable, remains variable. In this context, SMRs offer a source of firm, low-carbon electricity capable of operating around the clock and supporting grid stability when renewable generation is unavailable. Their role is therefore not to replace renewable energy but to complement it by providing reliable power when needed.

SMRs are also being explored as a tool for industrial decarbonisation and the repurposing of retiring coal-fired power plants. Many coal sites already possess transmission connectivity, cooling infrastructure and skilled workforces, making them attractive locations for future deployment. Beyond electricity generation, several advanced SMR designs can provide industrial process heat, district heating and hydrogen production, broadening their potential contribution to energy-transition strategies.

Technologically, SMRs encompass several reactor families. The most advanced are light-water reactors, based on technologies already used in conventional nuclear plants and therefore more familiar to regulators. Countries including the United States, Canada, the United Kingdom, France, China and South Korea are pursuing such designs. Other concepts include high-temperature gas-cooled reactors, which are well suited for industrial heat applications, and fast reactors that promise improved fuel efficiency and waste reduction but remain further from commercial maturity. A niche category of floating reactors has also emerged, led by Russia's pioneering efforts.

However, the gap between ambition and reality remains striking. As of the end of 2025, only two SMR projects worldwide are operating commercially for electricity generation.

The first is Russia's Akademik Lomonosov, a floating nuclear power plant located in the Arctic town of Pevek. Equipped with two small pressurised-water reactors producing about 70 MW of electricity, it has been supplying power and district heating since 2020. The project demonstrated that nuclear generation can be deployed in remote regions, but it also highlighted challenges related to marine safety, security and emergency response.

The second operational project is China's HTR-PM at Shidao Bay. This high-temperature gas-cooled reactor, producing approximately 210 MW of electricity, entered commercial operation in 2023. It represents the world's first grid-connected advanced SMR using non-light-water technology and is widely regarded as an important milestone for future industrial heat and hydrogen applications.

Beyond these two examples, most SMR projects remain under construction or in various stages of licensing and financing. China's ACPI00, also known as Linglong One, is under construction and expected to



become the first commercial land-based light-water SMR. Argentina's CAREM project has faced delays, while leading projects in North America and Europe continue to navigate regulatory approvals, financing requirements and supply-chain development. This limited deployment experience underscores the central challenge facing SMRs: while the technology is technically credible, its commercial viability remains largely unproven.

The most significant risk is economic. Although SMRs are smaller than conventional reactors, they remain capital-intensive projects. First-of-a-kind deployments have frequently experienced cost overruns and schedule delays, eroding the anticipated advantages of modular construction. Until multiple units are manufactured and deployed at scale, it remains uncertain whether the promised cost reductions can be achieved.

Regulatory uncertainty presents another major obstacle. Nuclear licensing is inherently rigorous and often time-consuming. Because regulatory frameworks differ across countries, reactor vendors frequently face repeated design reviews and approval processes, increasing costs and delaying deployment. For many developers, obtaining regulatory certainty remains as important as overcoming technical challenges.

Fuel supply is another area of concern. Several advanced SMR designs depend on specialised fuels such as High-Assay Low-Enriched Uranium (HALEU), for which global production capacity remains limited. Supply chains for nuclear-grade components and specialised manufacturing are also still developing, creating potential bottlenecks for future expansion.

Operational risks should not be overlooked. Unlike conventional nuclear plants, which benefit from decades of operating experience, many SMR technologies have little or no commercial track record. Questions remain regarding long-term reliability, maintenance costs and the ability of some designs to operate flexibly in renewable-dominated power systems.

Safety and security considerations continue to be central to the debate. While modern SMRs incorporate advanced passive safety features intended to reduce accident risks, nuclear energy remains a technology where low-probability events can have significant consequences. Cybersecurity, physical protection and nuclear safeguards become particularly important if large numbers of small reactors are eventually deployed across multiple locations. Waste management also remains unresolved. Although some advanced designs promise improved fuel utilisation and reduced waste generation, all reactors produce radioactive waste requiring long-term management and disposal.

For India, the SMR story is one of strategic preparation rather than deployment. The country does not yet have an operational SMR project, but recent policy initiatives, including the Nuclear Energy Mission, indicate growing interest in the technology as part of India's long-term energy transition.

India's position is strengthened by its extensive nuclear ecosystem. Institutions such as NPCIL, BARC and AERB provide capabilities across reactor design, fuel-cycle management, regulation and operations. This institutional depth gives India advantages that many aspiring SMR countries do not possess. Rising electricity demand, increasing renewable penetration, future coal retirements and growing land and transmission constraints all point towards the need for reliable low-carbon capacity. SMRs could potentially serve industrial clusters, support coal-site repowering and provide firm power in regions where grid flexibility becomes increasingly valuable.

India's private sector is also better prepared for SMR deployment than is often recognised. Over the past two decades, Indian companies have developed significant capabilities in heavy engineering, precision manufacturing, modular fabrication, construction, instrumentation and large-scale power project execution. Several domestic firms already participate in nuclear supply chains through the manufacture of forgings, pressure vessels, turbines, electrical equipment and specialised industrial components. As SMRs move towards commercial deployment, these capabilities can support reactor manufacturing, balance-of-plant systems, modular assembly and civil works under a government-led framework. This industrial preparedness not only strengthens India's prospects for domestic deployment but could also position the country as a competitive supplier of components and engineering services to the emerging global SMR market.

Nevertheless, SMRs are unlikely to follow a fully privatised path in India. Nuclear power remains a strategic sector under government control, and the financial, liability and safety risks associated with nuclear projects make purely private ownership improbable. A more realistic model is state-led deployment supported by private participation in manufacturing, construction, supply chains and long-term industrial offtake arrangements.

The global experience to date offers a clear lesson. SMRs should be viewed neither as a silver bullet nor as an immediate solution to power shortages. Their greatest potential lies in providing firm low-carbon electricity, industrial heat and long-term system reliability in increasingly complex energy systems. Whether they become a major component of future energy transitions will depend not on the number of announced designs, but on the ability of governments and industry to demonstrate safe, affordable and repeatable deployment at commercial scale. For India, that journey is only beginning, but the foundations technical, institutional and industrial are already taking shape.

Dr. Rajib K Mishra, Executive Director, IRADe

End of the Red Corridor: How India defeated Naxalism



BALAJI SRIVASTAVA

A 1967 spark at Naxalbari in West Bengal grew into an insurgency that spread through tribal heartlands of Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, Odisha, Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh and Jharkhand. The 2004 formation of CPI (Maoist) brought the factions under one banner, with greater coordination and resolve. At its peak, however, the scale was stark. By 2010, as many as 96 districts saw violence and 126 carried the Naxal-affected tag. Close to 12 crore Indians lived under what functioned as a parallel armed order. The Maoist pursuit of a 'Red Corridor' stretching across almost a fifth of India's geography was indeed, without exaggeration, her most serious internal security challenge.

The Naxal footprint began to shrink when political will shifted post-2014, and decisively after 2019. Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Naxalism was redefined as an integrated national security problem that cut across ministries and demanded a coordinated (whole-of-government) response. Union Home Minister Amit Shah drove this approach vigorously, matching sustained security operations with credible surrender and rehabilitation policies, and bringing personal oversight that enabled the system to deliver the desired outcomes.

What stood out was the speed at which operational gaps were closed. Backlogged procurement moved quickly, and modern equipment was sourced, when needed, from the Army, lending gear on the directions of the Union Home Minister. From anti-spike boots and sniper rifles to portable VSAT systems and air ambulances, requirements were met with rare urgency. To the forces on the ground, it sent one loud and clear message: the State stands firmly with you.

Two pillars anchored the approach. The first was a calibrated surrender-and-rehabilitation policy. When senior cadres laid down their arms, they were offered grants of up to ₹5 lakh, a three-year monthly stipend of ₹10,000, and support for housing and employment. Word travelled deep through kinship networks and trusted community intermediaries, amplified by All India Radio broadcasts in tribal languages that showcased real stories of those who returned and reintegrated into the mainstream. The second pillar was uncompromising action against those who held out. Intelligence-led joint Operations executed meticulously by CRPF battalions, CoBRA units, District Reserve Guards, and state police helped in dismantling the armed groups. The results are telling. Naxal-affected districts have fallen from 96 in 2010 to 38 in 2024. A decadal comparison shows security force casualties down by about 73per cent and civilian deaths by 74per cent. In 2024, 290 Naxalites were neutralised—the highest in a year—but the more striking numbers lie elsewhere: 881 surrenders and 1,090 arrests. In 2025, till September, surrenders have crossed 1,225; in Chhattisgarh alone, over 1,000 cadres laid down their arms within a year.

At one point in Jagdalpur, more than 200 cadres—including central committee members—surrendered en-masse, holding copies of the Constitution. Few images capture this transformation better than the shift from the gun to the Constitution. Central to this shift was the CAPFs and the state police, Jungle-warfare trained CoBRA units, the Bastariya Battalion drawn from local tribal communities, and DRG units often comprising surrendered Naxalites who knew the terrain, were the composite force who went into the forests and held ground.

Capacity expanded steadily. Over the past six years, 336 security camps have come up in core areas, supported by 76 new helipads across Bastar and Jharkhand to ensure rapid mobility. Drone surveillance now reaches even Abujhmad (unknown hills), once seen as operationally out of bounds. These camps have served a dual purpose—restricting Naxalite movement while steering development through the Niyad Nellnar (Your Good Village) initiative, which has brought banking, schooling, healthcare and Ayushman Bharat coverage to villages within a 10-km radius.

The impact of rehabilitation goes beyond what policy documents can measure. In Bastar, women who once carried weapons in the forests now manage the Bastar Café, serving both locals and security personnel. Former cadres inducted into the Bastar Fighters now protect the same villages they once intimidated. Every surrendered Naxalite living a stable public life disproves the Maoist calumny that the Indian State responds to dissent only with force.

At the top, the organisation has been systematically disrupted. The CPI (Maoist) general secretary Nambala Keshava Rao, or Basavaraju, was taken out, pursuant to a strategy that tasked senior IPS officers to track the top leadership of Maoists. In past four years, over 18 central committee members have been neutralized or captured thereby fracturing the leadership and planning capacity. Simultaneously, the enforcement agencies viz., NIA and ED have targeted the funding networks, choking the financial flows that sustained the Maoist operations.

The goal of a Naxal-Mukt Bharat by March 31, 2026 stands effectively achieved. The 'Red Corridor', once spread across 17per cent of the country, belongs to the past. Rehabilitation is picking up speed, and sustained governance is shutting the vacuum for good. Clarity and resolve drove this shift. Security forces were finally backed by an unequivocal policy after years of drift. Meanwhile, tribal communities that never signed up for a war waged in their name are getting to see roads, schools, and rights, in place of rhetoric. Our task is cut out. We now need to secure this peace.

The Writer is former Director General of Bureau of Police Research and Development, Ministry of Home Affairs, Govt of India



Standing against tyranny is service to God



HASAN KHURSHID

(October 10, 680 A.D.)

The pre-Islamic period in Arabia is known as the "age of ignorance". Succeeding away from the noble attributes of human principles, the Arabs were treading the path of retrogression and abhorrence. Suffering from worst evils and vices, these Arabs known as Bedouins (uncivilised rustics) were highly temptative of wrecking vengeance, group quarrels, tribal animosities leading to bloody warfare that lasted for generations.

In pre-Islamic period these Arabian Bedouins used to bury their newly born daughters alive out of ego. They had no sense of equality, humanity, decency and brotherhood.

In this crucial moment, Prophet of Islam Hazrat Mohammad brought the message of peace, tolerance, humanity, forbearance, liberty, equality, brotherhood, assisting to weak and securing justice for the persecuted. The Prophet gradually started transforming the heartless brutes to

humanise and turning towards peaceful life. The most notorious among them were the Bedouin tribals of "Bani-Omayya" (Omayyads). Omayyads did not tolerate the sojourn of humanity and peace. They violently opposed Prophet's teachings. Omayya's grandson, Abu Sufiyan, son of Herb, unfurled the flag of revolt against Islamic teachings. They started a campaign of persecution on the Prophet, who was forced to migrate from his home in Mecca to Medina. As such, the year of Prophet's flight from Mecca to Medina is marked as the beginning of Hijri era of Islamic calendar.

Still Prophet Mohammad was not given any respite and relief. Mohammad was compelled to fight battles many a time. In Medina, Prophet established the system for administering the "rule of law" in the light of Islamic jurisprudence, under the command of his son-in-law Hazrat Ali Murtaza ibn Abi Talib. Notwithstanding the bravery of Ali, the accused Omayyads suffered a thorough collapse. The shrewd Abu Sufiyan played a trick to subscribe to Islam outwardly and the Prophet mercifully granted quarter to Abu Sufiyan and his men.

On the contrary, Mohammad, realising his duties as Prophet was preparing his two beloved grandsons, 'Hasan' and 'Husain', sons of Ali Murtaza and Fatima Zehra, as perfect specimen of his own attainment and imparted to their young minds all the characteristics of his high morality.

After the demise of the Holy Prophet Mohammad, the school of Islamic thought, philosophy, culture and administration was shifted to 'Caliphate' with temporal and ecclesiastical powers. The first three caliphs were: Abubakar,



Umar and Usman. The last caliph Imam Ali Murtaza, was assassinated by the henchmen of the conspirator and hypocrite Muawiya son of Abu Sufiyan while Hazrat Ali Murtaza was prostrating before Allah in the mosque.

After Ali's assassination, Muawiya with the might of sword, usurped the seat of Caliphate in Syria and declared himself as the self-appointed caliph. Muawiya, the first ruler of the House of Omayyads displaced the democratic Islamic rule by oligarchical and barbaric despotic rule. After the death of Muawiya, his son accursed Yazid ascended to the Caliphate seat of Syria. He was a hardcore terrorist and had surpassed all his ancestors in practicing cruelty, violence and corruption. Yazid was libertine and sinner to the extent that the barest mention of his objectionable character is taboo in this civilised society. Yazid was the mammon of Unrighteousness, whose lust for power prompted him to beat

society into the mould he favoured. Yazid's criminal behaviour indicated the extreme occurrence of vulgar, inhuman innovations in the established Islamic values. He was immoral to the extent that he had married the real sister of his father.

On the contrary Imam Husain was recognised throughout the Arab world for his excellence of behaviour, wisdom, compassion and piety. When Yazid occupied the erstwhile seat of Caliphate, deceitfully usurped by his father Muawiya, Yazid by terrorising the citizens sought their allegiance to accept him as leader of the faithfully. He then demanded allegiance from Hazrat Imam Husain. Accursed Yazid was equipped with all the paraphernalia of power but so long as he didn't get the allegiance from Imam Husain, the grandson of the Prophet, he had no religious sanction to claim the Caliphate. He therefore demanded allegiance from Imam Husain to subscribe him as leader of the faithful. When Yazid bargained hard for Imam Husain to choose between allegiance and death, Husain straightaway refused him for allegiance, saying, "A person of my kind, cannot accept the allegiance of a man of his (Yazid's) kind." Husain knew that recognition of Yazid's immorality would permanently disfigure the "true faith" and a "pseudo religion" will emerge in the guise of Islam. Had he encountered no opposition, Islam was bound to acclimatised to the paralysing atonality from Yazid's degenerated symphony.

Imam Husain was mercilessly assassinated in the desert of Karbala along with 71 family members and companions on 10th of Muharram, 61 Hijri (October 10, 680 A.D.), after being kept

hungry and thirsty for three days.

Their heads were severed from the bodies and were mounted on lancers. Among the slain martyrs was Husain's six month old infant son, Ali Asghar, the buoyancy of whose innocent blood refloated the sinking ship of Islam. Ali Asghar's moon-like innocent severed head was too mounted on a lancer.

Asghar's little body among 71 others was too trampled through the hoofs of horses of Yazid's cavalry. The tents of Husain's household were torched. Daughters and grand children of Prophet Mohammad's extended family and the only surviving, ailing son office Imam Husain, were taken captives and paraded from Karbala to Syria, on bare backs of camels, where they were appeared before accursed Yazid, the wild beast in human form.

10th Muharram is universally observed by right thinking and kind-hearted people irrespective of caste, religion or faith. "Never in the fight of human conflict was so much owed by so many to so few", said Churchill. The event of Karbala, taking place on 10th Moharram, 61 Hijri, teaches us: Never support injustice and oppression, no matter, how powerful the oppressor might be. No matter, what incentive, what threat you might be given? Husain declared, "Do not submit to exploitation of any kind, maintain a tenacious grip on veracity, and better die with honour guarding against evil, than live in shame."

The writer is a legal journalist and a columnist



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**Jacqueline Fernandez
withdraws plea from SC**

The Supreme Court on Thursday permitted Bollywood actor Jacqueline Fernandez to withdraw her plea challenging a Delhi court order to frame charges against her in a ₹200 crore money laundering case.

“Counsel for the petitioner (Fernandez) has sought permission to withdraw this special leave petition with liberty to avail appropriate remedy in accordance with law,” a bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and Joymalya Bagchi said. The top court permitted the withdrawal of petition with the liberty as sought by the petitioner.

A Delhi court on May 30 ordered framing of charges against the actor, alleged conman Sukesh Chandrashekar and 15 others in the case. The actor had moved the top court against the order.

The trial court also directed that charges be framed against Chandrashekar and 20 others for various offences, including under the stringent MCOCA provisions, in another case registered by the city police’s special cell. On June 3, setting the stage for trial, a Delhi court formally framed charges in the money laundering case.

On June 11, apex court judge Justice Prashant Kumar Mishra recused himself from hearing the actor’s plea.

Fernandez, who was summoned by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) several times in connection with the probe, was named an accused for the first time in a supplementary charge sheet filed by the agency. (PTI)



**Late night phone calls
no evil: Delhi court**



A Delhi court has said that merely because a woman talks to a man over the phone at late hours cannot be a reason to question her character or justify intrusion into her privacy by seeking preservation of her call detail records (CDRs).

Additional Sessions Judge Shunali Gupta made the observation while dismissing an appeal filed by a man challenging a trial court order that had refused his request for the preservation of the CDRs of his wife and another person in a pending domestic violence case.

In an order dated June 2, the court said, “To my mind, talking to any person even at odd hours of the day cannot by itself put a question mark on the character of the woman until and unless it has been alleged that the woman has some illegal, adulterous etc relationship with a said man.”

The appellant husband had argued that the preservation of the records was necessary as the complainant, his wife, was allegedly in regular telephonic contact with certain persons during late night hours and the records might otherwise be erased by the service provider with the passage of time.

Upholding the trial court’s order, the sessions court said that although the right to privacy was not absolute and could yield to the right to a fair trial in appropriate cases, any request seeking preservation of another person’s call records must be supported by specific and reasonable grounds.

“The Indian society no longer remains a primitive society wherein a woman talking with a man is considered to be a taboo,” the judge said.

The court noted that neither the application before the trial court nor the appeal disclosed any concrete reason necessitating preservation of the records.

“Women are working in every field, multinational companies etc and have male colleagues. Just because a woman is found talking on the phone at night... the same cannot ipso facto become a ground seeking preservation of CDR of her mobile number,” the court said. (PTI)

Gujarat Govt told to decide on Haren Pandya’s remission plea

The Gujarat High Court has ordered the state government to take a decision within six months on the remission plea filed by a shooter sentenced to life imprisonment in the 2003 Haren Pandya murder case.

Mohammad Ashgar Ali, the shooter hailing from Hyderabad, was arrested a few days after Pandya, the former Gujarat home minister, was shot dead on March 26, 2003, in Ahmedabad.

He had approached the high court, stating that the government was not taking any decision on his plea for premature release made in 2025 after completing 14 years in prison, claiming his conduct in jail had been good. Justice MR Mengdey on June 17 directed the state to decide on Ali’s remission plea, preferably within six months from



HAREN PANDYA

the date of receipt of the order.

“From the jail remarks submitted on record, it appears that the process for consideration of the case of the petitioner for grant of remission is underway and the opinion from

the advisory committee has also been called for, which has been received and the same shall be put up before the concerned authority in the near future,” the court stated in its order.



**First step to equality is providing
equal access to law: CJI Surya Kant**

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant has said the first step to equality is providing equal access to the law and emphasised that it should not merely be a procedural nicety. Speaking at the XIV St Petersburg International Legal Forum in Russia on Wednesday, the CJI said equal access to law must fructify in the conferment of actual rights rather than hollow statutory declarations.

“We must ask ourselves what it actually takes for equality before the law to become real? My answer, which I draw from my experience presiding over the world’s largest and most complex judicial systems, is that the first step to equality is providing equal access to the law.

“Such access cannot merely be a procedural nicety and must fructify in the conferment of actual rights rather than hollow statutory declarations,” the CJI said.



He said the birthplace of equality was not necessarily the Magna Carta in 1215.

“Rather, my own personal belief is that its roots are traceable to Kautilya’s Arthashastra, which belongs to the Indian subcontinent and propounded the theory of equality in the fourth century,” he said.

CJI Kant said the Indian Constitution, upon its inception, promised a new dawn and conferred upon the people a series of Fundamental Rights, including

economic disparities.

“Consequently, the Indian constitutional courts have interpreted and provided a broad and expansive interpretation of constitutional guarantees in order to eliminate all such barriers. This approach ensures that access to law and justice is not just a technical convenience but a non-discriminatory founding principle of governance,” he said.

The CJI said equal justice and equal law are not ceremonial phrases and they are the conditions under which a legal order may credibly call itself law at all.

Regarding the international legal framework, the CJI said numerous nations in the global east and south are still constructing their institutions, addressing the repercussions of colonialism and tackling poverty. “These countries frequently endure scrutiny and pressure that are not proportionally applied to wealthier and more influential States, whose own compliance records are not necessarily irreproachable,” the CJI said.

Vadhvan Project: Bombay HC clears mangrove removal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai/Palghar

The Bombay High Court has paved the way for accelerated execution of the Vadhvan Port Project in Maharashtra’s Palghar district by granting clearance for the removal of mangrove patches located within the approach area of the near-shore reclamation zone. A bench of Justices Bharati Dangle and Manjusha Deshpande, in the order passed on Tuesday, said the project is of public importance and has wider economic significance.

The bench has permitted the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) to fell 208 mangrove trees for the construction of an eight-lane access-controlled highway linking the upcoming port in

Palghar district to NH-48.

The court added that the project proponent had secured all necessary environmental, coastal regulation zone and forest clearances, besides complying with compensatory afforestation requirements.

The project was in the larger public interest and would provide crucial connectivity to the proposed Vadhavan Port, which has been identified as a nationally important infrastructure project, HC said.

“In our view, the said project being of public utility, would provide connectivity to the Vadhavan Port which is being developed as a major port on landlord port development model, which would open an opportunity for India to make it into the countries



with top 10 container ports in the world,” the court said.

The NHAI had approached the court seeking approval in view of earlier directions passed by the high court in a long-pending mangrove protection PIL, which requires prior court permission for the destruction of mangroves even in public projects.

The court, in its order, said NHAI had complied with com-

pensatory afforestation requirements. The project proponent has undertaken the plantation of 1.33 lakh mangroves on 30 hectares of land and deposited more than ₹4.83 crore towards mangrove compensatory afforestation, apart from other payments required under forest clearance conditions. With this clearance, key pending issues affecting

**Ayodhya donation row: SC to take up plea
for fair, time-bound probe on June 29**

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday asked a petitioner to mention before it on June 29 his plea seeking registration of an FIR, and a fair and time-bound probe into the alleged embezzlement of donations received at the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

The matter was mentioned for urgent listing before a bench of Justices BV Nagarathna and Joymalya Bagchi. The petition, filed by practising advocates Ajay Kumar Rai and Dinesh Kumar Yadav, said a CBI-led multi-disciplinary special investigation team (SIT) should investigate the alleged financial irregularities and other purported illegalities concerning the affairs and administration of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

On Thursday, one of the petitioners mentioned the matter and urged the bench that the plea be listed for hearing on June 29.

“This is a PIL (public interest

litigation) and it relates to the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust. It has been numbered but no date is shown,” the petitioner said.

The bench observed if there was no deficiency in the plea, the registry would process it.

“Please approach the registry. If the deficiency is removed, it will be listed,” the bench said. The petitioner said the plea was registered and there were no deficiencies.

When he requested that the matter be listed for hearing on June 29, the bench said, “You mention it on Monday (June 29).”

The petition has sought directions to the Centre, the Uttar Pradesh government and the Trust for constituting and operationalising such regulatory, supervisory and audit mechanisms as may be necessary to safeguard public interest and maintain the confidence of millions of devotees and donors.

“Whether or not the reports regarding missing funds and other alleged irregularities concerning the Shri Ram



Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust are ultimately found to be true, such reports have caused deep concern among the generations that struggled for the restoration of the glory of Ayodhya,” the plea stated.

It said the SIT constituted by the Uttar Pradesh government has commenced its inquiry into the matter without the registration of an FIR or any regular criminal case.

The plea said the veracity of reports concerning alleged missing funds and other purported irregularities involving the Trust ought to be independently verified through a professional investigation conducted by a unified agency

possessing the requisite expertise, resources and institutional mechanisms for handling complex financial and criminal investigations.

“Such an inquiry would inspire greater public confidence than a preliminary probe conducted by a special investigation team (SIT) comprising administrative officers who may not possess specialised credentials in criminal investigation,” the plea said.

It said the issues involved not only concern the possible commission of cognisable offences but also directly affect the faith, sentiments and confidence of countless devotees and the public.

On June 13, the Uttar Pradesh government constituted the SIT on a request from the temple trust following allegations of misappropriation of donations received at the Ayodhya Ram temple.

The SIT comprises Lucknow Divisional Commissioner Vijay Vishwas Pant, Inspector General of Police Kiran S and Finance Department Special Secretary Neel Ratan.

**Bail to 5 held for non-veg
party on boat in Ganga**

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Varanasi

Five persons arrested for allegedly consuming liquor and holding a non-vegetarian party on a boat in the Ganga river in Varanasi were granted bail, their counsel said.

Advocate Vikas Singh said the accused were released by the court of the executive magistrate/assistant commissioner of police after furnishing two sureties of ₹20,000 each along with personal bonds.

The accused were identified as Deepak Kumar of Sujabad Padav in Ramnagar, boatman Ajay Sahni, Arun Kumar Sahni of Domri in Ramnagar, Anurag Nishad and Rahul Sahni of Bandha Road in Sujabad, Ramnagar.

The case came to light after a video allegedly showing the five men consuming beer and holding a non-vegetarian party on a boat in the river went viral on social media on Monday.

Following an investigation, the police identified



the individuals involved, arrested them and seized the boat.

The five accused, aged between 25 and 32 years, were arrested on June 23, Dasasvamedh ACP Atul Anjan Tripathi said.

Earlier this year, a similar controversy had surfaced when a video showing people eating biryani on a boat in the Ganga river went viral on social media on March 16. The Kotwali police had arrested 14 Muslim youths the following day in connection with that incident. The accused in that case were later granted bail by the Allahabad High Court.

**Jharkhand HC relief to CM
in model code violation case**

The Jharkhand High Court on Thursday quashed criminal proceedings against Chief Minister Hemant Soren in a case related to the alleged violation of the model code of conduct during the 2014 assembly elections.

Soren was facing prosecution before a district court in West Singhbhum district in connection with the case.

Justice Anil Kumar Choudhary set aside the proceedings after hearing the matter at length.

An FIR was lodged at

Adityapur police station in 2014 alleging violation of the model code of conduct by Soren.

The chief minister had subsequently moved the high court, which had earlier stayed the criminal proceedings against him.

During the hearing, Soren’s counsel contended that no violation of the model code had taken place and alleged that the FIR was lodged due to political vendetta.

The counsel submitted that Soren had merely participated in an election campaign for a candidate of his party.



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

**Delhi HC permits rape survivor to
terminate 28-week pregnancy**

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has permitted a 15-year-old rape survivor to medically terminate her 28-week pregnancy, observing that although the law does not provide for abortion after 24 weeks, such permission can be accorded in view of grave mental injury and trauma inflicted upon the mind of a minor girl.

A vacation bench of Justice Mini Pushkarna, however, clarified that if the child is born alive in this case, authorities must offer medical assistance to the baby, involve the Child Welfare Committee, and if so wished by the girl



and her father, give the baby up for adoption.

The bench further directed AIIMS Delhi to preserve the foetus’s tissue for DNA testing, which would be required in the criminal case. Invoking Right to Life, the

petitioner, who filed the plea through her father, told the court that she wanted to terminate her approximately 26-28 weeks pregnancy arising from an incident of rape.

She submitted that continuing the pregnancy would result in grave mental injury to her.

“The petitioner is permitted to get herself admitted at AIIMS, New Delhi on the strength of the present order for medical termination of her pregnancy. Let the procedure for termination of pregnancy be carried out by a team of competent doctors (as per law),” said the court in its order passed on June 24.

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Bajaj Auto to strengthen 125cc-plus bike segment

Bajaj Auto Ltd will strengthen strategically important 125cc plus domestic motorcycle portfolio, while ‘turbo charging’ its electric scooter Chetak in FY27, amid a volatile, uncertain and complex external environment, Chairman Niraj R Bajaj said. The company will also look to boost exports given the recovery across key international markets, whilst navigating the challenges and disruptions in global logistics, Bajaj said in the company’s annual report for 2025-26. “As we look ahead to FY27, the external environment remains volatile, uncertain and complex. Geopolitical developments, commodity inflation, supply chain disruptions and shifts in global trade dynamics are creating challenges in the operating environment that are particularly pronounced as we start the new financial year,” he said.

Mumbai Port Authority to take up projects worth ₹5,028.17 cr

Mumbai Port Authority on Thursday announced 63 projects worth ₹5,028.17 crore as part of its 154th Foundation Day celebrations. This includes 22 projects, totalling ₹3,541.29 crore, which are yet to be announced, 34 projects of ₹1,354.59 crore for foundation laying, and the remaining seven projects for inauguration worth ₹132.29 crore, the state-run port operator said. Delivering his keynote address at the celebration event in the financial capital, Union Minister for Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Sarbananda Sonowal said that institutions such as Mumbai Port have an important responsibility in the journey towards Viksit Bharat 2047. (PNS)

Jupiter International invests ₹550 cr in Himachal’s Baddi

City-based Jupiter International Ltd on Thursday inaugurated a new 1.25 GW TOPCon (Tunnel Oxide Passivated Contact) solar cell manufacturing unit at its Baddi facility in Himachal Pradesh, taking its total solar cell manufacturing capacity to 3.25 GW from 2 GW. The company said it has invested ₹550 crore in setting up the unit, which will manufacture next-generation high-efficiency TOPCon solar cells, a technology increasingly being adopted by the solar industry for its higher efficiency and improved long-term performance. The commissioning of the unit marks Jupiter International’s transition from expanding manufacturing capacity to scaling advanced solar cell technologies, the company said in a statement. The latest expansion follows the addition of 1 GW mono PERC solar cell manufacturing capacity at the Baddi campus earlier this year. “Commencement of production at Unit IV Baddi will be a defining step in Jupiter’s technology journey. By bringing 1.25 GW of TOPCon capacity into production, we are scaling next-generation cell technology that raises the bar on efficiency and long-term performance,” Jupiter International CEO Dhruv Sharma said. (PTI)

Tata Motors CEO sees West Asia war as brief hurdle to CV demand

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The implications of West Asia war, specially diesel price hike, will have a short-term impact on domestic commercial vehicle demand, which is expected to grow in single digit this fiscal but India’s macro-economic growth will help overcome it in the long term, Tata Motors Ltd MD & CEO Girish Wagh said on Thursday.

Terming fuel price hikes and increase in cost of commodities as “cyclical headwinds”, he said those will lead to some changes in the quarterly and annual demand but in the long term “India growth story

will lead to increase in road freight, and therefore the commercial vehicle demand”.

“We do have short-term headwinds. The Middle East

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | JUNE 26, 2026

Crude oil futures fall over 1% amid Iran deal optimism

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Crude oil futures fell by ₹80 to ₹6,589 per barrel on Thursday as improving prospects of a US-Iran agreement and rising shipments through key export routes eased concerns over global supply disruptions.

Extending the slide for the fourth straight session, crude oil for the July delivery slipped by ₹80, or 1.2 per cent, to ₹6,589 per barrel in a business turnover of 5,847 lots on the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX). The August contract also weakened by ₹76, or 1.14 per cent, to ₹6,587

per barrel in 2,023 lots on the MCX. Analysts said the selloff comes as market participants increasingly bet that a potential agreement between Washington and Tehran could pave the way for additional Iranian crude exports and reduce risks to shipments through the Strait of Hormuz, a critical route for global oil trade.

“MCX crude slipped more than 1 per cent as improving prospects for a US-Iran agreement eased supply concerns,” Pinky Yadav, Commodity Fundamental Analyst at Choice Broking, said.

Growing confidence in a

lasting peace deal has encouraged increased tanker movement through the Strait of Hormuz, while

crude exports from the Middle East and West Africa have increased, helping alleviate concerns over supply

Andhra govt signs MoU with Airbound to build large-scale drone delivery network

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Amaravati/New Delhi

The Andhra Pradesh government on Thursday signed a memorandum of understanding with Bengaluru-based aerospace company, Airbound, to launch a large-scale drone delivery network across the Amaravati Capital Region, targeting 10,000 drone flights a day to expedite the movement of healthcare supplies, commercial goods and other critical consignments.

The agreement, signed between Andhra Pradesh Drone Corporation (APDC) and Airbound, seeks to develop one of the world’s largest commercial drone delivery ecosystems while strengthening future-ready logistics infrastructure and positioning Andhra Pradesh as a global drone hub, according to a company statement.

“The MoU envisages the

development of a large-scale drone delivery network across the Amaravati Capital Region, with both partners targeting 10,000 drone flights a day to strengthen logistics and accelerate the movement of healthcare supplies, commercial goods and other critical consignments,” said Airbound Founder and Chief Executive Officer Naman Pushp in a press release.

The MoU was signed by APDC Managing Director and Chairman Geetanjali Sharma and Pushp in the presence of Union Civil Aviation Minister Kinjarapu Ram Mohan Naidu. Under the proposed

Amaravati Capital Region Drone Delivery Network (ACR DDN), Airbound will collaborate with stakeholders across the healthcare, logistics and e-commerce sectors to connect Amaravati, Vijayawada and Guntur region through drone operations.

The initiative is expected to commence with operations in Guntur before being scaled up across the state over the coming year, he said.

Pushp said the network will be powered by the company’s blended-wing-body tailsitter aircraft built using lightweight carbon fibre, adding that weighing 1.5 kg, the aircraft offers a payload-to-weight ratio of 1.5:1 compared with the industry standard of 4:1, enabling deliveries at costs of up to 20 times lower than conventional logistics methods.

Gold futures rebound on value buying after steep sell-off

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Gold futures recovered marginally on Thursday, rising ₹405 to ₹1.41 lakh per 10 grams as traders resorted to value buying after a sharp selloff, even as concerns over a strong dollar and the US interest-rate outlook kept sentiment cautious.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), the yellow metal for August delivery increased by ₹405, or 0.29 per cent, to ₹1,41,675 per 10 grams in a business turnover of 10,375 lots. Despite the recovery, the precious metal remained near a six-month low after plunging ₹5,259, or 3.6 per cent, in the previous

session to settle at ₹1,41,270 per 10 grams. Gold was last seen around these levels on December 16, 2025, when it traded at ₹1,41,600 per 10 grams on the MCX.

“Gold prices have seen a slight uptick on Thursday, reflecting a modest gain in the domestic commodities

market amid gains in the overseas trade,” Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk, said. The domestic commodities market will remain closed in the morning session on Friday on account of Muharram. In the international markets, Comex gold futures for August

delivery fell \$11.30, or 0.28 per cent, to \$3,997.50 per ounce, slipping below the key \$4,000-an-ounce level for the first time in more than eight months. The yellow metal was last quoted near these levels on October 2, 2025, when the trading value stood at \$3,980.8 per ounce.

“Gold prices declined on Thursday, slipping below the key psychological level of \$4,000 per ounce, driven by a stronger US dollar and rising expectations of further interest rate hikes by the Federal Reserve, which weighed on investor sentiment and reduced the appeal of assets such as gold,” Deveya Gaglani, Senior Research Analyst - Commodities, Axis Direct, said.

‘Housing sales rises 19% in Apr-Jun across 9 cities’

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Housing sales rose 19 per cent to 1,12,458 units during April-June across the top nine cities despite global economic uncertainties, according to PropEquity. Sales stood at 94,864 units in the year-ago period across the nine cities — Mumbai, Navi Mumbai, Thane, Delhi-NCR, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Chennai, Pune and Kolkata.

New supply of residential properties rose 43 per cent annually to 1,17,609 units during the April-June period.

PropEquity founder and CEO Samir Jasuja said, “The

Indian housing market has remained resilient despite the geopolitical uncertainties in the Middle East. Southern markets continue to lead growth, while Mumbai and Navi Mumbai have also seen strong demand. Although some regions such as Thane and Delhi-NCR have witnessed relatively softer activity, overall market sentiment remains positive”.

According to the data, the housing sales in Bengaluru rose to 21,516 units in April-June from 14,676 units in the year-ago period. In Chennai, sales increased to 6,323 units from 5,354 units. Sales of res-

idential properties in Hyderabad rose to 14,410 units from ₹11,815 units. Mumbai saw sales rising to 10,561 units from 8,006 units, while Navi Mumbai witnessed housing sales growing to 11,029 units from 6,833 units.

In Thane, the sales grew to

16,386 units from 14,832 units. Housing sales in Pune rose to 18,737 units from 17,196 units. However, sales in Delhi-NCR fell to 10,082 units from 11,703 units. In Kolkata, the sales declined to 3,414 units in April-June from 4,449 units in the year-ago period.

BUSINESS 11

disruptions, she added. The weakness also reflected in the international markets. Brent oil futures for August contract fell 1.55 per cent to \$72.60 per barrel on the ICE, and West Texas Intermediate crude oil was trading 1.25 per cent lower at \$69.46 per barrel on the NYMEX. “Crude oil prices extended their decline, with WTI falling below \$70 per barrel and erasing most of the gains recorded during the conflict in West Asia,” Yadav said.

She added that a temporary US waiver permitting purchases of already-loaded Iranian crude cargoes is

expected to bring additional barrels into the energy market, further easing supply tightness.

“The increased availability of crude has outweighed supportive inventory data from the US, where stockpiles fell to their lowest level since 1984.

“As a result, global oil prices have declined sharply from their wartime highs amid improving supply conditions,” Yadav added. Traders are closely watching developments in the US-Iran negotiations and crude flows through the Strait of Hormuz for fresh cues on oil price direction.

Jewellery demand in India resilient despite high gold prices: Indriya CEO

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Jewellery demand in India remains resilient despite volatility in gold prices and consumers rather adapt to new buying patterns instead of deferring purchases, said Sandeep Kohli, CEO of Indriya, the jewellery retail brand of Aditya Birla Group.

“Volatility in any kind of pricing is not something consumers like. When there is too much volatility in gold rates, consumers tend to hold back purchases. But the demand does not go down,” Kohli told PTI. Gold jewellery continues to occupy a special place in consumers’ hearts because purchases are often associated with weddings, festivals and other significant occasions, he said.

In the last six months, the demand for gold and value sales have been good. People have bought gold for wed-

dings and during festivals, including Akshaya Tritiya, he said. However, he acknowledged that soaring gold prices have prompted consumers to modify their buying patterns.

“... if the gold price has gone up to the extent that it has gone up just now, it is but obvious that consumers’ budgets have not increased by that much. So, then consumers change their behaviour. They change the way they are buying... They may stretch it a bit,” he said. There are reports that con-

sumers are moving beyond the traditional preference for 22-carat gold jewellery and opting for lower-purity variants, such as 18-carat and 14-carat. According to Kohli, this is not a “down-trading” but a “smart adjustment” by consumers seeking to balance affordability with design and aesthetics. Besides gold, the company is focusing on expanding its play in diamonds, which account for roughly 10 per cent of the Indian jewellery market, estimated at around ₹8 lakh crore.

SEBI resolves over 5,500 investor complaints in May via SCORES platform

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

SEBI has disposed of more than 5,500 investor complaints through its online grievance redressal platform SCORES in May, the capital markets regulator said in a public notice on Thursday. As many as 10 complaints are pending for more than three months on SCORES as of May-end, involving entities such as KFin Technologies Pvt Ltd, Secur Creditentials Ltd and Eastern Investments Ltd, according to SEBI data.

The regulator’s grievance platform received 4,918 fresh complaints in May, while 5,548 complaints were resolved during the period. As a result, the number of pending complaints declined from 6,167 to 5,537 as of May 31, 2026.

The regulator also reported that entities took an average time of five days to

submit the action taken reports (ATRs) on investor complaints during April, while the average resolution time for first-time level review complaints stood at eight days.

SEBI clarified that the pending complaints figure also includes complaints where entities, designated bodies have submitted their ATRs to investors within the stipulated time, but the complaints remain pending, giving opportunity for the investors to seek a review if they are dissatisfied with the response. Under SCORES 2.0, complaints are automatically forwarded to the entity concerned, and they have 21 days to submit the ATR to the investor.

If investors are not satisfied with the response, they can seek a first-level review within 15 days, following which the complaint is examined by a designated body and submit the ATR.

Suzlon bags 400 MW wind energy project order from Tata Power in AP

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Suzlon on Thursday said it has secured a repeat order from Tata Power to construct a 400 MW wind energy project in Andhra Pradesh.

The partnership with Tata Power across Karnataka, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh has crossed over 1 GW mark, Suzlon said in an exchange filing. As part of the new project, Suzlon will install 127 S144 series wind turbine generators (WTGs), each with a rated capacity of 3.15 MW.

The company will deliver the project through its EPC (Engineering, Procurement

and Construction) offering, covering land acquisition, balance-of-plant, the extra high voltage line, commissioning, and operations and maintenance services.

Girish Tanti, Vice Chairman, Suzlon Group

said, “Over the past two decades, our partnership has evolved from individual projects to advanced hybrid and round the clock renewable energy solutions that support the country’s energy transition vision.”

FROM THE WORLD

COLOMBIA

Trump-backed candidate wins

Conservative outsider Abelardo de la Esperiella, a millionaire political neophyte, will be Colombia's next president after electoral authorities on Wednesday declared him the winner of Sunday's runoff election. The businessman and lawyer, whose ventures include a clothing line, wine and rum brands, and a restaurant, earned US President Donald Trump's endorsement despite never having run for office. He defeated progressive lawmaker Ivan Cepeda by 1 percentage point, or more than 2,51,000 votes. The result effectively was an indictment of outgoing President Gustavo Petro's government, whose policies Cepeda had promised to continue, including a largely failed effort to establish dialogue with multiple armed groups.

USA

Hawaii gun law struck down

The Supreme Court struck down a Hawaii law requiring people to get permission to carry guns into stores and hotels on Thursday, in its latest opinion backing Second Amendment rights. The high court's 6-3 decision means people can carry guns onto privately owned property like shopping malls and gas stations, unless the owners specifically say guns are banned at their establishments. It comes shortly after the court found that marijuana users can't be completely banned from owning firearms. It's a win for President Donald Trump's Republican administration, which argued the law violates the Second Amendment. The measure was sometimes referred to as a "vampire rule" because it required people with guns get permission to enter, like vampire lore says bloodsuckers need an invitation to enter a home.

Oil tankers use new route through Hormuz despite Iranian threats

JON GAMBRELL / MATTHEW LEE ■ Dubai

Several tankers made their way out of the Strait of Hormuz on Thursday using a new route promoted by a UN maritime agency. Iran has threatened vessels using the path, which runs along the coast of Oman.

The opening of an alternative passage through the vital waterway would relieve pressure on the world economy and remove Iran's main source of leverage in ongoing peace talks with the United States. US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, on a visit to the Gulf to reassure American allies, said Washington was committed to the new route. Traffic through the strait has increased but is still well below prewar levels. Oil on Thursday briefly dipped below its last prewar price of just under \$73 per barrel, a sign that the market believes the situation is improving.

The two sides are still debating terms of an interim peace deal — from getting ships through the narrow mouth of the Persian Gulf to the future of Iran's stockpile of highly enriched uranium. Under the memorandum of understanding signed last week, the US and Iran agreed to a 60-day period to iron out the details. As talks are held behind closed doors, US President Donald Trump and Iranian leaders have seemed to negotiate in public, trading threats and claiming concessions the other side denies.

The flare-up of fighting in Lebanon between Israel and Iranian-backed Hezbollah militants has meanwhile



US Secretary of State Marco Rubio with Bahrain's Foreign Minister AP

threatened the wider truce. Israel's first airstrike on Lebanon since a ceasefire took effect over the weekend killed two people on Wednesday, according to Lebanon's state-run news agency.

The oil tankers, led by the Stoic Warrior vessel, sailed along the coast of the United Arab Emirates and then Oman early Thursday, passing by Oman's Musandam Peninsula fairly close to the shore. The route was laid out by Oman and the International Maritime Organisation, a UN agency. North of the route is the Traffic Separation Scheme corridor, in the center of the strait, where ships had moved through freely before the war, transporting about a fifth of all the world's oil and natural gas.

Iran said it mined that passage after the US and Israel attacked it on Feb. 28, and at least one mine has been sighted there. Though

some ships had been getting out of the strait, with US military support, the UN agency's effort is the latest to free trapped vessels. The shipping company Maersk said its container ship, the Maersk Baltimore, and another chartered vessel had also made it out of the strait on Thursday. Last week, 125 vessels crossed the strait, up from 33 the week before, according to marine data and analysis firm Lloyd's List Intelligence.

According to S&P Global, Wednesday saw 78 transits, the most since the war began. Among the vessels were 10 crude oil tankers, including five out-bound large carriers that can carry up to 2 million barrels of oil.

Still, that daily total is below the average of 130 or more from before the war.

"Opportunistic operators - and there are many of them - emboldened by the lower transit risk, or at least the perceived lower transit risk, have

NO TOLLS ON SHIPS: US

Dubai: Rubio met with foreign ministers from the six-nation Gulf Cooperation Council to assure them that their interests would be protected in any agreement with Iran. Those countries, including major energy producers reliant on the Strait of Hormuz for exports, came under attack by Iran after the start of the war.

"There is no part in this deal that's undertaken that in any way undermines the security, the stability or the prosperity of any of our partners in the Gulf region," Rubio said at the meeting in Bahrain, home to the US Navy's 5th Fleet. He later told journalists the US and Gulf allies would ensure there would be no fees charged on ships moving through the strait. He also criticized Iran's hard-liners for going "on their official media and making all kinds of pronouncements" that he described as not true.

He said the US wanted to make sure the Oman route continued for ships to transit the strait. "If that stops, then we're going to have a problem," Rubio said. (AP)

begun chasing the backlog of trapped cargoes that built up during the conflict," said Richard Meade, editor-in-chief at Lloyd's List.

The naval arm of the Revolutionary Guard, apparently reacting to the new shipping route and increased traffic, issued a warning Thursday, carried by Iran's state-run IRNA news agency. (AP)

Iran-US peace talks expected to resume next week, says Pakistan

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan has said talks between the US and Iran are expected to resume next week. In a statement issued late on Wednesday, Pakistan's foreign office spokesperson Tahir Andrabi said "parties are on the table" and that the process was going on. The US and Iran last week signed a memorandum of understanding aimed at restoring peace in West Asia.

Earlier this week, they engaged in technical-level talks in Switzerland's Burgenstock, in the presence of mediators Pakistan, which has signed the memorandum as a "guarantor", and Qatar, following which they agreed on a roadmap towards a final peace deal in 60 days.

"Talks are continuing. I believe that the talks will resume next week, probably on Tuesday... Basically, this is a temporary gap, and it is not as such a break," Andrabi was quoted as saying in the statement.

"Our delegation was there in Burgenstock for the 22nd June talks. I understand that our



Tahir Andrabi

delegation will also be there when the talks resume next week," he added.

He also said the expected resumption of talks between the US and Iran next week was a "positive development".

However, the US and Iran have not yet said anything on the possible resumption of talks.

Trump clashes with senate GOP over vote to block war against Iran

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Washington

President Donald Trump berated Senate Republicans face to face on Wednesday for allowing a vote to block his war in Iran, further escalating a feud that has diverted GOP efforts to focus on election-year affordability issues and brought much of the chamber's business to a halt.

Invited by Florida Sen Rick Scott to speak at a GOP luncheon in the Capitol, Trump had signalled ahead of time that he would use the closed-door meeting to push senators to pass his proof-of-citizenship voting bill. But the conversation was more



focused on Tuesday's vote to approve the war powers resolution, a mostly symbolic measure that allows Congress to rebuke the administration's military actions. The House passed its own version of the resolution earlier this month.

Trump had particular words for the four Republican senators who

voted with Democrats on the measure -- Republicans Lisa Murkowski of Alaska, Susan Collins of Maine, Rand Paul of Kentucky and Bill Cassidy of Louisiana — after calling them "losers" on social media.

Most Republicans stayed quiet. But Cassidy, who lost reelection in his primary last month after Trump endorsed an opponent, stood up and defended his vote. "I stood and said, You have not told the American people what's going on," Cassidy told reporters after the meeting. "This was supposed to last four weeks, it's lasted four months. Our original objectives have not been achieved" he added.

Very close on trade deal with US; competitive tariff advantage important for India: Goyal

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Thursday said that the trade pact with the US is "very close", but it cannot come into force unless India secures a competitive tariff advantage over its competitor nations.

"The day that happens, the deal is on," he said here at the India Global Forum (IGF) UK-India Week event.

Goyal is here on a three-day official visit to discuss issues related to the implementation of the India-UK free trade agreement.

The minister held two-day talks with US Trade Representative



Union Minister Piyush Goyal during the India Global Forum (IGF) UK-India Week in London AP

Jamieson Greer in New Delhi this week on the first phase of the India-US bilateral trade agreement (BTA).

However, a statement by the commerce ministry gave no indication that all differences were resolved ahead of the expiry of 10 per cent temporary tariff on July 24.

A free trade agreement is fundamentally aimed at providing a comparative advantage over competitor countries in terms of market access, he said.

"And until the framework of getting that competitive advantage can be finalised, we can't enter into force a US deal. I don't

think I can be more transparent than that...So that's broadly the discussions (between India and the US) on how the US will find the appropriate tools and legal backing to give us that competitive advantage over our competitors," he added.

When the framework of the first phase of the BTA was finalised, India had a comparative advantage over its competitor countries, such as ASEAN nations (Indonesia, Malaysia, Singapore, Thailand, Philippines, Brunei, Vietnam, Laos, Myanmar, Cambodia), Sri Lanka, Pakistan and Bangladesh.

Under the framework, the US had announced an 18 per cent

tariff on Indian goods. At that time, tariffs on India's competing countries ranged from 19 to 20 per cent. But now, all countries face the same 10 per cent additional levy.

"There is always a little give and take (in an agreement)," he said, adding, "We are very close" to the deal.

Suggesting that the India-United States trade deal was 99 per cent complete, US Ambassador Sergio Gora, on June 3 in Mumbai, said that both sides were trying to resolve the remaining "1 per cent" sticking points and expected the long-awaited pact to be inked within the next several weeks. (PTI)

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE						
SR NO	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD B&R, HISAR	SETUP OF REVENUE IT LAB AT 4TH FLOOR AT MINI SECTT., HISAR (PDG. E.I. INTERNAL AND ELY SERVICES ONLY)	24.06.2026 30.06.2026	15.63 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
2	PWD B&R, HISAR	UP-GRADATION OF SDM OFFICE IN DIVISIONAL COMMISSIONER AND I.G. POLICE RANGE BUILDING IN MINI SECTT. AT HISAR (PDG. E.I. INTERNAL ONLY)	24.06.2026 30.06.2026	10.18 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0166-2225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
3	PWD B&R, KAITHAL	REPAIR OF ROOF OF JUDICIAL COURT COMPLEX AT KAITHAL	CLOSING DATE 30.06.2026	45.22 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in dsndharyana.gov.in	9896320998 pwd-eeepd-kaithal@hry.nic.in
4	PWD B&R, KAITHAL	CONSTRUCTION OF 2 LANE MNB BRIDGE ACROSS JAKHOLI SUB BRANCH ON DHAND PUNDRI RAJOUND ALEWA ROAD (MDR 113) AT RD 23.9 IN KAITHAL DISTRICT.	CLOSING DATE 03.07.2026	99.97 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in dsndharyana.gov.in	9896320998 pwd-eeepd-kaitthal@hry.nic.in
5	PANCHAYATI RAJ, KARNAI	ROUGH COST ESTIMATE FOR THE COMPLETION OF COMMUNITY CENTER (SLAB, CEMENT PLASTER) AT VILLAGE UNISPER BLOCK NILOKHERI DISTT KARNAL + 1 WORKS	22.06.2026 30.06.2026	99.60 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896634422 prexeeng.krl@hry.nic.in
6	KALPANA CHAWLA GOVT MEDICAL COLLEGE KARNAL	REGARDING E-TENDER FOR SUPPLY MEDICINE & CONSUMABLES (CALCIUM GLUCONATE INJECTION 100MG/ML, 10ML, LEVETIRACETAM 500MG JN., HUDROXYPROPYL METHYLCELLULOSE SOLUTION, INJ. PHENOCAINE ETC.) AT KCGMC, KARNAL	26.06.2026 03.07.2026	EMD 10000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896154463 director.kcghc-hry@gov.in
7	KALPANA CHAWLA GOVT MEDICAL COLLEGE KARNAL	REGARDING E-TENDER FOR SUPPLY MEDICINE & CONSUMABLE (CALCIUM ASPARTATE 500MG, CALCIUM OROTATE 500MG, CALCITRIOL 0.25MCG, ZINC 7.5MG, ETORICOXIB 90MG ETC. JAT KCGMC, KARNAL	30.06.2026 07.07.2026	EMD 10000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896154463 director.kcghc-hry@gov.in
8	KALPANA CHAWLA GOVT MEDICAL COLLEGE KARNAL	REGARDING E-TENDER FOR SUPPLY MEDICINE & CONSUMABLE (DISPOSABLE PATCH, COTTON BUDS, EYE SURGICAL BLADE 400 MICRO METER, NYLON 10-0, DISPOSABLE NEEDLE 24 NO. ETC.) AT KCGMC, KARNAL	26.06.2026 03.07.2026	EMD 10000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896154463 director.kcghc-hry@gov.in
9	PANCHAYATI RAJ, ROHTAK	CONST. OF NALA FROM SC BASTI TO MANU WALA POND IN VILLAGE SINGHPURA KALAN + 2 WORKS	23.06.2026 30.06.2026	25.48 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01262254150 prexeeng.roh@hry.nic.in
10	PANCHAYATI RAJ, JHOJHU KALAN	CONSTRUCTION OF ZYM HALL AT VILLAGE NOSWA (SCHEME- VANGY) + 4 WORKS	22.06.2026 01.07.2026	25.54 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9582622008 xenprcharkhidadri@gmail.com
11	PANCHAYATI RAJ, SONIPAT	ESTIMATE FOR SUPPLY INSTALLATION AND DISMENTLING OF STREET LIGHT 2ND PHASE BLOCK MUNDLANA DIST. SONIPAT + 7 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 30.06.2026	79.72 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416391006 prexeeng.snp@gmail.com
12	PANCHAYATI RAJ, NARNJAL	KUNJPURA BLOCK ATELI NANGAL CONSTRUCTION OF 1PB RASTA FROM SHYAMPURA TO SHAPUR DOYAM + 7 WORKS	24.06.2026 01.07.2026	174.86 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8168502876 prexeeng.nrl@gmail.com
13	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, NARNJAL	REMODELING OF GUIDE BUND CUM DRAIN FROM KM. 0.000 TO 5.245 TO PROTECT THE RESIDENTIAL AREA FROM FLOOD WATER IN NARNJAL CONSTITUENCY (CM ANNOUNCEMENT CODE 29223) + 1 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 06.07.2026	80.34 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01282-251214 xencivilnrl@rediffmail.com
14	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, PANCHKULA	DATA AS SERVICE FOR ALREADY EXISTING 90 NO REAL TIME CANAL DATA ACQUISITION SYSTEM INSTALLED AT VARIOUS LOCATIONS FOR A PERIOD OF TWO YEARS.	24.06.2026 14.07.2026	EMD 1.81 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in dsndharyana.gov.in	01722585444 xenprojectpkl@gmail.com
15	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, ROHTAK	BANK CLEARANCE OF LADAIN MINOR FROM RD 0 TO 18630. + 1 WORKS	24.06.2026 30.06.2026	1.68 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01262271675 xenfdrrtk@gmail.com
16	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, SIRSA	INTERNAL CLEARANCE/DEWEEDING AND SILT CLEARANCE OF BHAGSAR MINOR (FLOODY) FROM RD. 0 TO 18750-TAIL OFF-TAKING AT RD. 49800-R GBSM LINK CHANNEL (SADEWA SECTION) FOR KHARIF 2026. + 2 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 01.07.2026	4.22 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9996665761 xensrs.swd1925@yahoo.com
17	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, PANCHKULA	SUPPLY OF HARDWARE ITEMS PERTAINING TO LWS MECH DIVISION CHARKHI DADRI + 4 OTHER WORKS	24.06.2026 08.07.2026	1.04 CRORE	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0172582542 xenproc@gmail.com
18	CIVIL SURGEON, KAITHAL	RDRUGS AND CONSUMABLES	25.06.2026 06.07.2026	EMD 1 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	7988672699 drugstorektd@gmail.com
19	ZILA PARISHAD, FARIDABAD	KHABRA KALAN CONST OF SHC BLOCK BHATTU KALAN DISTRICT FATEHABAD ZP	24.06.2026 30.06.2026	46.86 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01667230855 prexeeng.ftb@hry.nic.in
FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in					RO 46587-I-27-7	



Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot
(Admission Branch)



Baba Farid University of Health Sciences
Sadia Road, Faridkot-151203 Ph: 01639-256232,256236

Admission Notice
B.Sc Allied and Healthcare Sciences Courses-2026

Online applications are invited alongwith requisite fee for admission to Bachelor in Medical Radiology and Imaging Technology (BMRIT), Bachelor of Radiation Therapy Technology (B.RTT) Bachelor of Anesthesia and Operation Theatre Technology (B.AOTT), Bachelor of Optometry (B.Optom), Bachelor of Dialysis Therapy Technology (B.DTT), Bachelor of Audiology and Speech Language Pathology (BASLP), Bachelor of Emergency Medical Technologist (Paramedic), B.Sc. (Intensive Care Unit Techniques), B.Sc. (Orthopedic Assistant & Plaster Techniques), B.Sc. (Cardiac Technology), B.Sc. Neurophysiology Technology), B.Sc. (Perfusion Technology), B.Sc. (Medical Transcription) and B.Sc. (Neuro Electrophysiology) Courses, session-2026 in all the Govt./University constituent/private colleges of Punjab through University website from **26-06-2026 to 16-07-2026**. The schedule of counseling will be intimated later on through University website.
Note:- Any Notification/Corrigendum/Amendment by NCAHP/PSAH/Govt. of Punjab will be followed. For Prospectus/fee details/schedule/online counselling/ Colleges/ Seats/ other details & updates visit us at: **www.bfuhs.ac.in**.

Sd/-
REGISTRAR

3108/12/2026-27/12677 Dated CHD :- 24/06/2026

MODI INDUSTRIES LIMITED
CIN - U15429UP1932PLC000469
Regd. Office: Modinagar - 201204. (U.P.)
Tel: 01232-243115, 9084786567
Email: modindustrieslimited@gmail.com
Website: www.modindustries.net

LOSS OF DOCUMENTS
TO WHOM SOEVER IT MAY CONCERN
It is hereby informed that original Declaration Deed dated 29.11.1951 executed by Shri Gujar Mal Modi and its record that the property i.e. 7, Raj Niwas Marg, New Delhi 110054 was purchased by and belonged to Modi Sugar Mills Limited (now known as Modi Industries Limited) is lost. The said Declaration Deed was registered at Sub Registrar Meerut as Book No. 1, Volume No. 52, Folio Book No. 59, pages No. 69 to 74 as document No. 356 registered on 30.11.1951. The use of the original Declaration Deed by any person and/or entity shall be illegal. The owner (i.e. Modi Industries Limited) have already registered a Police Complaint in this regard and are in process for obtaining a certified copy of the said document.

Modi Industries Limited
Date: 24th June, 2026



GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER,
PWD (ROADS), CACHAR CIRCLE, SILCHAR

No:- T/CC/ETN/SIL/2026-27/391(T)
PRESS NOTICE INVITING RE-TENDER (e-Procurement)
The Superintending Engineer, PWD (Roads) Cachar Circle, Silchar on behalf of Governor of Assam, re-invites bids against this office earlier press notice no. T/CC/ETN/SIL/2025-26/231(T), Dtd. Silchar, the 29th May/2026 for 1(One) No. of package for Construction of Roads under Mukhya Mantrir Nagariya Pakipath Nirman Achanii (MMNPPNA) under SOPD-G for the year 2025-26, within Cachar District of Assam (under Silchar LAC) amounting to approximately Rs. Rs. 131.52 Lakhs (Rupees One Crore Thirty One Lakh Fifty Two Thousand) only including GST etc. within the jurisdiction of P.W.R.D. Silchar and UdhARBond Territorial Road Division, Silchar from approved and eligible contractors registered with Public Works Department (Roads), Assam.
Details may be seen at website www.assamtenders.gov.in and also in the office of the undersigned during office hours from 29/06/2026, 10:00 hours onwards. Amendment/Addendum to the SBD, if any, and further notifications shall appear in this website and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. The contractor/bidder must be registered with the Electronic Tendering System (ETS) of PWRD, Assam website www.assamtenders.gov.in.
Note:- N.I.T. Value is inclusive of GST (12%), Labour cess(1%) etc.
Sd/-
Superintending Engineer, PWD, (Roads)
DIPR/C/PIO/106/26-Jun-26
Cachar Circle, Silchar.

ARMY PUBLIC SCHOOL, SRINAGAR
BB, CANTT., BATWARA (J&K)- 190004
Website: www.apssrinagar.co.in

TENDER NOTICE

1. Chairman APS, Srinagar invites sealed quotations from experienced vendors for supplying of Stationery and other items to APS, Srinagar.

2. Interested parties may visit the school during all working hours from 09 a.m to 03 p.m. to collect the list of stationery & other items required to school before quoting his final rates. The same is also uploaded on the school website. **Please submit your quotations by or before 04 Jul 2026. For any query contact during all working days between 10 a.m. to 03 p.m at 0194-2468224.**

Sd/- Principal

▼ PROSPECT

Project Navbharat inspires students through ‘Know Your Army’ event at Sigar



As part of Project Navbharat, Spearhead Division organised an engaging ‘Know Your Army’ event at Sigar Military Station for students and NCC cadets from Don Bosco School and IGGJ Higher Secondary School. The programme aimed at fostering awareness about the Indian Army, inspiring patriotism among the youth and providing firsthand exposure to the life and ethos of a soldier. More than 100 students, accompanied by their teachers, participated in the event and interacted closely with Army personnel. A key highlight of the programme was an informative briefing on Operation Sindoor, which provided participants with insights into the professionalism, courage and operational capabilities of the Indian Army. The students also witnessed displays of modern weapons, surveillance and drone systems, offering them a glimpse into contemporary military technology and its role in modern warfare. The event further featured live firing demonstrations and a battle obstacle course, enabling participants to experience the challenges, discipline and determination that define military training. The interactive nature of the programme generated immense enthusiasm among the students and encouraged meaningful engagement with the Armed Forces.

Assam prepares for National Immunisation Day on June 28

More than a decade after India was declared polio-free, the country continues to undertake intensive immunisation efforts to protect children from the risk of polio virus transmission and importation. National Immunisation Day (NID) or often referred to as Polio Sunday, remains a key public health initiative to ensure that every child aged zero to five years receives protection through the Oral Polio Vaccine (OPV) in addition to the polio vaccine doses administered during the routine immunisation schedule. As part of the nationwide Pulse Polio Programme this year, the State of Assam along with the rest of the country will also observe the National Immunisation Day (NID) on June 28, with a target of vaccinating approximately 45 lakh children within the age group of zero to five across all the districts. Appealing to the people of Assam, the Minister of Health and Family Welfare Department, Ashok Singhal, has urged all parents to protect their child by giving them two drops of the polio vaccine during the campaign days. The Minister informed that the health department, with active participation of the district commissioners, has made elaborate arrangements in the districts for the successful conduct of the campaign and appealed to all sections of the society to join hands and ensure that every child of zero to five years of age in their localities receives the vaccine for ensuring the continued victory over polio for the state and the country.



Ashok Singhal

DoT notifies new telecom authorisation norms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government has notified rules that operationalise a new authorisation-based framework in the telecom sector, marking a transition from the legacy licensing regime. The Centre has also notified the ‘Telecom eServices Portal’ that enables the digital implementation of the provisions of the Telecom Act.

A set of norms has been notified under the Telecom Act, among them, the Telecommunications (Authorisation for Provision of Main Telecommunication Services) Rules, 2025, that effectively shift entities from the old licence regime to a new authorisation-based framework.

Existing Unified Licence, UASL, ISP, NLD and ILD licensees can migrate to the new regime.

The draft of the rules pertaining to the authorisation-based framework was published on September 5, 2025, inviting objections and suggestions from stakeholders



Jyotiraditya Scindia

within 30 days — a window that was later extended to October 21, 2025.

“...comments and suggestions received in that period in respect of the said draft rules have been considered by the Central Government,” the notification by the Telecom Department said.

The rules allow any eligible entity to apply to the government for authorisation to provide telecom services either as a network service operator, a virtual network operator (VNO), or both.

“Any person may apply to the Central Government under rule 6 to obtain authorisation as a network service operator or virtual network operator or both to provide one or more telecommunication services that are within the scope and service area of any authorisation specified,” it said.

This includes unified service authorisation for a national service area, access service authorisation for one or more service areas, wireline access service authorisation, internet service authorisation for a national service area or one or more service areas, and long-distance service authorisation for a national service area.

Music meets social impact: Sonam Kalra supports HBA Foundation’s drowning prevention initiative

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Sonom Kalra, the world-renowned Sufi singer, demonstrated how powerful influencers can strengthen a cause. While she enthralled the audience at IIC with her Sufi songs, she supported the drowning prevention campaign spearheaded by Hemant Bala Advaita (HBA) Foundation.

It is painful for the family to lose the life of a younger member to drowning, and only parents can know what the pain is about. It never goes away. While stressing the need to create awareness that can prevent drowning, she also urged grieving parents not to weep over their beloved.

“Every soul that has passed remains with us in spirit,” she said. To capture this eternal connection, she beautifully recited the timeless verses of Mary Elizabeth Frye, leaving the audience with its comforting truth: ‘Do not stand at my grave and weep; I am not there, I do not sleep.’”



Among others who were present to strengthen the Drowning Prevention Mission were former Speaker of the Lok Sabha Meira Kumar, India’s Waterman and Raman Magsaysay Award Winner Dr Rajendra Singh, eminent Kathak dancer Shovana Narayan, senior IAS

officer Rashmi Singh, cultural visionary Sangeeta Gupta, strategic and defence expert Major General Karun Kumar Sinha (Retd.), veteran journalist Rakesh Sharma and Founder and Chairman of ANI Prem Prakash.

HBA convenor Santosh Verma stressed the need to create awareness about water safety measures, and he exhorted people to join this mission to multiply the efforts. There is a need for children to know what

Korean delegation visits YEIDA to explore investment opportunities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Korean delegation visited the Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA) on Thursday to explore investment opportunities in the region. The delegation included representatives from the Ministry of Trade, Industry and Resources, Republic of Korea, the Embassy of the Republic of Korea, and the Korea Trade-Investment Promotion Agency (KOTRA).

The delegation comprised Kim Jinsoo, Director, Ministry of Trade, Industry and Resources; Sungjoong Cho, Commercial Counsellor, Embassy of the Republic of Korea; Donghyon Kim, Managing Director, KOTRA South Asia Head Office; and Jaewook (Jake) Lee, Executive Director, India-Korea Business Cooperation Desk, KOTRA.

During the visit, Shaileendra Kumar Bhatia, IAS, Additional Chief Executive Officer, YEIDA, made a presentation



on the investment potential of the YEIDA region. He highlighted the region’s strong connectivity, the operationalisation of the Noida International Airport, and the growing presence of leading investors such as Escorts Kubota, HCL-Foxconn and other prominent companies.

He further stated that investments in the YEIDA region are coming in key sectors and products such as semiconductor chips, electronics manufacturing, medical devices, automobile components and other emerging industrial segments, which have strengthened the region’s industrial and logistics ecosystem.

Bhatia also briefed the delegation about the pro-

posed Korean City in Sector 4A of YEIDA, planned to attract and facilitate Korean investment in the region. He further shared details of the proposed Korean City, spread over approximately 900 acres and having “Multiple Land Use Industry” as its land use, with provisions for industrial, residential, commercial and institutional facilities.

He also highlighted its strong connectivity, including doorstep access to Noida International Airport and proximity to Yamuna Expressway, Eastern Peripheral Expressway and Dedicated Freight Corridors, making it suitable for attracting and facilitating Korean investment in the region.

Institutional investors put in bids worth ₹1,900 cr in IRFC share sale

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Institutional investors on Wednesday put in bids worth over ₹1,900 crore for Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC) shares, over-subscribing the portion reserved for them.

Non-retail investors placed bids for over 21.87 crore IRFC shares, or 1.86 times of the 11.76 crore shares reserved for them. The indicative price for the bids is ₹91.10 per share, stock exchange data showed.

The government is selling up to 2 per cent stake or 26.13 crore shares in IRFC at a floor price of ₹91/share. The OFS includes a greenshoe option of 1 per cent stake.

Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM) Secretary Arunish Chawla said the OFS has received “enthusiastic



response from the investors”. “The Government has decided to exercise the green shoe option. Retail investors and employees get to bid on Thursday, 25th June 2026,” Chawla said.

At the floor price, bids for over 21.87 crore IRFC shares are valued at over ₹1,900 crore.

The floor price of ₹91/share was set at a discount of 7.8 per cent over Tuesday’s closing price of IRFC shares on the BSE.

Shares of IRFC closed 6.24 per cent lower at ₹92.53 on the BSE on Wednesday.

DAILY SUDOKU

3				6		9	
		9		5		3	
	8		4		3		2
		5				1	7
4	3					5	
	2		9		4		5
5			7			4	
4		1					9

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

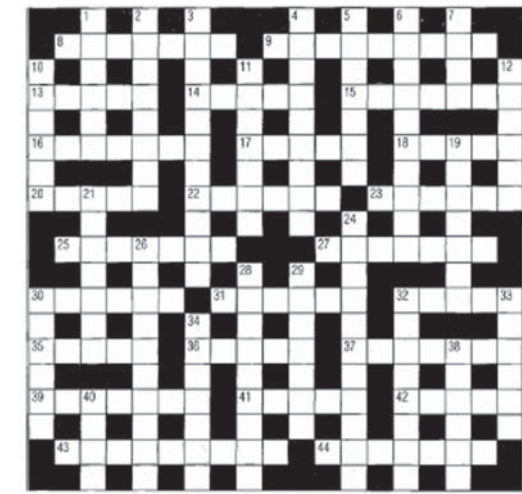
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (25.6.26)								
6	8	3	9	2	1	5	7	4
1	2	4	5	6	7	3	8	9
9	7	5	3	8	4	2	1	6
8	4	9	7	5	2	6	3	1
5	1	6	4	3	8	7	9	2
2	3	7	6	1	9	4	5	8
3	5	2	1	9	6	8	4	7
7	6	1	8	4	5	9	2	3
4	9	8	2	7	3	1	6	5

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
FRIDAY | JUNE 26, 2026



ACROSS

- Put a skirt, mother, on at least! (7)
- Don't allow clutter in and stay well away from (4,5)
- Item of furniture from the inventory (5)
- The cheek is tender (5)
- He performs first in a tear-jerker (7)
- Hemmed in by two vehicles is a large vehicle (7)
- Didn't go on foot with the animals (5)
- The cockney kept her captive in the wood (5)
- Ahead in the first half of the series, which is great (5)
- Wrapped up, as a camper will be (6)
- It's the lucky the master's gone to bed (6)
- Strain to keep from (7)

DOWN

- Shout just before the crashing plane hits the ground? (6)
- Transfer to? Don't be ridiculous! (4,4)
- Harping on, while applying the salve? (7,2,2)
- Loses one's figure but doesn't let that stop one? (4,5)
- Rushed the fish inside and kept it from drying out (7)
- However, strivers after equality want us to be (3,3,4)
- A whole lot of mothers and one son (4)
- Dull, boring people from the backwoods? (6)
- An officer and in command (7)
- Something to hunt with - or hunt for (6)

- The foreigner, I bet, will be put in the shade (7)
- Believe in giving commendation (6)
- Tear when getting something from the tool box (6)
- Send and he'll see how long it takes coming back (5)
- Half the battle is getting it in right (5)
- Volunteer to make the bid (5)
- Re-doing, foolishly took no notice of (7)
- PC 99 has entered "36" (7)
- Music suitable for the children's playground? (5)
- Dig that house! (5)
- The entrance to a day job (9)
- The musician is good - isn't a flop (7)

- Spout about how you waive all rights to? (7)
- Give to, for now (7)
- Well able to engage the enemy? (8,3)
- Caused a great commotion, Adam and Eve did (6,4)
- He claims the chair is his (9)
- Going on using public transport (2,5)
- Not to get caught up with the thread (6)
- Having called Nola back in, go away (3,5)
- I'd moored it outside, as ordered (6)
- Most embarrassed to be worst (7)
- Many split hairs about it being a vegetable (6)
- Supposing you turn up at the party with a dog (4)

Punjab & Sind Bank celebrates its 119th Foundation Day



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Punjab & Sind Bank celebrated its 119th Foundation Day with great enthusiasm and a spirit of public service. On this occasion, the Regional Office, Lucknow, took significant steps towards expanding banking services by inaugurating six new branches and dedicating a newly renovated model branch to the public.

The newly inaugurated branches include Unnao City (Unnao), Vrindavan Colony (Lucknow), Jankipuram Extension (Lucknow), Kamta Chauraha Chinhat (Lucknow), Berwa (Hardoi), and Sandila (Hardoi). In addition, the Vikas Nagar Branch, Lucknow, has been upgraded and dedicated to customers as a modern model branch equipped with enhanced facilities.

As part of the Foundation Day celebrations, a blood donation camp and a free dental health check-up camp were organised at the Vikas Nagar Model Branch

premises. Bank officials, employees, and local residents participated enthusiastically in these initiatives. The blood donation camp reinforced the message of service to society and humanity, while a large number of people benefited from health consultations and dental check-ups.

Addressing the gathering, Rajiv Kumar Bansal, General Manager, said that Punjab & Sind Bank has always remained committed to supporting the weaker and underprivileged sections of society. He stated that the bank's 119th Foundation Day is not only a celebration of its achievements but also a reaffirmation of its commitment to fulfilling its social responsibilities with greater dedication.

On this occasion, Avdhesh Narain Singh, Deputy General Manager & Regional Head, stated that throughout its glorious 119-year journey, Punjab & Sind Bank has consistently progressed on the values of customer trust, excellence in service, and social responsibility.

HUDCO celebrates 12th International Yoga Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Housing and Urban Development Corporation Ltd. (HUDCO) celebrated the 12th International Yoga Day with great enthusiasm across its offices nationwide.

The main event was organised by the Ministry of Ayush in association with the Morarji Desai National Institute of Yoga, Delhi Development Authority (DDA), Aadya Kaushalam Trust, and Samarpan Sewa Trust at Ansal Plaza Park, HUDCO Place, New Delhi.

The programme was graced by Sanjay Kulshrestha, CMD; M Nagaraj, DCP; Daljeet Singh Khatri, Director (Finance); and Vineet Gupta, CVO, who inspired employees through their active participation in the yoga session and

reaffirmed the importance of adopting yoga as a way of life. In line with this year's theme, “Yoga for Healthy Ageing,” employees enthusiastically participated in activities promoting physical fitness, mental well-being, and a balanced lifestyle.

The celebrations extended across all HUDCO regional offices, reflecting the organisation's collective commitment to health and wellness.

Around 500 employees participated in the Yoga Day activities nationwide, underscoring HUDCO's continued focus on fostering a healthy and inclusive workplace culture. Through such initiatives, HUDCO remains dedicated to promoting holistic well-being and encouraging sustainable practices that contribute to the overall wellness of its workforce.



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Shikhar, Plot No. 1, Sector – 29, Gurgaon – 122001		
Requires qualified professionals in following position(s)/discipline(s):		
VC No.	Post	No of Post
RG/30-R1/25	Assistant Manager (HR)	03
RG/02-R1/26	DGM (Civil - Tunnel Construction Expert)	01
RG/03-R1/26	DGM (Transport Economist)	01
RG/18-R2/25	DGM (Civil-Marine Structural Expert)	01
Last date of application		22.07.2026 (Wednesday)
For complete details, candidates may see the detailed advertisement posted on RITES website www.rites.com under Career Section.		

BRIEFLY

Neymar debuts in this WC as sub for Brazil against Scotland



Neymar has finally played in this World Cup, and Brazil has a superstar back in time for knockout rounds. Neymar checked in during the 76th minute against Scotland on Wednesday, with the team leading 3-0 and well on its way to clinching a spot in the knockout stage. Brazil won by that score. His appearance wasn't a surprise: Brazil said earlier this week that he would be available, clearing the way for the forward to make his debut after missing first two matches because of right calf injury. It was his first appearance for Brazil since 2023.

"I'm very happy to be wearing the national team jersey again after three years," he told, following an emotional embrace with his family. "I feel fine physically. It was tough being sidelined for all those days." He did not start, and it seemed like that was plan Brazil coach Carlo Ancelotti had all along when he raised the possibility earlier this week that Neymar could play as substitute.

(AP)

Bosnia-Herzegovina boosts chances with win over Qatar



Ermin Mahmic stripped his jersey off, darted toward the corner of the pitch in front of Bosnia-Herzegovina's fans and pumped his right fist. The 21-year-old Mahmic prompted thousands of the team's supporters at Lumen Field to celebrate Wednesday following his 80th-minute goal against Qatar in a 3-1 victory that boosted Bosnia-Herzegovina's chances of advancing at the World Cup.

Mahmic, who had come on just past the hour mark, received a yellow card for removing his top.

It was worth it. "We knew that the bookings are erased after the group stage," coach Sergej Barbarez said in Bosnian. "I also heard that he shed a tear. I think it was quite emotional for him."

(AP)

Rahimi and Yassine help Morocco to beat Haiti 4-2



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Atlanta

Soufiane Rahimi and Gessime Yassine came off the bench to help Morocco rally for a 4-2 victory over Haiti on Wednesday and erase the Caribbean nation's hopes of a first ever point at the World Cup.

Morocco, which became the first African team to reach the World Cup semifinals four years ago in Qatar, twice came from behind against a team playing on soccer's biggest stage for the first time in 52 years.

Rahimi's deflected shot in the 78th minute put Morocco ahead 3-2 and Yassine killed off any chance of an upset with a goal in the 89th.

Morocco advanced to the round of 32 in second place behind Brazil in Group C and will next play the runner up in Group F - Netherlands, Japan or Sweden - in Monterrey. The five-time champion Brazilians beat Scotland 3-0 in the other group match.

"At times we lacked humility and paid the price for



it," Morocco midfielder Bilal El Khannouss said. "We weren't fully committed in the duels, we gave them confidence and allowed them to grow into the game and score twice. At halftime, the coach told us we needed to be more aggressive, win second balls and bring greater intensity to our attacking play."

Morocco, which won the most recent Africa Cup of Nations, has ambitions to go deep again after making history at the last World Cup. But the team was given a scare by Haiti, which took a surprise lead in the 10th minute with a goal that was more than five decades in the making. Lenny Josphe's back-heeled flick at the near post went in off the back of Morocco goalkeeper Yassine Bounou for the country's first World Cup goal since Emmanuel Sanon in 1974, Haiti's only other appearance at tournament. Bounou was officially credited with an own-goal on the play.

(AP)



England storms into Women's T20 World Cup semifinals at sweltering Lord's

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

Host England was first into the Women's Twenty20 World Cup semifinals with a group match to spare after beating the West Indies by 38 runs at sweltering Lord's on Wednesday.

Both former one-time champions came to the matchup unbeaten, and Danni Wyatt-Hodge batted England out of reach with 65 off 42 balls. Wyatt-Hodge is the tournament's leading run-scorer with 193, averaging 65. The West Indies can still advance if it beats winless Ireland in its last group match on Saturday. On the hottest

June day on record in Britain the evening game started at 35 degrees C and an air temperature of 41 C, and England made an impressive 186-7, the highest women's T20 total at Lord's and the second highest by a men's or women's side.

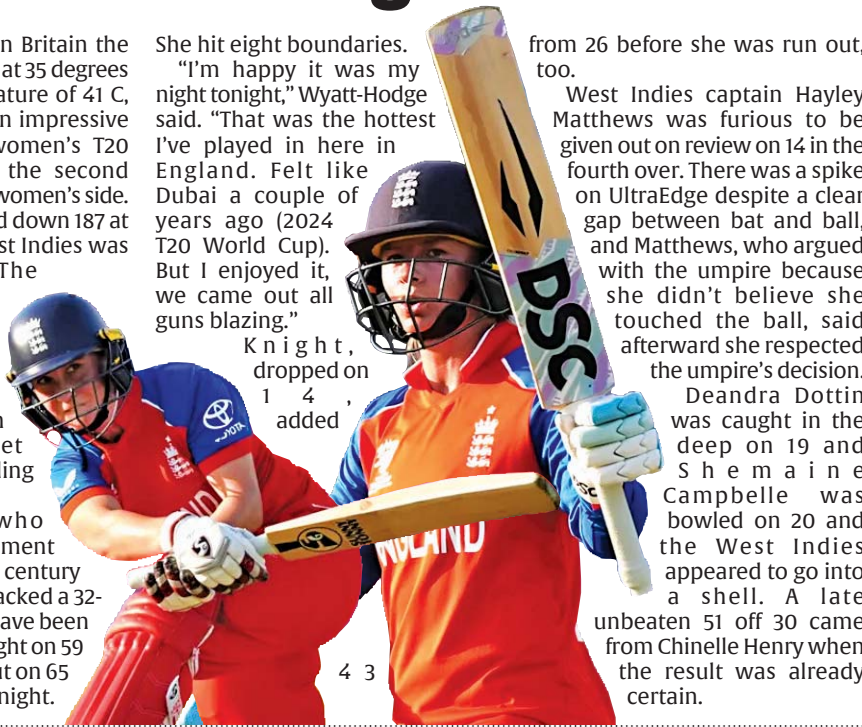
No team has chased down 187 at a World Cup and West Indies was limited to 148-5. The required run rate was at 10 after only two overs and after 69-4 in the 11th over the team appeared to have no interest in attacking the target despite a sloppy fielding effort by England.

Wyatt-Hodge, who launched the tournament two weeks ago with a century against Sri Lanka, smacked a 32-ball fifty. She should have been run out on 58 and caught on 59 and was finally run out on 65 by partner Heather Knight.

She hit eight boundaries.

"I'm happy it was my night tonight," Wyatt-Hodge said. "That was the hottest I've played in here in England. Felt like Dubai a couple of years ago (2024 T20 World Cup). But I enjoyed it, we came out all guns blazing."

Knight, dropped on 14, added



from 26 before she was run out, too.

West Indies captain Hayley Matthews was furious to be given out on review on 14 in the fourth over. There was a spike on UltraEdge despite a clear gap between bat and ball, and Matthews, who argued with the umpire because she didn't believe she touched the ball, said afterward she respected the umpire's decision.

Deandra Dottin was caught in the deep on 19 and Shemaine Campbell was bowled on 20 and the West Indies appeared to go into a shell. A late unbeaten 51 off 30 came from Chinelle Henry when the result was already certain.

Top tennis players to limit media appearances at Wimbledon as protest over prize money continues

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

Top tennis players at Wimbledon will extend their protest over prize money by limiting their media appearances at the grass-court Grand Slam tournament next week.

The decision means the players will only talk to media for 15 minutes after each match during the first week of the tournament.

The protest began at this year's French Open where players complained that the total prize money only made up 14.3 per cent of the clay-court tournament's revenue.

Wimbledon responded by hiking its total prize money by 20 percent this year—with the singles champions to get 3.6 million pounds (\$4.75 million) each.

However, a statement put out Wednesday by an advisory firm representing the players said the "direct action protest" will continue during the first week at the All England Club.

"Players will limit their contractual media commitments at the tournament to 15 minutes — reflecting that Wimbledon currently pays slightly below 15 per cent of revenues to players as prize money—for the duration of the



first week of the Championships," the statement said. "Following detailed consultation with players across both tours, player representatives have written to Wimbledon's leadership to inform them of the planned action, while acknowledging the welcome recent 20% increase in prize money compared to last year's Championships."

The statement said the the players' share of Wimbledon's projected revenues this year is 14.4 per

cent, which would be below the 14.9 per cent share they received 10 years ago.

The players had written a proposal last year asking for 16% of revenues. The statement did not specify which players would take part in the protest.

At the French Open, No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka, Coco Gauff and Iga Swiatek were among the top-10 ranked women who limited their media appearances, as did men's No. 1 Jannik Sinner. However, Novak Djokovic did not take part in the protest.

In announcing Wimbledon's 20-percent increase in prize money two weeks ago, All England Club chair Deborah Jevans said she hoped it would satisfy the players.



Mexico wins all 3 World Cup group-stage matches for 1st time

CARLOS RODRIGUEZ ■ Mexico City

Javier Aguirre has been saying for a while now that the key to the Mexican team's success at the World Cup is that they are a family. This family, it seems, is on a historic journey.

Mateo Chavez and Julian Quinones scored in a six-minute span early in the second half, and Mexico beat the Czech Republic 3-0 on Wednesday to complete wins in all three of its World Cup group-stage matches for the first time.

The 22-year-old Chavez, in his first World Cup, opened the scoring in the 55th minute and Quinones scored his second goal of the tournament in the 61st. Alvaro Fidalgo added a



goal in stoppage time.

"It was something very beautiful, and I'll take it with me to the grave," Chavez said of his goal. "I imagined it many times;

I dreamed of this."

Mexico's previous best group-stage performance was two wins and one draw, done in 1986 and 2002 and both featur-

South Africa reaches World Cup knockout round for 1st time



MAYA KOLUDER-RAMIREZ ■ Guadalupe (Mexico)

South Africa advanced to the knockout phase of the World Cup for the first time with a 1-0 victory over South Korea on Wednesday night.

Thapelo Maseko scored in the 63rd minute off a precise cross from Tshepang Moremi and South Africa finished in second place in Group A behind Mexico, which won all three of its group-stage games.

South Africa will take on Canada, the second-place finisher in Group B, in a knockout game Sunday at Inglewood, California.

Maseko had five total shots in the

match and leads South Africa with eight shots in the tournament.

When Maseko was asked what he would tell his younger self about his accomplishment, the Mamelodi Sundowns forward said: "The one thing I would say is keep dreaming."

South Africa had opened its World Cup with a 2-0 loss to Mexico before using a late goal to earn a 1-1 draw with Czech Republic. It entered its final group-stage needing to defeat South Korea in order to advance. Bafana Bafana had failed to advance from the group stage in 1998, 2002 and as host in 2010.

(AP)

Switzerland wraps up 1st place in Group B

ANNE M PETERSON ■ Vancouver (Canada)

Switzerland put a damper on Canada's World Cup party.

The Swiss got goals from Ruben Vargas and Johan Manzambi to beat Canada 2-1 on Wednesday and win Group B. Switzerland will get a week of rest before returning to Vancouver to face one of the eight best third-place finishers on July 2.

"I think that we deserve to be where we are right now," Switzerland coach Murat Yakin said. "In three days from now, we will know the opponent of the next match, and now we have the possibility to watch this tournament, and to watch the matches, and we will take what we will get."

Canada dropped to second place in the group and will play in the knockout round for the first time in team history. But the Canadians had been hoping for a win or a draw on Wednesday so they would play their round-of-32 match on home soil.



Instead, Canada will travel Inglewood, California, to play Sunday against South Africa, which beat South Korea 1-0 Wednesday night in Monterrey, Mexico, to finish second in Group A.

"We wanted to be here in Vancouver, but we still have a massive opportunity ahead of us to find a way to still electrify the nation, even though it'll be from Los Angeles," Canada coach Jesse Marsch said.

After Manzambi came off the bench and scored two goals in Switzerland's 4-1 victory over Bosnia-Herzegovina on Thursday,

return for Australia's final group-stage clash at Lord's against Harmanpreet Kaur's side.

"I think Pheeb's (Litchfield) is tracking really well and hopefully will be available for the India game," Nitschke was quoted as saying by cricket.com.au.

Litchfield's return could force Australia into a selection rejig, admitted Nitschke.

"And then, that's going to be a really tough call — Pheeb's is likely to come back into that No. 3 position, so then we've got some decisions to make on what the set-up looks like and how to structure up. But obviously someone has come out for her," she said.

in World Cup qualifying against Honduras on Sept. 6, 2013.

The match Wednesday included nods to Mexico's past and future. Gilberto Mora, at 17, became the youngest Mexico player to start in a World Cup. And 40-year-old goalkeeper Guillermo "Memo" Ochoa entered in the 77th minute, joining Argentina's Lionel Messi and Portugal's Cristiano Ronaldo as the only players to appear in six World Cups.

Mora said "it's like a dream come true after everything I've worked for." "Now we have tough opponents ahead," he added. "We're going to keep working to stay on this path. We want to keep advancing because Mexican national team can become champion." (AP)

Shafali powers India to five-wicket win over Bangladesh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Manchester

Shafali Verma bludgeoned the Bangladesh attack with a 34-ball 53 to set up a five-wicket win for India in the Women's T20 World Cup here on Thursday, notwithstanding another poor fielding effort from her team.

India's abysmal fielding in tournament thus far hit a new low as Bangladesh managed to post 136 for eight at Old Trafford. India, who lost to South Africa largely due to their poor fielding, dropped as many as four catches in the powerplay.

The target was very gettable and Shafali provided a flying start to ensure that India got home in 16.5 overs. There was bit of lull in the middle overs before Jemimah Rodrigues (26 off 15 balls) took India close to the finishing line. Having lost to South Africa, India will need to beat Australia on June 28 in their bid to make the semifinals.

Smriti Mandhana fell cheaply but Shafali single-handedly fired India to 63



India's Harmanpreet Kaur, right, during the ICC Women's T20 World Cup cricket match between India and Bangladesh in Manchester, England on Thursday

for one in the powerplay. She punished the spinners and pacers with equal disdain, unleashing the inside out shot on multiple occasions.

She brought her second World Cup fifty off 29 balls in the eighth over, taking India on the cusp of a big win. The

explosive opener was stumped in a rather unusual fashion as she went for a non-existent single after under edging a ball from Nahida Akter in the ninth over, not realising the wicketkeeper had collected the ball and dislodged the stumps. Earlier, all the four dropped



India's Deepti Sharma celebrates taking the catch of Bangladesh's Sobhana Mostary during the ICC Women's T20 World Cup cricket match between India and Bangladesh in Manchester on Thursday

catches were rather straightforward but the fielders made a mess of them. Among the guilty were Nandni Sharma, Yastika Bhatia and Radha Yadav, who had grassed two chances in the loss to South Africa in the previous game. The biggest beneficiary of India's indiscretion

was Juairiya Ferdous, who was dropped thrice by the fifth over. Ferdous did hit some fine boundaries but failed to make the most of the luck that came her way. After being warned twice for running on the pitch, Nandni, who had dropped Ferdous and Sobhana Mostary

off successive balls, took a sharp return catch to get rid of Ferdous. The opener scored 33 off 31 balls. India have been found wanting in all departments in the tournament thus far. The management has been guilty of making too many changes in the pace department, leaving out the likes of Kranti Gaud. On Thursday, Renuka Thakur got her first game of the competition and she struck in her very first over. Opener Dilara Akter (4) went for the pull but could not clear Shree Charani at deep square leg. Charani bowled a brilliant 20th over, picking up two wickets and giving away only three runs.

Unlike her fielding, Radha (3/28) had a better outing with the ball as she removed opposition captain Nigar Sultana (32 off 27 balls) and Mostary (22 off 26 balls) in quick succession. Considering the unusual heat in the UK, spinners have been getting more assistance. India too predominantly stuck to spin in Bangladesh's innings. Besides the dropped catches, India bowled seven wides and three no balls.

India grapples with Sooryavanshi's inclusion; focus on Samson, Kishan, Abhishek vs Ireland



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Belfast

Accommodating teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi in the starting eleven will be the toughest riddle for the team management when India step into a new T20 era under Shreyas Iyer in the first of a two-match series against Ireland here on Friday. There is heightened interest surrounding Sooryavanshi's possible international debut after the 15-year-old's stunning run in the IPL and a marauding 29-ball 94 for India A against Sri Lanka A in a tri-series one-day match at Dambulla.

But according to the popular demand will not be easy for the think tank.

Currently, India's top three are: Sanju Samson, Abhishek Sharma and Ishan Kishan. And their overall and recent T20 records are not easy to ignore. Samson, Abhishek and Kishan



made fifties in the ICC T20 World Cup final win over New Zealand in March, which was also India's last assignment in the shortest format.

If the management wants to include Sooryavanshi, an opener, then one of Samson or Abhishek will have to go down or sit out, and that is a harsh step in the aftermath of a World Cup title win.

The bigwigs can push Samson down to the middle-order, as he has batted at No. 4 and No. 5 in the past.

But those slots will now be taken by skipper Iyer and his deputy Tilak Varma, leaving No. 6 the only open space.

However, it traditionally belongs to an all-rounder and India have multiple choices in Shivam Dube, Washington Sundar, Axar Patel and newcomer Suryansh Shedge.

Placing Samson at No. 6 will force India to enter the field with just five bowlers, and that department already wears a thin look in the absence of Jasprit Bumrah, Mohammad Siraj and Varun Chakravathy. Even otherwise, Samson has excellent numbers at the pole position — 926 from 28 innings with three hundreds and four fifties, striking at 181.93. His strike-rate at Nos 3, 4 and 5 respectively are not particularly confidence-inspiring 121, 129 and 127 respectively.

Strong domestic show will pave my way back to Team India: Avesh Khan

HARDIK SHARMA ■ New Delhi

It's been two years since Avesh Khan was last seen in India colours but the injury-ravaged pacer, who could regularly strike at over 140kph early in his career, remains determined for a comeback, hoping to catch the selectors' attention with strong Ranji Trophy performances this season.

Avesh endured an underwhelming run in the Indian Premier League for Lucknow Super Giants this season.

Currently representing Chambal Ghariyal in the Madhya Pradesh T20 League, the 29-year-old missed the domestic season last year after undergoing a knee surgery following the 2025 IPL. Back to full fitness now, he is keen to play the full domestic season and help his team Madhya Pradesh win the Ranji Trophy.

"Last year, I had surgery after the IPL, so unfortunately I couldn't play the entire domestic season and went straight into the IPL. This year, I am trying to play the full domestic season," Avesh told PTI in an interview.



"I want to play red-ball cricket. I want to win the Ranji Trophy for my team and my goal is to return to the Indian team, and that will only be possible if I perform well in domestic cricket. I need to take wickets and win matches for my team. That is my main objective," he added.

Avesh said he wants to focus on strength and conditioning while carefully managing his

workload to ensure an injury-free domestic season.

"...I will play both white-ball and red-ball cricket, especially Vijay Hazare Trophy and Ranji Trophy. My approach is not to think too far ahead. I just think that when Vijay Hazare comes around, I need to help my team win, make my team champions and become the highest wicket-taker. That is my aim," said the bowler.

Indian skiers Arif Khan, Stanzin Lundup to receive IOC's \$10k grant for Olympians

POONAM MEHRA ■ New Delhi

Skiers Arif Mohammad Khan and Stanzin Lundup will be the first Indian beneficiaries of the International Olympic Committee's \$10,000 grant for Olympians as they had represented the country at this year's Milano-Cortina Winter Games, which would be the starting point for the programme's roll-out.

The grant marks a major shift from over a century old IOC principle of not handing out financial benefits to athletes due to the concept of amateurism enshrined in the Olympic movement.

It is a part of IOC's "Fit for the Future" strategic framework to find "new and complementary ways" to provide support to ath-



letes, who qualify for the Games and steer clear of any doping offences.

IOC President Kirsty Coventry has refused to call it prize money, insisting that it is a support mechanism. The payouts will begin by the end of this year after examining applications through a soon-



to-be-launched mechanism.

The 36-year-old Arif had produced India's best-ever finish in men's slalom by ending 39th in Milano-Cortina. It was 10 notches higher than India's previous best result in the event, set by Kishore Ratna Rai at the 1988 Games in Calgary.

Sitting in my room, sometimes I wondered Is my journey over? Yarraji

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH
■ Bhubaneswar

A painful knee injury brought her to the brink of an emotional collapse last year but having battled through her fears with some hope and lots of resilience, hurdler Jyothi Yarraji is now aiming to turn her previous Asian Games silver into gold this time. The National record-holding 100m hurdler has no qualms admitting that she had fleeting thoughts of her career being possibly over during the one year of knee injury and rehabilitation.

The resolve paid off as she came back to win a gold medal in the National Inter-State Championships here on



Wednesday. In the process, she breached the Asian Games qualifying time of 13.34 seconds set by Athletics Federation of India (AFI) by clocking 12.99 seconds.

"There were a lot of nights when I cried a lot. I suffered many injuries earlier also (before the ACL tear in 2025). While

sitting in my room, sometimes I asked myself 'Is it done? Is this journey over?' she recalled.

"These things also came in my mind. But I kept telling myself that 'it's okay Jyothi, you will do it, you will prove it,'" said an emotional Yarraji after her triumphant return.

Record holder Anushka wants javelin-like status for hammer throw



PHILEM DIPAK SINGH ■ Bhubaneswar

A national record holder at just 18, Uttar Pradesh athlete Anushka Yadav has a simple wish — to make hammer throw match the popularity of javelin which has a massive fan following in the country due to the exploits of two-time Olympic medallist Neeraj Chopra.

Anushka smashed the women's hammer throw national record with an effort of 67.02m on an eventful opening day of the National Inter-State Championships here on Wednesday. She bettered the nine-year-old previous national record of 65.25m set in 2017 by Sarita Singh. "Not many people know hammer throw in India, but everybody knows javelin throw. I want people to know hammer throw just like javelin throw," Anushka, who hails from a farming family at Baleni village in Baghpur district of Uttar Pradesh, said after her feat. "I am looking for a gold in the upcoming Asian Games and hoping to cross the 70m mark in the near future," she said when asked about her target this year.

Anushka made an improvement of more than four metres from her previous personal best of 62.89m, which she came up with on way to winning gold in the National Games last year.

US Open badminton: Tanvi, Srikanth advance



RESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Fullerton (US)

World Junior Championship silver-medallist Tanvi Sharma and the seasoned Kidambi Srikanth began their US Open badminton campaign with comfortable wins at Fullerton.

Tanvi defeated Yvonne Li of Germany 23-21, 21-16 while Devika Sihag, who is the reigning Thailand Masters champion, beat Ines Lucia Castillo of Peru 21-14, 21-14 in the women's singles first round on Wednesday. In the first of the two all-Indian men's clashes, the promising Rounak Chouhan defeated former world junior silver-medallist Sankar Muthusamy 23-21, 21-16.

I would get angry and cry, wondering why I was out of the team: Deepika

ONA PARTHSARATHI
■ New Delhi

Star drag-flicker Deepika Sehrawat says the toughest challenge of her career was not scoring goals but coping with months away from hockey after a serious hamstring injury, a period that left her frustrated, emotional and questioning when she would return to the field.

Now, after playing a pivotal role in India's title-winning FIH Nations Cup campaign in New Zealand, the 22-year-old feels she has rediscovered both her confidence and rhythm at a crucial time, with the World Cup and Asian Games on the horizon.

Deepika, who missed last year's Asia Cup after suffering a Grade III hamstring tear, made an impressive return by finishing as the joint highest scorer at the Nations



Cup with six goals, alongside American Ashley Sessa.

"Nations Cup was my first tournament after rehab and regaining full fitness. It had been a long time since I had played at this level, so I was a little nervous in the beginning. But it turned out to be

a good tournament and this performance has given me a lot of confidence after returning from injury," Deepika told PTI Bhasha in an interview.

The prolific forward admitted that the months spent on the sidelines tested her mentally as much as physically.

Para-athletes Pranav, Ajeet get TOPS funding for ahead of Asiad



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Sports Ministry's Mission Olympic Cell (MOC) has approved lengthy overseas training stints for Paralympic silver-winning duo of javelin thrower Ajeet Singh and club thrower Pranav Soorma at a total cost of ₹35.46 lakh to enhance their preparations for this year's Asian Para-Games in Japan. The 32-year-old Ajeet has left for international training at Offenburger in



Germany till September 16, while Pranav has flown out for a training stint in Czechia till August 15.

Both of them are a part of the government's flagship Target Olympic Podium Scheme's (TOPS) core group. Pranav, who became wheelchair-bound after a spinal injury caused by an accident at home, had won a gold at the previous Asian para Games and is currently ranked world number one in his classification of F51.